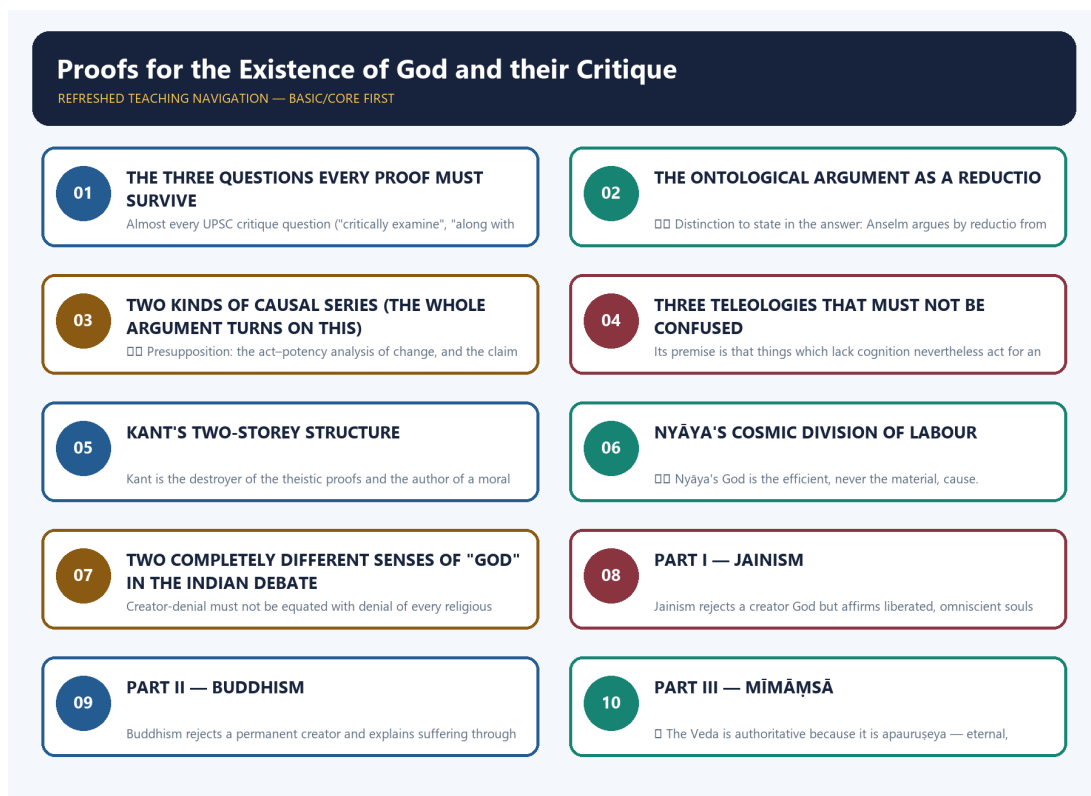


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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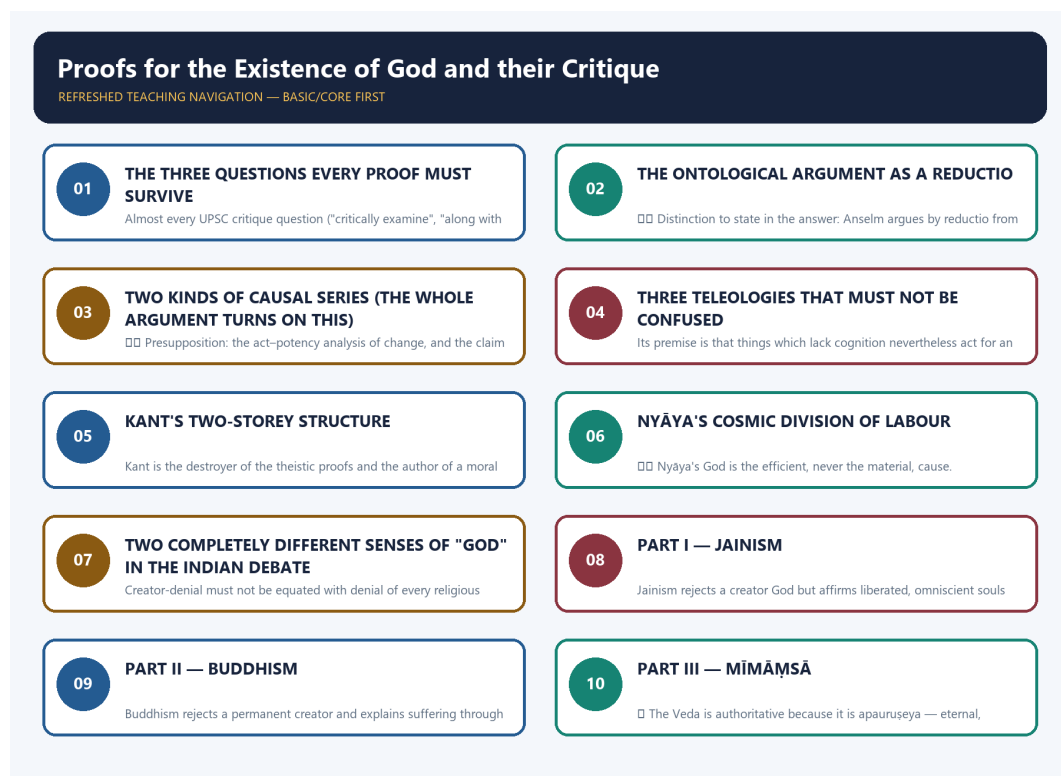
Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · philosophy-paper-ii-philosophy-of-religion-02 **Generation:** g2, 21 August 2026 · **Approval:** pending explicit topic approval **Evidence discipline:** exact proof attributions and PYQ wording/year/marks are controlled by repository owners. Model answers are pedagogic, never official UPSC keys.

Package practice counts

Component	Count
Direct verified topic-owned PYQs	12
Core diagnostic MCQs	32
Remedial diagnostic MCQs	8
Total diagnostics	40
Retained original solved Mains models	6 (2 × 10, 2 × 15, 2 × 20)
Approval	false

BASIC LEARNING SESSION



Refreshed teaching navigation

Distinct embedded teaching-navigation image. The separate continuous Cārvāka-style flowchart package remains an independent at-a-glance artifact.

Source-complete coverage ledger and learning labels

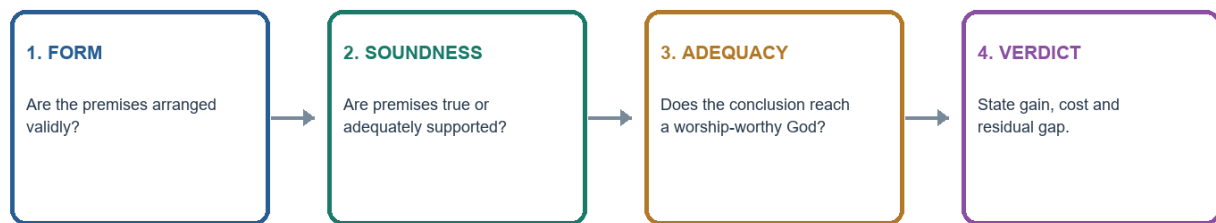
[FACT] marks retained repository doctrine/question data. **[INFERENCE]** marks the learner-facing organisation and graded verdict. This ledger maps source units to the final location rather than merely asserting reconciliation.

Source corpus and unit	Final location	Retention decision
Canonical 0-4: proof map; Western/Indian proofs; a priori/a posteriori; statement bank	Basic modules 1-5 and comparative synthesis	Full doctrine/terminology retained in visual-first sequence
Canonical 5-6: applications, parity bench, PYQ skeletons	Basic answer workshops; Practice full models	Preserved once in full premium form rather than duplicated skeleton/model pairs
Canonical 8.1-8.8: advanced proof dossiers	Optional Advanced	Full owner block retained after practice
Canonical 9-18: debates, critiques, traps, keyword bank, routing and directive/verdict discipline	Basic comparison/answer workshops; Optional Advanced; final register	Preserved in the section where it performs a distinct learning role
Complete session: roadmap, six proof modules, visual maps, objection/reply ladders, comparison grids, revision aids and workshop	Basic Learning Session	Retained in original pedagogic order; only interleaved old MCQs/current anchors and explicitly advanced cards moved
Complete session: advanced-refinement cards	Optional Advanced	Moved intact after practice, as learner-v2 requires
Premium workbook: 12 verified PYQs, 32 core diagnostics, 8 remediation items, answer protocol and revision matrix	MCQs and Practice	Full verified answers and all diagnostic explanations retained
Premium originals	Practice	Six solved models retained because they add non-duplicate coverage; four overlapping prompts omitted
Philosophy of Religion dossier Topic 2	Optional Advanced	Retained in full after core practice

Visible answer-worthiness labels. Proof structures, named proponents, school-specific arguments and core critiques are **CORE PAPER II**. Premise testing, objection/reply, comparison and directive-specific judgment are **CORE ANSWER**. Historical supplements and extra illustrations are **SUPPORTING**. Modal, PSR, Bayesian, anthropic and meta-epistemic depth is **OPTIONAL ADVANCED**.

What to do with the material. Memorise each proof's shortest premise chain and its named critic. Understand what the proof does-and does not-establish. Use one carefully chosen comparison or reply selectively. Reserve modal, probabilistic and specialist meta-level debates for a high-value 15/20-marker.

HOW TO EVALUATE A PROOF: DO NOT JUMP FROM A CAUSE TO THE GOD OF RELIGION



Use this ladder for Anselm, Aquinas, Paley, Kant, Nyāya/Udayana and their critics. A successful proof may establish less than classical theism.

Proof evaluation ladder

Learning route - [CORE PAPER II]

The retained source sequence moves from what counts as a proof, through Western and Indian argument families, to comparison and answer construction. Notions of God, evil, experience, faith and language appear only as bounded links or targets of a premise; they are not silently absorbed into this topic.

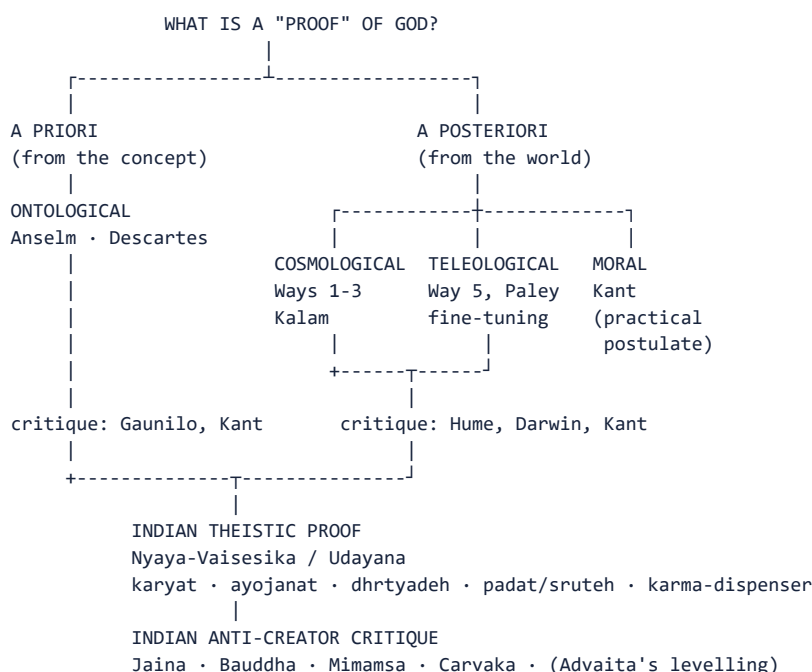
UPSC Philosophy Optional · Paper II · Section B · Philosophy of Religion · Syllabus item 2

Date of session: 10 August 2026 · Progress: 0/8 · Estimated effort: 7-9 sittings

Evidence key used throughout: FACT: canonical doctrine directly grounded in the authored knowledge file or a local source text · ANALYSIS: analytical synthesis / inference for exam use · CAUTION: contested or textually variable · CURRENT: dated contemporary anchor only, never authority.

Roadmap

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: The topic moves from classifying proof-families to reconstructing their premises, testing objections and grading what concept of God, if any, the inference establishes.



Session	Subtopic	Core focus
1	Architecture of theistic proof	Demonstration vs probable inference vs postulate; a priori/a posteriori; validity-soundness-adequacy
2	Ontological argument	Anselm's two forms, Descartes, Gaunilo, Kant, modal repair
3	Cosmological argument	Aquinas' Ways 1-3, essentially ordered series, Kalām, Hume and Kant
4	Teleological argument	Way 4 and Way 5, Paley, Hume's five-front critique, Darwin, fine-tuning
5	Moral argument	Kant's demolition and reinstatement; postulates; Newman; Euthyphro
6	Nyāya-Udayana theism	<i>Kāryāt, āyojanāt, dhṛtyādeḥ, padāt/śruteḥ</i> , karma-dispenser, efficient-cause thesis
7	Indian anti-theistic critique	Jaina proofs and refutation; Buddhist anti-creator arguments; Mīmāṃsā <i>apauruṣeya</i> ; Cārvāka
8	Comparative synthesis	India-West matrix, graded verdicts, 10/15/20-mark architecture

PYQ priority: FACT: Very high - **12 topic-owned question-parts across 2018-2025**, spanning ontological (2018, 2020, 2024), Aquinas (2018, 2022), Nyāya (2018, 2023, 2025), design-Hume (2025), moral (2021), Jaina (2019), Buddhist (2018) and the a priori/a posteriori distinction (2022).

MEMORY: Master mnemonic - "O-C-T-M + N, then J-B-M": Ontological, Cosmological, Teleological, Moral, plus Nyāya; critiqued by Jaina, Bauddha, Mīmāṃsā.

Progress: 1 / 8 | Stage: Foundation | Subtopic: The Architecture of Theistic Proof

--- PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST ---

BOOK: Book context: Authored Markdown paper - 2/philosophy-of-religion/Proofs-for-God.md §0, §3, §11 read in full; local OCR-searchable John Hick, *Philosophy of Religion*, Chapter 2 ("Arguments for the Existence of God", pp. 15-29 of the print pagination) confirmed searchable and consulted.

SEARCH: CA Search: "cosmological, teleological and fine-tuning arguments for God's existence - scholarly debate 2025-2026"

CURRENT: CA Found: CURRENT: A 2026 paper, *"The Rational Defence of God's Existence: Exploring Cosmological..."*, and a 2025 review, *"A Discourse On God's Existence: Cosmological And Teleological Proofs"*, both continue the cosmology/fine-tuning debate. **Use only as a dated contemporary-debate anchor. It is not proof, and not canonical authority.**

SESSION 1 - THE THREE QUESTIONS EVERY PROOF MUST SURVIVE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Every proof must be tested for validity, soundness and adequacy: whether the conclusion follows, the premises are true and the being reached is genuinely God.

Technical definition: Almost every UPSC critique question ("critically examine", "along with its criticism") is answered by locating the objection on one of these three tiers instead of shouting a general "the proof fails".

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Every proof must be tested for validity, soundness and adequacy: whether the conclusion follows, the premises are true and the being reached is genuinely God.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Core argument
- Demonstration
- Probable / explanatory inference
- Practical postulate
- A priori
- A posteriori

How to use them: Use Core argument to define the issue, connect Demonstration with Probable / explanatory inference to explain it, and use Practical postulate to distinguish or qualify the conclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Core argument: Every proof must be tested for validity, soundness and adequacy: whether the conclusion follows, the premises are true and the being reached is genuinely God.

PROOF FOR GOD

(1) VALIDITY Does the conclusion follow from the premises as stated?	
+-----	
(2) SOUNDNESS Are the premises actually true (causal principle, PSR, analogy)?	
+-----	
(3) ADEQUACY Is the being reached actually GOD - infinite, one, personal, good?	
+-----	

A proof can be VALID, yet UNSOUND;
valid AND sound, yet still INADEQUATE to classical theism.

ANALYSIS: This three-tier grid is the single most examiner-pleasing device in the whole topic. Almost every UPSC critique question ("critically examine", "along with its criticism") is answered by locating the objection on one of these three tiers instead of shouting a general "the proof fails".

1. What counts as a "proof" here?

FACT: Three logically different things are all loosely called "proofs" in this syllabus item:

Type	Claim made	Standard example	If it fails, it fails as...
Demonstration	The conclusion follows necessarily; denial is contradictory	Anselm's ontological argument	invalid or question-begging
Probable / explanatory inference	God is the best or a required explanation of some feature of the world	Aquinas' Ways, Paley, Nyāya <i>kāryāt</i>	weak analogy, available rival explanation
Practical postulate	Belief is rationally required by the moral standpoint, not by theoretical proof	Kant's moral argument	a projection, or not binding on the sceptic

ANALYSIS: Never write "Kant proves God through morality." Kant explicitly *denies* theoretical proof; he postulates. This single sentence has sunk many otherwise good scripts.

2. A priori and a posteriori - the 2022 distinction

Axis	A priori	A posteriori
Starting point	FACT: The concept of God alone	FACT: Some fact of the world (motion, causation, contingency, order, moral experience)
Method	Conceptual analysis; denial produces contradiction	Inference from effect to cause; inference to best explanation
Standard instance	Ontological (Anselm, Descartes)	Cosmological, teleological, moral, Nyāya <i>Īśvara-anumāna</i>
Modality of conclusion	FACT: Necessary being, if it works at all	ANALYSIS: At best a probable, and often finite, cause
Independence from science	Total - no empirical premise	ANALYSIS: Exposed to Darwin, Big-Bang cosmology, multiverse models
Characteristic defeat	FACT: Kant: "existence is not a real predicate"	FACT: Hume: analogy is weak; effect underdetermines cause
Religious payoff	Reaches necessity but not obviously a personal God	Reaches an agent-like cause but not obviously an infinite one

MEMORY: Mnemonic - "CONCEPT versus COSMOS": a priori argues from the *concept*, a posteriori from the *cosmos*.

ANALYSIS: The 2022 examiner asks which should be preferred. The strongest answer is a graded one: a posteriori arguments are epistemically more respectable because they begin from something granted by the opponent, but they pay for it by reaching only a finite, probable cause; the a priori argument alone promises necessity, but it purchases that necessity by an inference that Kant showed to be illegitimate. Preference therefore depends on the criterion - **evidential contact** favours a posteriori, **modal strength** favours a priori, and **religious adequacy** is achieved by neither alone.

3. The five families in one frame

Family	Premise drawn from	Terminus reached	Chief critic
Ontological	FACT: Concept of a maximally great being	Necessarily existing being	Gaunilo; Kant
Cosmological	FACT: Motion, efficient causation, contingency	Unmoved mover / first cause / necessary being	Hume; Kant
Teleological	FACT: Order, adaptation, fine order	Intelligent designer	Hume; Darwin
Moral	FACT: The moral law and the highest good	God as practical postulate	Naturalist axiology; Euthyphro
Nyāya inference	FACT: The world as <i>kārya</i> (composite effect)	Omniscient intelligent efficient cause (Īśvara)	Mīmāṃsā; Buddhism; Jainism; Cārvāka

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The syllabus phrase is "*Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique (Indian and Western)*". The examiner is therefore testing four capacities at once:

RECONSTRUCT -> the argument as numbered premises, not as a slogan
 EXPOSE -> the hidden presupposition that carries the weight
 OBJECT/REPLY -> the strongest critic, and the proponent's best answer
 GRADE -> how far it succeeds, and what kind of God it delivers

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not treat "proof" univocally: demonstration, probable inference and practical postulate have different success conditions.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not say the ontological argument is a posteriori because Anselm "observes" that people have the idea of God - the *premise* is conceptual.

3. ANALYSIS: Do not equate "a priori" with "certain" and "a posteriori" with "uncertain"; a priori reasoning can be invalid, and a posteriori reasoning can be strong.
4. ANALYSIS: Distinguish **validity** from **soundness** from **adequacy of the God established**. Most critiques attack the second and third, not the first.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not present the Indian material as a decorative appendix; Nyāya is a fully-formed *a posteriori* natural theology and belongs inside the taxonomy.
6. ANALYSIS: A proof's failure does not establish atheism; it establishes only that *that route* does not compel.

Revision notes

- Theistic proofs divide into a priori (conceptual) and a posteriori (world-based) routes.
- Ontological is the only classical a priori proof; cosmological, teleological, moral and Nyāya are a posteriori.
- Assess every proof on three tiers: validity, soundness, adequacy of the God reached.
- Demonstration claims necessity; explanatory inference claims probability; postulation claims practical rationality.
- Kant's moral argument is a postulate, never a theoretical demonstration.
- A posteriori proofs begin from conceded facts but reach only a finite, probable cause.
- The a priori proof promises necessity but is charged with the existence-predicate fallacy.
- 2022 asked exactly this distinction plus a reasoned preference - answer with a criterion-based, graded verdict.
- Nyāya's *Īśvara-anumāna* is a cosmological-teleological hybrid, not a separate exotic species.
- No single proof reaches the full God of developed religion; cumulative-case strategies attempt to repair this.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - THE THREE QUESTIONS EVERY PROOF MUST SURVIVE

START / CONCEPT: THE THREE QUESTIONS EVERY PROOF MUST SURVIVE

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Core argument · Demonstration · Probable / explanatory inference · Practical postulate
· A priori · A posteriori

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Almost every UPSC critique question ("critically examine", "along with its criticism") is answered by locating the objection on one of these three tiers instead of shouting a general "the proof fails".

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: ANALYSIS: Do not treat "proof" univocally: demonstration, probable inference and practical postulate have different success conditions. ANALYSIS: Do not say the ontological argument is a posteriori because Anselm "observes" that people have the idea of God - the premise is conceptual. ANALYSIS: Do not equate "a priori" with "certain" and "a posteriori" with "uncertain"; a priori reasoning can be invalid, and a posteriori reasoning can be strong. ANALYSIS: Distinguish validity from soundness from adequacy of the God established.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: The a priori proof promises necessity but is charged with the existence-predicate fallacy.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Every proof must be tested for validity, soundness and adequacy: whether the conclusion follows, the premises are true and the being reached is genuinely God.

SESSION 2 - THE ONTOLOGICAL ARGUMENT AS A REDUCTIO

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The ontological argument is an a priori attempt to derive God's necessary existence from the concept of the greatest conceivable being.

Technical definition: ANALYSIS: Distinction to state in the answer: Anselm argues by reductio from a comparative ("greater than"); Descartes argues from essence containment ("existence is a perfection").

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The ontological argument is an a priori attempt to derive God's necessary existence from the concept of the greatest conceivable being.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The Ontological Argument As A Reductio
- Recommended opening definition
- more perfect
- Crucial textual point
- First form - Proslogion 2
- Second form - Proslogion 3

How to use them: Use The Ontological Argument As A Reductio to define the issue, connect Recommended opening definition with more perfect to explain it, and use Crucial textual point to distinguish or qualify the conclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening definition: The ontological argument is an a priori attempt to derive God's necessary existence from the concept of the greatest conceivable being.

```

ASSUME (for reductio):  God exists in the understanding ALONE
|
|   Premise A: God =def "that than which nothing greater
|               can be conceived"  (aliquid quo nihil maius cogitari possit)
|
|   Premise B: To exist in reality is greater than
|               to exist in the understanding alone
|
▼
THEN a greater than God can be conceived
     (namely, the same being existing in reality too)
▼
BUT that contradicts Premise A - "the greatest conceivable"
     cannot be exceeded by anything conceivable
▼
THE ASSUMPTION IS FALSE.  God exists in reality.          [Proslogion 2]
▼
SECOND FORM: a being that CANNOT be thought not to exist
              is greater than one that can.
              God exists NECESSARILY (aseity, self-existence).  [Proslogion 3]

```

ANALYSIS: The second form is the philosophically serious one. It shifts the claim from *existence* to *necessary existence*, and it is the form Anselm uses to answer Gaunilo.

1. Anselm's definition - and why its wording matters

FACT: Anselm compresses the monotheistic concept of God into the formula **"a being than which nothing greater can be conceived."** "Greater" here means **more perfect**, not spatially larger.

FACT: Crucial textual point: Anselm deliberately does *not* say "the most perfect being that there is". That description would be trivially satisfied by whatever happens to be the best existing thing, with no guarantee that it is God. He says "so perfect that no more perfect can even be *conceived*". The argument is built on the second, stronger notion.

FACT: Anselm addresses the Psalmist's "fool" who says in his heart, "There is no God." Even the fool, says Anselm, possesses the concept; and when the concept is unpacked, the fool is refuted out of his own understanding.

2. The two forms, side by side

	First form - Proslogion 2	Second form - Proslogion 3
Conclusion	God exists in reality as well as in the mind	God exists <i>necessarily</i> ; God's non-existence is inconceivable
Key comparative	Existing in reality > existing in the mind alone	Being unable to be thought not to exist > being able to be so thought
Core notion	Existence	FACT: Necessary being / aseity (self-existence)

	First form - Proslogion 2	Second form - Proslogion 3
Vulnerable to	Gaunilo's island parody; Kant's predicate objection	ANALYSIS: The charge that "necessary existence" is itself an incoherent or unestablished notion
Modern descendants	-	FACT: Malcolm, Hartshorne, Plantinga's modal versions

FACT: Because God as infinitely perfect is not limited in or by time, the two possibilities of God's ever *coming to be* or ever *ceasing to be* are alike excluded; God's non-existence is thereby rendered impossible.

3. Descartes' reformulation

FACT: Descartes (*Meditations* V) recasts the argument through his doctrine of clear and distinct ideas: existence belongs to the essence of a supremely perfect being as necessarily as having three angles summing to two right angles belongs to the essence of a triangle, or as a valley belongs to the idea of a mountain. A supremely perfect being that lacked existence would lack a perfection, which is a contradiction in terms.

ANALYSIS: **Distinction to state in the answer:** Anselm argues by *reductio* from a comparative ("greater than"); Descartes argues from *essence containment* ("existence is a perfection"). Both are a priori, but their machinery differs, and Kant's objection strikes Descartes' version most directly.

ANALYSIS: Descartes elsewhere offers a *different*, causal proof of God (from the idea of the infinite in a finite mind, *Meditations* III). Do not fuse the two; the causal one is not ontological.

4. Objection 1 - Gaunilo's lost island

FACT: **Gaunilo**, a monk of Marmoutiers and Anselm's contemporary, replied in a tract titled *In Behalf of the Fool*. He argued that Anselm's reasoning would generate absurd conclusions elsewhere, and constructed a parallel argument for the most perfect island: given the idea of such an island, Anselm's principle would force us to conclude that it exists, since otherwise it would not be the most perfect conceivable island.

ANALYSIS: **Precision point rarely made in scripts:** Gaunilo actually spoke of the most perfect *of* islands rather than, as he should have, the most perfect *conceivable* island. Making that correction strengthens the parody, and stating the correction shows the examiner that you have read the debate rather than a summary of it.

FACT: **Anselm's reply** rests on the second form. The element present in the concept of God and absent from the concept of any island is **necessary existence**. An island - "a piece of land surrounded by water" - is by definition part of the contingent physical world, a dependent reality that can without contradiction be thought not to exist. Anselm's principle therefore does not apply to it. It applies only to a being defined as having eternal and independent existence.

ANALYSIS: **Residual pressure:** the reply protects the second form but leaves the first form exposed, and it transfers the entire burden to a further question - *is the idea of a maximally great being coherent at all?* If "most perfect conceivable island" is incoherent (because island-perfections have no intrinsic maximum), the parody fails; but the theist must then show that maximal greatness *does* have an intrinsic maximum.

5. Objection 2 - Kant: existence is not a real predicate

FACT: **Kant's objection** is the decisive one in the tradition: **"existence is not a real predicate."** A real (determining) predicate adds something to the concept of a subject. Existence adds nothing to a concept; it *posits* the concept's object. Kant's illustration: a hundred real thalers contain not one coin more than a hundred possible thalers; the concept is identical, only my financial position differs.

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta make the same point in the Indian textbook tradition, and put it in an idiom worth borrowing: *the idea of one hundred rupees in my pocket involves the image or the idea of their existence, but not their real physical existence*. To think of the existence of something is not to prove its existence.

ANALYSIS: **Therefore:** you cannot define anything into existence. From an analysis of a concept only conditional propositions follow - *if* such a being exists, it exists necessarily - and the antecedent is exactly what was to be proved.

6. Objection 3 - the modern logical objection

ANALYSIS: On the standard post-Fregean analysis, "exists" is not a first-order property of individuals but a second-order quantificational notion: to say tigers exist is to say the concept *tiger* is instantiated. If that is right, "existence" cannot appear in the list of perfections at all, and the argument cannot even be stated in its classical form.

7. The reply - modal ontological arguments

ANALYSIS: Twentieth-century defenders (Malcolm, Hartshorne, and in the most discussed form Plantinga) work exclusively with Anselm's second form and with *necessary* existence, which they claim is not vulnerable to Kant's objection because it is a modal status rather than a bare existence-predicate. The skeleton is:

1. It is POSSIBLE that a maximally great being exists.
2. A maximally great being is one that exists necessarily and is maximally excellent in every possible world.
3. If it is possible that such a being exists, then it exists in some possible world.
4. Whatever exists necessarily in some possible world exists in every possible world.
5. A maximally great being exists - in the actual world.

ANALYSIS: **The burden simply migrates.** The whole weight now rests on premise 1 - the **possibility premise**. A parallel "it is possible that no maximally great being exists" yields, by the same modal logic, the opposite conclusion. So the modal version does not prove God; it converts the dispute into a dispute about whether maximal greatness is genuinely possible, i.e. coherent. FACT: This is precisely the point the authored knowledge file records: *"Possibility premise bears the burden."*

8. Does the concept of God entail the existence of God? - the 2018 formulation

FACT: **2018, Q6(c), 15 marks:** *"Does the concept of God entail the existence of God? Examine from the perspective of ontological argument."*

ANALYSIS: **Model verdict:** the concept of God **entails** existence conceptually - i.e. it is analytic that God, if God exists, exists necessarily and not contingently - but conceptual entailment does not deliver **instantiation**. The argument proves at most a conditional: if the concept of a maximally great being is coherent and instantiable, then it is instantiated necessarily. What it cannot do is establish the antecedent by conceptual means alone. Hence: **entailment within the concept, yes; entailment to reality, no.**

9. Is there an Indian ontological argument?

ANALYSIS: There is **no exact classical Indian analogue** of the ontological argument. This is itself an examinable observation, and the reason is structural:

Feature of Indian epistemology	Consequence for an a priori proof
FACT: Nyāya recognises <i>pratyakṣa</i> , <i>anumāna</i> , <i>upamāna</i> , <i>śabda</i> - all of which are contentful, world-involving <i>pramāṇas</i>	An argument with no empirical premise has no recognised evidential source
FACT: Nyāya inference requires <i>vyāpti</i> (invariable concomitance) established by observed co-presence	Pure conceptual analysis cannot generate <i>vyāpti</i>
FACT: Advaita reaches Brahman through <i>śruti</i> plus <i>anubhava</i> , not through concept-analysis	Brahman is not established by definition but disclosed
ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā treats the Veda as intrinsically valid and authorless	No conceptual route to a divine being is needed or offered

ANALYSIS: **Safe comparative sentence:** *"Indian natural theology is overwhelmingly a posteriori and inferential; the ontological route has no classical Indian counterpart because Indian epistemology grounds existence-claims in *pramāṇas* that are world-involving."*

India-West comparison

	Ontological (West)	Nyāya inference (India)
Type	FACT: A priori, conceptual	FACT: A posteriori, inferential
Starting point	Concept of maximal greatness	The world as composite effect (<i>kārya</i>)
Conclusion's modality	Necessary existence	ANALYSIS: Probable existence of an intelligent agent
Characteristic objection	Existence is not a real predicate	Weak world-artefact analogy; karma may suffice

	Ontological (West)	Nyāya inference (India)
Divine attributes reached	Maximal perfection by definition	Omniscience, eternality, agency - argued for stepwise

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present only *Proslogion* 2 and omit the second form; Anselm's reply to Gaunilo *requires* the second form.
2. ANALYSIS: Gaunilo is not Kant. Gaunilo offers a **parody** (the form proves too much); Kant offers a **diagnosis** (the form uses "existence" illegitimately).
3. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute the island example to Kant, or the thaler example to Gaunilo.
4. ANALYSIS: Descartes' ontological proof (*Meditations* V) must not be confused with his causal proof from the idea of the infinite (*Meditations* III).
5. ANALYSIS: The modal version does not defeat Kant "cleanly"; it relocates the problem to the possibility premise.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not say the ontological argument is "obviously absurd". It is the argument that has attracted the most sustained modern logical attention of all the proofs.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not manufacture an "Indian ontological argument" out of Advaita. Brahman is not established by conceptual analysis.

MEMORY: **Mnemonic - "A-D-G-K-M"**: Anselm defines, Descartes essentialises, Gaunilo parodies, Kant diagnoses, Modal logic repairs (and re-buries the burden).

Revision notes

- Anselm defines God as that than which nothing greater can be conceived - "greater" means more perfect.
- *Proslogion* 2 argues that existing in reality is greater than existing in the mind alone.
- *Proslogion* 3 upgrades the conclusion to necessary existence rooted in aseity.
- Descartes makes existence a perfection contained in the essence of a supremely perfect being.
- Gaunilo's *In Behalf of the Fool* offers the perfect-island parody.
- Anselm answers that only God is defined as having necessary, non-contingent existence.
- Kant: existence is not a real predicate; a hundred real thalers add no concept to a hundred possible ones.
- Chatterjee-Datta echo this with the hundred-rupees illustration.
- Frege-style analysis makes existence a second-order quantificational notion, not a perfection.
- Modal versions (Malcolm, Hartshorne, Plantinga) shift the burden onto the possibility premise.
- 2018 asks about concept-to-existence entailment; the correct verdict is conditional entailment without instantiation.
- There is no classical Indian ontological argument, for pramāṇa-theoretic reasons.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - THE ONTOLOGICAL ARGUMENT AS A REDUCTIO

START / CONCEPT: THE ONTOLOGICAL ARGUMENT AS A REDUCTIO

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v

EXACT TERMS: The Ontological Argument As A Reductio • Recommended opening definition • more perfect
• Crucial textual point • First form - Proslogion 2 • Second form - Proslogion 3

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: ANALYSIS: Distinction to state in the answer: Anselm argues by reductio from a comparative ("greater than"); Descartes argues from essence containment ("existence is a perfection").

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: It is the argument that has attracted the most sustained modern logical attention of all the proofs. ANALYSIS: Do not manufacture an "Indian ontological argument" out of Advaita.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not fuse the two; the causal one is not ontological.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The ontological argument is an a priori attempt to derive God's necessary existence from the concept of the greatest conceivable being.

SESSION 3 - TWO KINDS OF CAUSAL SERIES (THE WHOLE ARGUMENT TURNS ON THIS)

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: ANALYSIS: Ways 1-3 constitute the cosmological family; Way 4 is the henological / degrees argument; Way 5 is the teleological one, treated in Subtopic 4.

Technical definition: ANALYSIS: Presupposition: the act-potency analysis of change, and the claim that derivative causal power must be traced to non-derivative power here and now.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

ANALYSIS: Ways 1-3 constitute the cosmological family; Way 4 is the henological / degrees argument; Way 5 is the teleological one, treated in Subtopic 4.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Recommended opening definition
- cosmological
- henological / degrees
- teleological
- Reconstruction
- Presupposition

How to use them: Use Recommended opening definition to define the issue, connect cosmological with henological / degrees to explain it, and use teleological to distinguish or qualify the conclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening definition: Aquinas targets an essentially ordered present dependence, not merely a temporal sequence extending indefinitely into the past.

ACCIDENTALLY ORDERED (per accidens) - Aquinas does NOT need to stop this
great-grandfather -> grandfather -> father -> son
Each cause can perish and the effect continues.
An infinite backward series here is not obviously incoherent.

ESSENTIALLY ORDERED (per se) - THIS is what Aquinas terminates
HAND --moves--> STICK --moves--> STONE
Remove the hand and the whole series stops NOW.
Every intermediate member has only DERIVATIVE power.

An infinite series of borrowers with no owner explains nothing.

"FIRST" = EXPLANATORY PRIORITY, not the earliest event in time.

ANALYSIS: This diagram is the single highest-value item in the cosmological answer. The commonest UPSC error is to reduce all five Ways to "everything had a beginning, so God started it", which is neither Aquinas' argument nor a good argument.

1. Aquinas' Five Ways - the map before the detail

FACT: Aquinas offers five ways of proving divine existence (*Summa Theologiae* I, q.2, a.3). Unlike the ontological argument, which focuses on the idea of God and unfolds its inner implications, Aquinas' proofs **start from some general feature of the world around us** and argue that there could not be a world with this particular characteristic unless there also existed the ultimate reality we call God.

Way	Starts from	Terminates in
1	FACT: Change / motion	Prime Mover (unmoved mover)
2	FACT: Efficient causation	First Cause
3	FACT: Contingent beings (possibility and necessity)	Necessary Being
4	FACT: Degrees of value and perfection	Absolute Value / maximum
5	FACT: Evidence of purposiveness in nature	Divine Designer

ANALYSIS: Ways 1-3 constitute the **cosmological** family; Way 4 is the **henological / degrees** argument; Way 5 is the **teleological** one, treated in Subtopic 4. Each concludes with Aquinas' cautious formula, "*and this everyone understands to be God*" - a phrase that itself concedes that further theological work is needed to identify the terminus with the God of religion.

2. Way 1 - from motion

FACT: Reconstruction:

1. Some things in the world are in motion (in the broad sense: undergoing change, passing from potentiality to actuality).
2. Whatever is moved is moved by another; nothing can be in potentiality and actuality in the same respect at the same time.
3. That mover, if itself moved, requires a further mover.
4. An essentially ordered series of movers cannot proceed to infinity, for then there would be no first mover and hence no motion now.
5. There is a first, unmoved mover - "*and this everyone understands to be God.*"

ANALYSIS: Presupposition: the act-potency analysis of change, and the claim that derivative causal power must be traced to non-derivative power *here and now*.

FACT: Canonical example (state it in the answer): the stick moves the stone only while the hand moves the stick. The stick has no power of its own; its causal efficacy is borrowed. This is what makes the series essentially ordered.

3. Way 2 - from efficient causation

FACT: Reconstruction: In the observable world there is an order of efficient causes. Nothing is the efficient cause of itself, for it would then have to be prior to itself. In an ordered series of efficient causes, the first is the cause of the intermediate and the intermediate of the last; take away the cause and you take away the effect. An infinite regress of such causes would remove the first, and hence the intermediate and the last. Therefore a first efficient cause must be admitted.

ANALYSIS: FACT: Hick's assessment, worth reporting: the weakness of the argument as Aquinas states it lies in the difficulty - which Aquinas himself elsewhere acknowledges - of excluding as impossible an endless regress of events requiring no first state. **FACT: Neo-Thomists reformulate it** by insisting that the excluded series is not a regress of *events back in time* but an endless and therefore *eternally inconclusive* series of dependent causes existing simultaneously.

ANALYSIS: Do not miss the historical point: Aquinas holds, on philosophical grounds alone, that the universe *could* be eternal; that it began is known by faith, not demonstration. So Way 2 is not, and cannot be, an argument for a temporal beginning.

4. Way 3 - from contingency

FACT: **Reconstruction:**

1. We find things that are possible-to-be and possible-not-to-be (they are generated and corrupted).
2. What is possible-not-to-be at some time is not.
3. If everything were contingent, then at some time nothing would have existed.
4. If nothing existed at some time, nothing would exist now, since what does not exist begins to exist only through something that already exists.
5. Not all beings are merely possible; there must be something NECESSARY.
6. Every necessary being either has its necessity from another or from itself; the series of necessity-from-another cannot regress infinitely.
7. There exists a being necessary of itself - "this all men speak of as God."

ANALYSIS: **Two vulnerable steps.** (i) Step 3 arguably commits a **quantifier shift**: from "for each thing there is a time at which it does not exist" it does not follow that "there is a time at which no thing exists". (ii) Step 6 needs the distinction - Aquinas himself makes it - between beings necessary *ab alio* (angels, on his scheme) and the being necessary *a se*.

ANALYSIS: **Precision worth writing:** Way 3 is not the same as Way 2. Way 2 concerns causal *dependence*; Way 3 concerns *modal status* - contingency versus necessity. A script that merges them loses the very distinction the 2022 question was testing.

5. Way 4 - from degrees of perfection

FACT: **Reconstruction:** Among beings there are some more and some less good, true and noble. But "more" and "less" are predicated of things according as they resemble in different degrees something which is the maximum. Therefore there must be something which is truest, best and noblest, and consequently something which is the cause of being, goodness and every perfection in all things - and this we call God.

ANALYSIS: This is the least popular Way and the one most exposed to the objection that comparative judgements do not require an existing maximum (a "hottest possible thing" is not entailed by degrees of heat). Its defence requires the Platonic-Aristotelian machinery of participation and of a cause containing eminently what it confers.

ANALYSIS: It is nonetheless the Way most useful for showing the examiner that you understand Aquinas' **metaphysics of participation** rather than only his causal reasoning.

6. The Kalām cosmological argument

FACT: The Kalām form, which originates in Islamic philosophical theology and has been revived in modern discussion, is structurally different from Aquinas:

1. Whatever BEGINS to exist has a cause of its beginning.
2. The universe began to exist.
3. The universe has a cause of its beginning.
(+ conceptual analysis: that cause is beginningless, uncaused, changeless, timeless, immaterial, enormously powerful - and personal, since only agency explains a temporal effect from a timeless cause.)

ANALYSIS: **Contrast to state explicitly:** the Kalām argues *for* a temporal beginning and therefore engages Big-Bang cosmology directly; Aquinas' Ways deliberately do not require one. Collapsing the two is the standard textbook error.

7. Leibniz and the Principle of Sufficient Reason

ANALYSIS: Leibniz's version asks not "what started it?" but "**why is there something rather than nothing?**" Every fact requires a sufficient reason; the totality of contingent facts is itself contingent; therefore its sufficient reason must lie in a necessary being. This is the version that engages the modern brute-fact debate.

8. Objections and replies

Objection	Aimed at	Reply	Residual pressure
FACT: Hume: why not an infinite series, with each member explained by its predecessor?	Ways 1-3	ANALYSIS: The series concerned is essentially ordered; an infinite set of derivative causes still has no non-derivative actualising power	ANALYSIS: Requires proving the series <i>is</i> essentially ordered, not merely asserting it

Objection	Aimed at	Reply	Residual pressure
FACT: Hume : explaining each member explains the whole; the demand for a cause of the collection is illegitimate	Leibnizian version	ANALYSIS: A contingent totality is not made self-explanatory by enlarging the set	CAUTION: Tracks a genuine dispute over the scope of the PSR
FACT: Fallacy of composition : because each part has a cause, the whole need not	Cosmological family	ANALYSIS: The argument concerns <i>dependence</i> , not the transfer of a shared property	ANALYSIS: Must be stated as an essentially ordered series to hold
FACT: Kant : the cosmological argument covertly relies on the ontological	Ways 2-3	ANALYSIS: Thomists deny the covert reliance: they identify the necessary being with God through further metaphysical argument, not by definition	ANALYSIS: Even so, the identification is a separate and disputable stage
FACT: Hume : why must the cause be one, personal, infinite or good?	All	ANALYSIS: Cumulative-case strategies add attributes from several arguments together	FACT: <i>No single proof reaches classical theism</i>
ANALYSIS: Brute fact : the universe may simply be there	Leibnizian version	ANALYSIS: Explanatory demand does not evaporate merely because it is inconvenient	CAUTION: Genuinely unresolved

ANALYSIS: **Kant's objection, spelled out because it is frequently mis-stated**: the cosmological argument concludes to a *necessary being*; but to move from "a necessary being" to "the most real being (*ens realissimum*), i.e. God", one must argue that only the most perfect being can be necessary - and that step is the ontological argument. Kant's point is therefore an **adequacy-tier** attack: the cosmological argument's own resources take it only to "something necessary", and it borrows the rest.

9. India-West comparison

	Aquinas (Ways 1-3)	Nyāya kāryāt
Starting fact	FACT: Motion, causation, contingency	FACT: The world is a composite <i>effect</i>
Reason the world needs a cause	Derivative actuality requires non-derivative act	Composite parts + intermediate magnitude => producedness
Nature of the cause	FACT: Pure act; creator of <i>being</i> itself	FACT: Intelligent efficient cause who <i>orders</i> pre-existing eternal atoms
Material cause	God creates <i>ex nihilo</i> ; no independent matter	FACT: Eternal atoms are the material cause; God is not
Continuing relation	Conservation of being	FACT: Creation, maintenance, destruction - hence theism, not deism
Chief internal difficulty	Regress-exclusion; identification with God	Analogy from artefact to world; sufficiency of karma

ANALYSIS: **The single sharpest comparative sentence available for 2018 Q8(a)**: "*Both are a posteriori inferences from features of the world to an intelligent ultimate cause; but Aquinas' God confers existence itself, whereas Nyāya's Īśvara confers only order upon eternally existing atoms and souls.*"

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: **Do not merge the five Ways into one temporal "first cause" argument**. They start from different features and terminate in differently described conclusions.
2. ANALYSIS: "First" means **explanatory priority**, not chronological firstness.
3. ANALYSIS: Aquinas does not argue that the universe began in time; he holds that its beginning is known by faith.
4. ANALYSIS: The Kalām *does* argue for a temporal beginning; it is not Aquinas' argument.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute Paley's watch to Aquinas (see Subtopic 4).
6. ANALYSIS: Kant's objection is that the cosmological argument *borrow*s the ontological argument, not that it is invalid on its own terms.

7. ANALYSIS: Way 3 is modal (contingency/necessity); Way 2 is causal. Keep them apart.
8. ANALYSIS: Do not say Hume "refuted" the cosmological argument; he attacked the necessity of the regress-stop and the identification of the cause with God.

MEMORY: Mnemonic - "MCC-DP": Motion, Causation, Contingency (the cosmological three); then Degrees and Purpose (Ways 4 and 5).

Revision notes

- Aquinas' Ways begin from general features of the world, unlike the a priori ontological argument.
- Way 1: motion -> prime mover; Way 2: efficient causation -> first cause; Way 3: contingency -> necessary being.
- Way 4: degrees of perfection -> maximum; Way 5: purposiveness -> designer.
- The regress excluded is essentially ordered (hand-stick-stone), not accidentally ordered.
- "First" is explanatory, not temporal; Aquinas permits an eternal universe philosophically.
- Neo-Thomists reinterpret the excluded series as simultaneous dependence, not backward time.
- Kalām: whatever begins to exist has a cause; the universe began; therefore it has a cause.
- Leibniz's PSR version asks why there is something rather than nothing.
- Hume: infinite regress may be acceptable; explaining parts may explain the whole; the cause need not be God.
- Kant: the move from "necessary being" to "God" imports the ontological argument.
- Fallacy-of-composition charge is met by framing dependence rather than property-transfer.
- Aquinas' God causes being; Nyāya's Īśvara causes only order among eternal atoms.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - TWO KINDS OF CAUSAL SERIES (THE WHOLE ARGUMENT TURNS ON THIS)

START / CONCEPT: TWO KINDS OF CAUSAL SERIES (THE WHOLE ARGUMENT TURNS ON THIS)

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Recommended opening definition · cosmological · henological / degrees · teleological · Reconstruction · Presupposition

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: ANALYSIS: Kant's objection, spelled out because it is frequently mis-stated: the cosmological argument concludes to a necessary being; but to move from "a necessary being" to "the most real being (ens realissimum), i.e.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Kant's point is therefore an adequacy-tier attack: the cosmological argument's own resources take it only to "something necessary", and it borrows the rest.

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Keep them apart. ANALYSIS: Do not say Hume "refuted" the cosmological argument; he attacked the necessity of the regress-stop and the identification of the cause with God.

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v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: ANALYSIS: Ways 1-3 constitute the cosmological family; Way 4 is the henological / degrees argument; Way 5 is the teleological one, treated in Subtopic 4.

SESSION 4 - THREE TELEOLOGIES THAT MUST NOT BE CONFUSED

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: FACT: The inference is not weakened if I have never seen a watch made (as we have never seen a world other than this one) and therefore do not know from direct observation that watches are products of intelligence. FACT: The inference is not invalidated if the mechanism does not always work perfectly - as may appear to be the case with the mechanism of the world. FACT: The inference is not undermined if there are parts whose function we cannot discover - as there are in nature.

Technical definition: Its premise is that things which lack cognition nevertheless act for an end, and do so with regularity - which cannot be chance.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

FACT: The inference is not weakened if I have never seen a watch made (as we have never seen a world other than this one) and therefore do not know from direct observation that watches are products of intelligence. FACT: The inference is not invalidated if the mechanism does not always work perfectly - as may appear to be the case with the mechanism of the world. FACT: The inference is not undermined if there are parts whose function we cannot discover - as there are in nature.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Recommended opening definition
- Why the difference matters
- watch
- never seen a watch made
- does not always work perfectly
- parts whose function we cannot discover

How to use them: Use Recommended opening definition to define the issue, connect Why the difference matters with watch to explain it, and use never seen a watch made to distinguish or qualify the conclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening definition: Teleological arguments infer intelligence from purposive order, but Aquinas, Paley and fine-tuning employ distinct forms of order and inference.

(A) AQUINAS, FIFTH WAY - regularity of NON-COGNITIVE nature Natural bodies without knowledge act for an end, and do so ALWAYS or NEARLY ALWAYS in the same way. Whatever lacks knowledge cannot move toward an end unless directed by something with knowledge -> as the ARROW by the ARCHER. an intelligent being directs natural things. NOT an analogy with human artefacts.
(B) PALEY (1802) - ANALOGY from ARTEFACT to ORGANISM Watch on the heath : watchmaker :: eye, wing, fin : Designer Biological means-end ADJUSTMENT is the evidence. -> Directly vulnerable to Darwin.
(C) FINE-TUNING (modern) - PROBABILISTIC, not analogical Cosmological constants lie in an extremely narrow life-permitting range -> design as inference to the best explanation. Rivals: multiverse, anthropic selection, brute necessity. -> NOT touched by Darwin, because it is pre-biological.

ANALYSIS: Reproducing this three-way distinction is what separates a 60% answer from a 75% answer in 2025 Q6(a). Most candidates write Paley, get demolished by Darwin, and stop.

1. Aquinas' Fifth Way - stated properly

FACT: The design argument occurs in philosophical literature from Plato's *Timaeus* onward, and appears again as the last of Aquinas' five Ways.

FACT: The Fifth Way is *not* an analogy with human manufacture. Its premise is that things which lack cognition nevertheless act for an end, and do so with regularity - which cannot be chance. Hence they are directed by an intelligent being, as the arrow is directed by the archer.

ANALYSIS: Why the difference matters: Darwinian natural selection is a direct competitor to Paley's premise (biological adaptation) but a much less direct competitor to Aquinas' premise (the regular law-like directedness of nature as such), which arguably persists after evolution is granted.

2. Paley's watch

FACT: Paley's analogy of the watch conveys the essence of the argument. Walking in a desert place I see a stone, and may properly attribute its presence to the operation of natural forces - wind, rain, heat, frost, volcanic action. But if

I find a **watch**, I cannot reasonably account for it in the same way. A watch consists of a complex arrangement of wheels, cogs, axles, springs and balances, all operating accurately together to give a regular measurement of time. I am obliged to postulate an intelligent mind responsible for the phenomenon.

FACT: Paley's three supplementary points - quote them; they anticipate obvious replies:

1. **FACT:** The inference is not weakened if I have **never seen a watch made** (as we have never seen a world other than this one) and therefore do not know from direct observation that watches are products of intelligence.
2. **FACT:** The inference is not invalidated if the mechanism **does not always work perfectly** - as may appear to be the case with the mechanism of the world.
3. **FACT:** The inference is not undermined if there are **parts whose function we cannot discover** - as there are in nature.

FACT: Paley then argues that the natural world is as complex a mechanism, and as manifestly designed, as any watch: the rotation of the planets, the procession of the seasons, the mutual adaptation of the parts of a living organism. The eye, in particular, is a superb optical instrument with self-adjusting lenses, colour sensitivity and long continuous operation; the bird's wing is suited to the air and the fish's fin to the water.

ANALYSIS: Paley's is a **long cumulative argument** drawing on virtually all the sciences of his day - not a single inference. Saying so is worth a mark.

3. Hume's critique - the 2025 question's centre of gravity

FACT: The classic critique of the design argument occurs in David Hume's *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion*, **published in 1779, twenty-three years before Paley's book** - and Paley took no apparent account of it. That chronological point is a genuine fact worth stating, because it forestalls the naive assumption that Hume was replying to Paley.

Hume's attack proceeds on **five fronts**:

#	Front	Hume's argument	Tier attacked
1	FACT: Any universe must look designed	There could not be a universe at all in which the parts were not adapted to one another to a considerable degree - there could not be birds that grew wings but, like fish, could not live in air. So apparent adaptation is not evidence of design; it is a precondition of any persisting order. He proposes the Epicurean hypothesis : a finite number of particles in random motion will, in unlimited time, pass through every possible combination; one such combination is a stable order - perhaps ours.	Soundness
2	FACT: The analogy is weak	The universe is not particularly like a machine. One could as plausibly liken it to a great inert animal such as a crustacean, or to a vegetable - in which case the argument fails, since whether crustaceans and vegetables are designed is precisely the question at issue. Only if the world is strikingly analogous to a human artefact is there a basis for inferring a Designer.	Soundness
3	FACT: Proportioning cause to effect	From a given effect we can infer only a cause sufficient to produce it; therefore from a finite world we can never infer an infinite creator. Hume's illustration: if I see one side of a pair of scales and observe that ten ounces is outweighed by the unseen side, I may infer that the unseen weight exceeds ten ounces - but never that it is infinite.	Adequacy
4	FACT: Plurality and imperfection of designers	Great works are often built by many hands; the world may be the product of many deities, or an inferior deity, or a senile or infant one, or a bungled first attempt abandoned by its maker.	Adequacy
5	FACT: Evil and disorder	The mixed character of the world - waste, suffering, disease, catastrophe - counts against inferring a designer who is both good and powerful.	Adequacy

ANALYSIS: FACT: **The trap:** Hume does **not** claim to prove that no designer exists. His target is the **strength of the inference** and the **attributes** of the being inferred. In the *Dialogues* Philo himself concedes a remote, undefined analogy between the cause of order in the universe and human intelligence. Writing "Hume disproved design" is a factual error.

4. Darwin

FACT: The Darwinian theory of natural selection gives a more concrete account of the apparently designed character of animal bodies. Small random variations occur in every generation; species are relatively well adapted because the less well-adapted have perished in the continual competition to survive and have not perpetuated their kind. The "struggle for survival", as a constant pressure toward better adaptation, lies behind the evolution of life into increasingly complex forms.

FACT: **Hick's ozone illustration reverses the design intuition beautifully:** animal life is not sheltered by the ozone layer because God created the animals and then installed a filter for them; rather the ozone layer was there first, and only those forms of life capable of existing under the precise level of ultraviolet radiation that penetrates it have developed on earth.

ANALYSIS: **Exact scope of Darwin's defeat:** natural selection removes biological adaptation as evidence of design - that is, it removes Paley's premise. It does **not** touch (i) Aquinas' law-like directedness of non-cognitive nature, (ii) the fine-tuning of the physical constants that make chemistry and biology possible at all, or (iii) the question why there are law-governed regularities in the first place.

5. Fine-tuning and the probabilistic turn

ANALYSIS: Modern design reasoning is typically **Bayesian or explanatory** rather than analogical: the life-permitting values of certain cosmological parameters are said to be enormously improbable on chance, and less surprising on theism, so they raise the probability of theism.

Line of defence	Rival explanation	Assessment
ANALYSIS: Fine-tuning of constants	Multiverse plus observation-selection effect	CAUTION: Neither decisively wins; the dispute is about the legitimacy of the probability assignments
ANALYSIS: Intelligibility and law-governedness of nature	Brute necessity; the laws could not have been otherwise	ANALYSIS: Shifts the question rather than closing it
ANALYSIS: Cumulative case (Swinburne-style)	Underdetermination - many hypotheses fit	ANALYSIS: Yields a probability claim, never a demonstration

CURRENT: As noted, the 2025 review and 2026 paper both foreground exactly this migration - Paley -> irreducible complexity -> cosmic fine-tuning. ANALYSIS: **Use it as one contemporary sentence and no more.** UPSC rewards Hume and Paley, not physics.

6. The Indian analogue - potter and pot

FACT: Nyāya's inference is the closest Indian analogue: the world is treated as a vastly more complex *kārya* (effect) than a pot, and a pot's ordered parts warrant inference to a potter. FACT: Chatterjee and Datta observe that the Naiyāyika's causal argument strikingly resembles the reasoning of Western thinkers such as **Paul Janet, Hermann Lotze and James Martineau**, for whom the world of finite objects requires an intelligent cause giving order and co-ordination to its concurrent physical causes; Janet lays it down that all co-ordination between divergent phenomena implies a final cause or an intelligent agent. FACT: The Naiyāyika view of efficient cause as intelligent agent, they add, "strikingly anticipates Martineau's idea of cause as will directed to the realization of ends."

FACT: **But the decisive difference:** Western theists generally believe God is not only the cause of the unity/order of things but also **the creative energy that gives existence to the things of Nature**. For the Naiyāyikas, God is only the cause of the **order** of Nature, and not of the existence of its ultimate constituents.

ANALYSIS: Hume's second objection - that the world is unlike an artefact - therefore lands on Nyāya with full force, since Nyāya's inference is explicitly artefact-modelled (*ghaṭavat*, "like a pot").

7. Solved PYQ - 2025, Q6(a), 20 marks

FACT: Exact question: "Present an account of Design argument to prove the existence of God along with its criticism by David Hume."

Answer spine (write this shape, not a list):

1. CLASSIFY : teleological = a posteriori; distinguish Aquinas' Way 5 (regularity of non-cognitive nature, archer-arrow) from Paley's artefact ANALOGY.
2. RECONSTRUCT: Paley's watch on the heath + his three supplementary points (never seen one made; imperfect working; unknown parts) + the eye, wing, fin, seasons; note it is a CUMULATIVE argument.
3. CRITICISE : Hume, *Dialogues* (1779, PRIOR to Paley) on five fronts -
 - (a) any universe must look adapted; Epicurean hypothesis
 - (b) the world is as like a vegetable/animal as a machine
 - (c) proportion cause to effect: finite world => at most finite cause (the scales illustration)
 - (d) many/imperfect/infant/absentee designers are equally supported
 - (e) evil and disorder count against a good designer
4. EXTEND : Darwin removes Paley's biological premise (ozone illustration); but fine-tuning relocates the argument to pre-biological constants.
5. GRADE : Hume defeats DEMONSTRATION and defeats the inference to the infinite, single, perfectly good God; he does not disprove design. Design survives only as inference to the best explanation.
6. CONCLUDE : teleology retains cumulative and religious force while forfeiting demonstrative status; it points beyond the world without compelling.

India-West comparison

	Paley / Way 5	Nyāya āyojanāt
Evidence	FACT: Means-end adjustment in organisms; regular directedness in nature	FACT: Purposive combination of inert atoms into an ordered world
Model	Watch -> watchmaker; arrow -> archer	FACT: Pot -> potter
Cause's role	Creates and orders	FACT: Orders only; atoms are eternal
Cause's knowledge	Intelligence adequate to the design	FACT: Omniscience , since only an omniscient being can directly know entities as simple and infinitesimal as atoms
Main critic	Hume, Darwin	Mīmāṃsā, Buddhism, Jainism, Cārvāka

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: **Paley's watch is not Aquinas'**. Aquinas' Fifth Way is about the regular goal-directedness of non-cognitive nature.
2. ANALYSIS: Hume's *Dialogues* (1779) precede Paley's *Natural Theology* (1802).
3. ANALYSIS: Hume does not disprove a designer; he attacks inference-strength and divine attributes.
4. ANALYSIS: Darwin defeats Paley's biological premise, not every form of teleology.
5. ANALYSIS: Fine-tuning is probabilistic and pre-biological; it is not "Paley with physics".
6. ANALYSIS: "Irreducible complexity" is a modern, contested move - mention, never endorse.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not conflate the design argument with the problem of evil; evil enters here only as *one* of Hume's five fronts.
8. ANALYSIS: Nyāya's design-type inference reaches an *orderer*, not a creator of matter.

MEMORY: Mnemonic - Hume's five fronts, "A-A-P-P-E": Any universe looks adapted · Analogy is weak · Proportion cause to effect · Plurality/imperfection of designers · Evil.

Revision notes

- Teleology runs from Plato's *Timaeus* through Aquinas' Fifth Way to Paley and modern fine-tuning.
- Aquinas' Fifth Way: unknowing natural bodies act regularly for ends, as the arrow is directed by the archer.
- Paley: the watch on the heath obliges us to postulate an intelligent maker.
- Paley's three riders: never seen one made; imperfect working; unknown parts.
- Paley's evidence is cumulative - eye, wing, fin, planetary motion, seasons.

- Hume front 1: any persisting universe must exhibit adaptation; Epicurean hypothesis.
- Hume front 2: the world is as like a vegetable or animal as a machine.
- Hume front 3: proportion cause to effect - a finite world yields at most a finite cause (scales illustration).
- Hume front 4: many, imperfect, infant or absentee designers fit the evidence equally.
- Hume front 5: evil and disorder tell against a good and powerful designer.
- Darwin supplies a naturalistic mechanism for adaptation; the ozone case reverses the design intuition.
- Fine-tuning relocates design to pre-biological constants; multiverse and anthropic selection are the rivals.
- Nyāya's *āyojanāt* is the Indian analogue, modelled on potter and pot, reaching an orderer of eternal atoms.
- Verdict: teleology survives as inference to the best explanation, not as demonstration.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - THREE TELEOLOGIES THAT MUST NOT BE CONFUSED

START / CONCEPT: THREE TELEOLOGIES THAT MUST NOT BE CONFUSED

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Recommended opening definition · Why the difference matters · watch · never seen a watch made · does not always work perfectly · parts whose function we cannot discover

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: That chronological point is a genuine fact worth stating, because it forestalls the naive assumption that Hume was replying to Paley.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: ANALYSIS: FACT: The trap: Hume does not claim to prove that no designer exists.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: FACT: But the decisive difference: Western theists generally believe God is not only the cause of the unity/order of things but also the creative energy that gives existence to the things of Nature.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: FACT: The inference is not weakened if I have never seen a watch made (as we have never seen a world other than this one) and therefore do not know from direct observation that watches are products of intelligence. FACT: The inference is not invalidated if the mechanism does not always work perfectly - as may appear to be the case with the mechanism of the world. FACT: The inference is not undermined if there are parts whose function we cannot discover - as there are in nature.

SESSION 5 - KANT'S TWO-STOREY STRUCTURE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: FACT: Hick's objection: the basic assumption of all such arguments is that moral values are not capable of naturalistic explanation - in terms of human needs, desires, ideals, self-interest, or the structure of human nature or society.

Technical definition: Kant is the destroyer of the theistic proofs and the author of a moral argument, and he sees no contradiction because the two operate on different storeys.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Kant rejects speculative demonstrations of God while postulating God within practical reason as a condition of the highest good.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Kant's Two-Storey Structure
- Core argument
- logical inference
- Newman's version
- Hick's objection
- sovereign claim

How to use them: Use Kant's Two-Storey Structure to define the issue, connect Core argument with logical inference to explain it, and use Newman's version to distinguish or qualify the conclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Core argument: Kant rejects speculative demonstrations of God while postulating God within practical reason as a condition of the highest good.

```
===== THEORETICAL REASON (Critique of Pure Reason) =====
Categories apply only within possible EXPERIENCE.
God, freedom, immortality are IDEAS of reason - no intuition
corresponds to them.
↓
ONTOLOGICAL -> demolished: existence is not a real predicate
COSMOLOGICAL -> demolished: covertly presupposes the ontological
PHYSICO-THEOL.-> demolished: reaches at most an architect,
                  (design) then leans on the cosmological, then on the
                           ontological
↓
VERDICT: SPECULATIVE THEOLOGY IS IMPOSSIBLE. God is not KNOWN.
=====
                ||
            "I had to deny knowledge
            to make room for faith."
                ||
===== PRACTICAL REASON (Critique of Practical Reason) =====
The moral law is a FACT of reason; it commands categorically.
↓
It commands us to promote the HIGHEST GOOD (summum bonum)
    = complete virtue + happiness PROPORTIONED to virtue
↓
Ought implies can -> the highest good must be POSSIBLE
↓
But: complete virtue is unattainable in a finite lifetime -> IMMORTALITY
    and nature does not proportion happiness to virtue -> GOD
    (plus FREEDOM, presupposed by obligation itself)
↓
THREE POSTULATES: FREEDOM · IMMORTALITY · GOD
These are objects of RATIONAL FAITH (Vernunftglaube),
NOT items of theoretical knowledge.
=====
```

ANALYSIS: The whole examinable point is in the architecture, not the content. Kant is the destroyer of the theistic proofs *and* the author of a moral argument, and he sees no contradiction because the two operate on different storeys.

1. The first form of the moral argument - and why it fails

FACT: Hick distinguishes a first form of the argument that is presented as a **logical inference**: from objective moral laws to a divine Law Giver; or from the objectivity of moral values to a transcendent Ground of Values; or from the fact of conscience to a God whose "voice" conscience is.

FACT: **Newman's version** (*A Grammar of Assent*, 1870): "If, as is the case, we feel responsibility, are ashamed, are frightened, at transgressing the voice of conscience, this implies that there is One to whom we are responsible, before whom we are ashamed, whose claims upon us we fear... If the cause of these emotions does not belong to this visible world, the Object to which the conscientious person's perception is directed must be Supernatural and Divine."

FACT: **Hick's objection**: the basic assumption of all such arguments is that moral values are not capable of naturalistic explanation - in terms of human needs, desires, ideals, self-interest, or the structure of human nature or society. **To make that assumption is to beg the question.** An essential premise of the inference from axiology to God is precisely what is in dispute; from the sceptic's standpoint nothing has been established.

2. Kant's second form - the postulates

FACT: The second kind of moral argument "is not open to the same objection, for it is not strictly a proof at all." It claims that anyone seriously committed to respecting moral values as exercising a **sovereign claim** upon their life must thereby implicitly believe in a transhuman source and basis for those values.

FACT: **Kant's own structure** (*Critique of Practical Reason*, Book II, Ch. 2):

1. The moral law categorically obligates the will; obligation presupposes FREEDOM.
2. The complete object of a morally determined will is the HIGHEST GOOD:

- virtue (worthiness to be happy) together with happiness proportioned to it.
- Reason commands us to promote the highest good; "ought implies can", so the highest good must be really possible.
 - Perfect conformity of the will to the moral law (holiness) cannot be achieved by a finite being at any moment of its existence
-> an endless progress is required -> POSTULATE OF IMMORTALITY.
 - Nature and morality are causally independent; a finite agent cannot ensure that happiness follows virtue -> a cause of the whole of nature, distinct from nature, possessing intelligence and will, must be postulated
-> POSTULATE OF GOD.
 - These are postulates of PRACTICAL reason: theoretically undemonstrable propositions inseparably attached to an unconditionally valid practical law.

ANALYSIS: Three postulates, not one. Freedom, immortality and God. Many scripts mention only God and lose the systematic point.

3. What a postulate is - and is not

A postulate of practical reason is	A postulate is not
ANALYSIS: A proposition whose acceptance is rationally required if the moral law is to be coherently obeyed	FACT: A speculative demonstration
ANALYSIS: An object of <i>Vernunftglaube</i> - rational faith	FACT: An empirical hypothesis confirmable by evidence
ANALYSIS: Practically necessary, theoretically undecidable	FACT: A theoretical extension of knowledge
ANALYSIS: Subjectively sufficient, objectively insufficient assent	FACT: A dogma imposed on the sceptic

FACT: Hick's verdict, which is also the safest exam verdict: to recognise moral claims as taking precedence over all other interests is implicitly to believe in a reality other than the natural world that is superior to oneself and entitled to one's obedience. This is "at least a move in the direction of belief in God". But it cannot be presented as a proof, because the sovereign authority of moral obligation can itself be questioned; and even if moral values point toward a transcendent ground, they **cannot be said to point all the way to the infinite, omnipotent, self-existent, personal creator** of biblical faith.

4. Objections and replies

Objection	Force	Reply	Residual
FACT: It assumes moral values resist naturalistic explanation (Hick, against the first form)	Fatal to Newman-type inference	ANALYSIS: Kant's version does not infer from values to a Lawgiver; it postulates conditions of the highest good	ANALYSIS: But the sceptic may deny the highest good is obligatory
ANALYSIS: Wish-fulfilment / projection: the postulate merely dresses up a desire for cosmic fairness	Serious	ANALYSIS: Kant answers that the postulate arises from the <i>structure of moral reason</i> , not from reward-seeking; acting for reward would be heteronomy and would destroy moral worth	ANALYSIS: The line between "rational hope" and "consoling wish" is thin
ANALYSIS: Autonomy tension: if morality is autonomous, why does it need God at all?	Serious and internal	ANALYSIS: Kant does not ground <i>obligation</i> in God; God enters only for the <i>realisability</i> of the highest good	ANALYSIS: Some Kantians (and Kant in places) suggest the highest good could be reconceived so as not to need the postulate
FACT: Euthyphro dilemma: is the good good because God wills it, or does God will it because it is good?	Fatal to divine-command versions	ANALYSIS: Kant is untouched: for him the moral law is not divine command; God is the guarantor of proportion, not the source of obligation	FACT: Useful to show which versions the dilemma actually hits
ANALYSIS: Adequacy: postulation reaches a moral governor, not the God of religion	Standard	ANALYSIS: Kant grants it: he claims practical faith, not theology	FACT: Reinforces the "no single proof reaches classical theism" thesis

5. The Indian counterpart - Nyāya's *karmaphaladātā*

FACT: This is a genuine and underused comparison. Chatterjee and Datta, expounding the Nyāya argument from *adr̥ṣṭa*, write that God "combines happiness with virtue and misery with vice" - and note explicitly: **"Or, as Kant would say, it is God who combines happiness with virtue and misery with vice."**

	Kant	Nyāya
Problem addressed	ANALYSIS: Nature does not proportion happiness to virtue	FACT: Unconscious <i>adr̥ṣṭa</i> cannot allot determinate fruits
Role assigned to God	Postulated author of a nature in which the highest good is possible	FACT: <i>Karmaphaladātā</i> - actual dispenser of the fruits of action, the moral governor
Epistemic status	ANALYSIS: Practical postulate; theoretically undemonstrable	FACT: Conclusion of an <i>anumāna</i> , claimed as knowledge
Where the proportioning happens	Beyond this life, over an endless progress	FACT: Across this and previous lives, through <i>adr̥ṣṭa</i>
Chief rival	Naturalistic ethics	FACT: Mīmāṃsā: karma is self-operating; no dispenser is needed

ANALYSIS: **Sharp exam sentence:** "Kant postulates a God who could proportion happiness to virtue; Nyāya infers a God who actually does. The Indian argument is therefore epistemically bolder and correspondingly more exposed - it must show that an unconscious principle could not do the job."

6. Solved PYQ - 2021, Q7(b), 15 marks

FACT: **Exact question:** "Give a critical account of moral argument to prove the existence of God."

FRAME : Kant's two storeys - speculative proofs destroyed in CPR;
God re-entered in CPR as practical postulate.
STATE : Two forms - (i) inference from objective moral law/conscience to a Lawgiver (Newman); (ii) Kant's postulation from the highest good.
BUILD : moral law -> highest good -> ought implies can -> virtue unattainable in finite time (immortality) + nature does not proportion happiness to virtue (God). Three postulates: freedom, immortality, God.
CRITIQUE: (a) first form begs the question against naturalistic axiology;
(b) projection/wish-fulfilment charge; (c) autonomy tension;
(d) Euthyphro hits divine-command, not Kant;
(e) adequacy - reaches a moral governor, not the biblical creator.
COMPARE : Nyaya's karmaphaladātā - same problem, stronger epistemic claim.
GRADE : as a PROOF it fails and was never offered as one; as an account of the practical presuppositions of the moral life it retains force.
CONCLUDE: the moral argument does not prove God; it shows what a serious moral agent must hope, which is a different and more defensible claim.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: **Kant does not prove God through morality.** He postulates God for practical reason. This is the topic's most penalised error.
2. ANALYSIS: Three postulates - freedom, immortality, God - not one.
3. ANALYSIS: Newman's conscience argument is *not* Kant's; keep the two forms separate.
4. ANALYSIS: God is not the source of moral obligation for Kant; the moral law is autonomous.
5. ANALYSIS: Euthyphro refutes divine-command theories, not Kant's postulate.
6. ANALYSIS: "Ought implies can" applies to promoting the highest good, not to achieving it single-handedly.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not present the postulate as a reward-motive; that would be heteronomy and would destroy moral worth on Kant's own terms.
8. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the Indian comparison; *karmaphaladātā* is the natural Indian counterpart.

MEMORY: **Mnemonic - "F-I-G":** Freedom, Immortality, God - Kant's three postulates.

Revision notes

- Kant destroys the ontological, cosmological and physico-theological proofs in the *Critique of Pure Reason*.
- He shows the cosmological and design arguments ultimately lean on the ontological.

- In the *Critique of Practical Reason* he postulates God, immortality and freedom.
- The moral law is a fact of reason and commands categorically.
- Its complete object is the highest good: virtue plus proportionate happiness.
- Ought implies can, so the highest good must be possible.
- Holiness is unattainable in finite time, hence immortality is postulated.
- Nature does not proportion happiness to virtue, hence God is postulated.
- A postulate is practically necessary and theoretically undemonstrable - rational faith.
- Newman's conscience argument is the first form and begs the question against naturalism.
- Hick: the moral argument moves toward belief in God but cannot reach the infinite personal creator.
- Euthyphro strikes divine-command theories, not Kant's postulate.
- Nyāya's *karmaphaladātā* is the Indian analogue; Chatterjee-Datta explicitly invoke Kant.
- Verdict: not a proof, but a defensible account of the practical presuppositions of moral seriousness.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - KANT'S TWO-STOREY STRUCTURE

START / CONCEPT: KANT'S TWO-STOREY STRUCTURE

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Kant's Two-Storey Structure · Core argument · logical inference · Newman's version · Hick's objection · sovereign claim

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Kant is the destroyer of the theistic proofs and the author of a moral argument, and he sees no contradiction because the two operate on different storeys.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: FACT: Hick's objection: the basic assumption of all such arguments is that moral values are not capable of naturalistic explanation - in terms of human needs, desires, ideals, self-interest, or the structure of human nature or society.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: ANALYSIS: The whole examinable point is in the architecture, not the content.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Kant rejects speculative demonstrations of God while postulating God within practical reason as a condition of the highest good.

SESSION 6 - NYĀYA'S COSMIC DIVISION OF LABOUR

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Nyāya's Īśvara is an eternal, omniscient, omnipotent special self, never bound by karma.

Technical definition: ANALYSIS: Nyāya's God is the efficient, never the material, cause.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

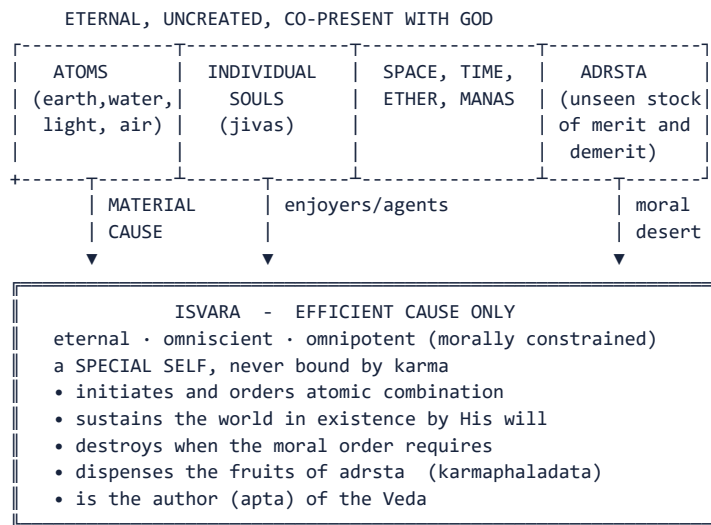
Nyāya's Īśvara is an eternal, omniscient, omnipotent special self, never bound by karma.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Nyāya'S Cosmic Division Of Labour**
- **Recommended opening definition**
- **preserver**
- **destroyer**
- **omnipotent**
- **omniscient**

How to use them: Use Nyāya'S Cosmic Division Of Labour to define the issue, connect Recommended opening definition with preserver to explain it, and use destroyer to distinguish or qualify the conclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening definition: Nyāya (school of logic and realism) infers an omniscient efficient cause that orders eternal atoms and dispenses karmic fruits, not a material creator from nothing.



=> GOD IS NIMITTA-KARANA (efficient cause), NOT UPADANA-KARANA (material cause). Atoms are the material cause.

ANALYSIS: Write this distinction in the first two lines of any Nyāya answer. It is the trap the examiner is checking for, and it is the difference between Nyāya and both Advaita and Rāmānuja.

1. The idea of God in Nyāya

FACT: God is the creator of the world **in the sense of being the first efficient cause of the world and not its material cause** - "a sort of demiurgus or a builder of the ordered universe". **FACT:** He is also the **preserver**, in so far as the world is kept in existence by the will of God, and the **destroyer**, who lets loose the forces of destruction when the exigencies of the moral world require it.

FACT: God is one, infinite and eternal, since the world of space and time, minds and souls does not limit Him but is related to Him as a body to the self residing in it. **FACT:** He is **omnipotent**, although guided in His activities by moral considerations of the merit and demerit of human actions; **omniscient**, possessing right knowledge of all things and events; and possessed of **eternal intelligence** as a power of direct and steadfast cognition of all objects.

FACT: A precise doctrinal point worth stating: eternal intelligence is only an **inseparable attribute** of God, **not His very essence**, as maintained in Advaita Vedānta. **FACT:** God possesses to the full all the **six perfections (ṣaḍ-aiśvarya)**.

FACT: Just as God is the efficient cause of the world, so He is the **directive cause** of the actions of all living beings. No creature, not even man, is absolutely free; man is relatively free - his actions are done under divine direction and guidance, as a wise and benevolent father directs his son according to his gifts, capacities and previous attainments. **FACT:** While man is the **efficient instrumental cause** of his actions, God is their **efficient directive cause (prayojaka kartā)**. God is thus the moral governor of the world, the impartial dispenser of the fruits of our actions (**karmaphaladātā**), and the supreme arbiter of our joys and sorrows.

ANALYSIS: FACT: Theism, not deism: according to deism, God creates the world at a point of time and then leaves it to itself, having usually no concern with its affairs - like a clock-maker who intervenes only when the clock goes out of order. On the Nyāya theory God maintains a **continuous relation** with the world, being creator, maintainer and destroyer. This is the essence of theism as distinguished from deism.

2. The proofs - the classical enumeration

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta record that "the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣikas have to their credit an array of proofs which include almost all the arguments given in Western philosophy for God's existence. There are as many as **ten proofs**, of which the more important may be considered here." **CAUTION: Lists therefore vary across summaries and across editions of Udayana's Nyāyakusumāñjali (Book V).** Use only the arguments the question requires, and say that the list is variously enumerated - that is accuracy, not evasion.

The compact Sanskrit mnemonic set, which the authored knowledge file uses and which UPSC answers should carry:

Term	Literal sense	Argument
FACT: Kāryāt	"from the effect"	The composite world is an effect and needs an intelligent maker
FACT: Āyojanāt	"from combination/arrangement"	Inert atoms cannot combine purposively by themselves
FACT: Dhṛtyādeḥ	"from support/sustenance etc."	The world's being upheld, maintained and destroyed requires governance
FACT: Padāt	"from the word"	Linguistic convention and the meaning-relation of words require an authoritative source
FACT: Pratyayataḥ / Śruteḥ	"from credibility / from scripture"	The authority of the Veda presupposes a trustworthy omniscient author; and śruti testifies to God
FACT: Argument from adṛṣṭa	-	Unconscious merit and demerit require an intelligent dispenser

3. Proof 1 - the causal argument (*kāryāt*), reconstructed

FACT: **Premises, in Chatterjee-Datta's own sequence:**

1. All composite objects of the world formed by the combination of atoms (mountains, seas, sun, moon, stars, planets) must have a cause, because they are of the nature of EFFECTS - like a pot (ghatavat).
2. That they are effects follows (a) from their being made up of parts (SAVAYAVA), and (b) from their possessing an intermediate magnitude (AVANTARA-MAHATTVA).
3. What is NOT an effect is excluded on the same principle:
space, time, ether and self are infinite substances not made of parts;
atoms of earth, water, light and air, and manas, are simple, indivisible and infinitesimal.
4. These composite objects are what they are because of the concurrence of a number of MATERIAL causes; but without the guidance of an INTELLIGENT cause (karta) the material causes cannot attain just that order, direction and co-ordination which enables them to produce effects.
5. This intelligent cause must have (i) direct knowledge of the material causes, i.e. the atoms, as means, (ii) a desire to attain some end, and (iii) the power of will to realise the end.
6. He must be OMNISCIENT (sarvajna), since only an omniscient being can have direct knowledge of entities so absolutely simple and infinitely small as atoms.
7. That intelligent cause is God and none but God.

ANALYSIS: **Notice how much work step 6 does.** The move to *omniscience* is not decorative: it is derived from the requirement of knowing atoms, which are imperceptible to ordinary cognition. This is the step that lifts the argument from "an intelligent artisan" to "an omniscient God", and it is Nyāya's answer to Hume's proportioning objection.

FACT: **Western parallels, from the same text:** the argument resembles the causal argument as explained by **Paul Janet** (Final Causes), **Hermann Lotze** (Outlines of a Philosophy of Religion) and **James Martineau** (*A Study of Religion*), for whom the world of finite objects requires an intelligent cause giving order and co-ordination to concurrent physical causes.

FACT: **But the crucial divergence:** Western theists generally believe that God is not only the cause of the unity of things but also **the creative energy that gives existence to the things of Nature**. For the Naiyāyikas, **God is only the cause of the order of Nature, and not of the existence of its ultimate constituents**.

4. Proof 2 - the argument from *adṛṣṭa*

FACT: **The problem:** how are we to account for the differences in our lot on earth - some happy, some miserable, some wise, some ignorant? These are events, and every event must have a cause.

FACT: **Step one:** the causes are our own actions in this or some previous life, governed by the moral law of karma, which requires that every individual reap the fruits of its own actions. This follows from extending the law of universal causation to the moral world: just as bodily acts produce bodily changes and mental functions produce mental

dispositions, so morally good or bad actions lead to good or bad moral consequences.

FACT: **Step two - the time-gap problem:** how do moral actions produce consequences separated from them by long intervals? "A sinner in the heyday of youth may be a sufferer in the infirmity of old age." Hence good actions produce an efficiency called **merit (punya)** and bad actions a deficiency called **demerit (pāpa)** in our souls, persisting long after the actions have ceased. This stock of merit and demerit is **adr̥ṣṭa**.

FACT: **Step three - the decisive move:** **adr̥ṣṭa** is an **unintelligent principle** which cannot by itself produce just that kind and degree of joy and sorrow which are due to our past actions. It must therefore be guided by an intelligent agent. Individual selves cannot direct it, for they know nothing about their own **adr̥ṣṭa**, and it not infrequently defies the control of their will. □ The intelligent agent who guides **adr̥ṣṭa** through the proper channels is the eternal, omnipotent and omniscient Divine Being, who dispenses all the joys and sorrows of life in strict accordance with it - "as a wise and potent monarch rewards or punishes his subjects according to the merit or guilt attaching to their actions."

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta themselves add the Kantian gloss: "Or, as Kant would say, it is God who combines happiness with virtue and misery with vice."

5. Proofs 3 and 4 - the Veda's authority (*padāt / āptaprāmānya*) and śruti's testimony

FACT: **Proof 3 - from the authoritativeness of the scriptures.** The authority (*prāmānya*) of the Vedas has its source in the supreme authority of their author (*āptaprāmānya*). Just as the authoritativeness of medical science, or of any science, derives from the scientists who founded it, so the authoritativeness of the Vedas derives from a person who imparted that character to them. The individual self (*jīva*) cannot be the author, since the supramundane realities related in the Vedas cannot be objects of an ordinary individual's knowledge. Hence the author must be a supreme person with direct knowledge of all objects - past, present and future; finite, infinite and infinitesimal; sensible and supersensible. That is, the Vedas are revealed by God.

ANALYSIS: Note the neat epistemological analogy embedded here: the Veda may be **partially verified** in its worldly injunctions (following them produces the desired results), and we accept the whole as authoritative just as we accept a whole science as true when only some parts are verifiable.

FACT: **Proof 4 - the testimony of śruti.** God exists because Vedic scripture bears testimony to His existence - *Bṛhadāraṇyaka* ("the highest eternal self is the Lord of all, the ruler of all, the protector of all"), *Śvetāśvatara* ("the one God lies hidden in all, is all-pervading, is the inmost self of all"), *Kauṣītaki*, and the *Bhagavadgītā* ("I am the highest end of all, the maintainer of all, the controller of all, the witness of all...").

FACT: **The circularity objection and Nyāya's reply - a genuinely elegant piece of philosophy that almost no candidate writes.** The objection: proof 3 shows God is the author of the Vedas, while proof 4 exhibits the Vedas as the ground of our knowledge of God - a circle. The reply distinguishes **the order of existence from the order of knowledge**:

ORDER OF EXISTENCE : GOD --creates--> VEDA
ORDER OF KNOWLEDGE : VEDA --leads to--> KNOWLEDGE OF GOD

The Vedas depend on God for their EXISTENCE but not for our KNOWLEDGE of them (they may be learned from a competent teacher);
God depends on the Vedas for our KNOWLEDGE of Him but not for His EXISTENCE.
Reciprocal dependence across two different orders is not a vicious circle.
Circularity arises only within the SAME order or universe of discourse.

ANALYSIS: **A second classical objection with a dilemma-reply:** if God be the creator of the world He must have a body, since without a body no action is possible. The Naiyāyikas reply that the objection is caught between two horns - if God's existence is proved by śruti, arguing against what is already proved is pointless; and if God's existence is not yet granted, the objection presupposes what it disputes.

6. Anti-theistic criticism - including from within the Indian textbook tradition

Critic	Objection	Nyāya reply	Assessment
FACT: Cārvāka	God cannot be perceived; the world is made by the automatic combination of the material elements, not by God; inference is unreliable	ANALYSIS: Inference is an independent <i>pramāṇa</i> ; the Cārvāka's own denial uses inference	ANALYSIS: The dispute is really about the scope of <i>pramāṇas</i>

Critic	Objection	Nyāya reply	Assessment
FACT: Mīmāṃsā	The Veda is eternal and authorless (<i>apauruṣeya</i>), so no divine author is needed; karma is self-operating	FACT: Nyāya: an unconscious principle cannot intelligently allot determinate fruits	CAUTION: The dispute tracks rival metaphysics of causation and normativity
FACT: Buddhism / Jainism	The world runs by karma and conditions without a creator	ANALYSIS: Same reply as above, plus the <i>kāryāt</i> premise	ANALYSIS: Requires defending the artefact analogy
FACT: Śāṅkara (Advaita)	Nyāya's God is a <i>saguṇa</i> Īśvara at the empirical level, not the absolute Nirguṇa Brahman; and the atomistic scheme is logically weak	ANALYSIS: Nyāya denies that the empirical order is <i>mithyā</i> and defends realist pluralism	ANALYSIS: A level-distinction dispute, not a simple refutation
FACT: Śāṅkara's atomism dilemma (reported by C. D. Sharma)	Are atoms essentially active, inactive, both or neither? If active, creation is permanent; if inactive, creation is impossible; if both, the conception is self-contradictory; if neither, activity must come from an outside agency - and that agency, seen or unseen, generates further absurdities	ANALYSIS: Nyāya locates the initiating impulse in God's will operating through <i>adrṣṭa</i>	ANALYSIS: Sharp, and still discussed
FACT: Sharma's own verdict	The Vaiśeṣika God "is not the creator of this universe... He has been reduced to the status of a supervisor," His "hands and feet chained by the shackles of the Law of Karma unfolding itself as the <i>Adrṣṭa</i> "; the system "could have easily done away with a God"	ANALYSIS: Nyāya answers that a supervisor who alone can intelligently allot is not dispensable	ANALYSIS: The redundancy objection is the most serious challenge Nyāya theism faces

FACT: **The textbook's own conclusion, which is examiner-gold when quoted as a critical position:** Chatterjee and Datta, invoking Kant and Lotze, argue that **none of the so-called proofs can really prove God's existence**. To prove anything is to deduce it as a necessary conclusion from given premises; but God, being the ultimate reality, is "the highest of all premises", so there can be no anterior premise from which God is deducible. All the proofs, they say, are vitiated by deducing God's existence from the mere idea of Him: "the idea of the most perfect being may involve the idea of existence, but not actual existence, just as the thought of one hundred rupees in my pocket involves the image or the idea of their existence, but not their real physical existence." Their positive conclusion: **God must be known through direct experience, not through reasoning** - and they quote Lotze: "all proofs that God exists are pleas put forward in justification of our faith and of the particular way in which we feel that we must apprehend this highest principle."

ANALYSIS: **Deploy this as your evaluative paragraph in 2023 Q7(a) and 2025 Q7(b).** It lets you criticise Nyāya from *within* the Indian tradition rather than importing Hume, which is what a first-class script does.

7. Solved PYQ - 2018, Q8(a), 20 marks (the comparison question)

FACT: **Exact question:** "Compare St. Thomas Aquinas' five ways of knowing God with the arguments of the Nyāya School of Indian Philosophy for the existence of God."

Comparison axis	Aquinas	Nyāya
Epistemic type	FACT: A posteriori demonstration (<i>demonstratio quia</i>)	FACT: <i>Anumāna</i> requiring <i>vyāpti</i> , modelled on artefacts
Starting facts	Motion, causation, contingency, degrees, purpose	Compositeness, arrangement, maintenance, <i>adrṣṭa</i> , Vedic authority
Cause of <i>existence</i>	FACT: Yes - God creates being itself	FACT: No - atoms are eternal, uncreated
Cause of <i>order</i>	Yes	FACT: Yes, and only this

Comparison axis	Aquinas	Nyāya
Relation to scripture	FACT: Proofs are <i>praeambula fidei</i> , from reason alone	FACT: Two of the standard proofs are explicitly scriptural
Moral government	Providence	FACT: <i>Karmaphaladātā</i> administering <i>adṛṣṭa</i>
Divine attributes reached	Pure act, simplicity, infinity	FACT: Omniscience derived from the need to know atoms
Principal internal weakness	Regress-exclusion; the identification with God	Artefact analogy; the redundancy of God given karma
Standard critique	Hume, Kant	Cārvāka, Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā, Advaita

ANALYSIS: **The conclusion that earns marks:** *"Both traditions produce a posteriori natural theology from order to intelligence, and both are attacked on the same two tiers - the strength of the inference and the adequacy of the God reached. They diverge decisively on material causation: Aquinas' God is the source of being, Nyāya's Īśvara only the architect of an eternally given material. The Indian argument is consequently more modest in metaphysical ambition and more exposed to the charge of divine redundancy."*

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: **Nyāya's God is the efficient, never the material, cause.** Atoms are the eternal material causes.
2. ANALYSIS: Nyāya theism is **theism, not deism** - God preserves and destroys as well as creates.
3. ANALYSIS: Eternal intelligence is an *inseparable attribute* of God in Nyāya, not His essence as in Advaita.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not answer "the nature of Nyāya's God" merely by listing Udayana's proofs, or vice versa.
5. ANALYSIS: *Adṛṣṭa* does not consciously distribute its own fruits - that unconsciousness is the whole premise of the argument.
6. ANALYSIS: Enumerations of the proofs vary; say so and use the ones the question needs.
7. ANALYSIS: The Veda-God circularity is answered by the order-of-existence / order-of-knowledge distinction; do not concede the circle.
8. ANALYSIS: Do not treat Nyāya as "the Indian Aquinas" without flagging the material-causation divergence.

MEMORY: **Mnemonic - "K-A-D-P-Ś + adṛṣṭa":** *Kāryāt* · *Āyojanāt* · *Dhṛtyādeḥ* · *Padāt* · *Śruteḥ*, plus the argument from *adṛṣṭa*. MEMORY: **Second mnemonic - "E-A-K-V":** Efficient cause · Atoms · Karma · Veda - the four pillars of Nyāya theology.

Revision notes

- Nyāya's Īśvara is an eternal, omniscient, omnipotent special self, never bound by karma.
- God is the first efficient cause, a builder or *demiurgus*, not the material cause.
- Atoms, souls, space, time, ether, manas and *adṛṣṭa* are eternal and co-present with God.
- God is creator, preserver and destroyer - hence theism, not deism.
- God is *prayojaka kartā*, the efficient directive cause of human action; man is relatively free.
- God is *karmaphaladātā*, impartial dispenser of the fruits of action.
- Eternal intelligence is an inseparable attribute of God, not His essence.
- *Kāryāt*: the composite world (*sāvayava*, *avāntara-mahattva*) is an effect and needs an intelligent maker.
- Omniscience is inferred because only an omniscient being can directly know atoms.
- *Āyojanāt*: inert atoms cannot combine purposively without a conscious arranger.
- *Dhṛtyādeḥ*: the world's support, maintenance and destruction require governance.
- *Adṛṣṭa* argument: unconscious merit and demerit require an intelligent dispenser.
- *Padāt* / *āptaprāmāṇya*: the Veda's authority presupposes an omniscient trustworthy author.
- *Śruteḥ*: scriptural texts testify to God's existence.

- The circularity charge is met by distinguishing the order of existence from the order of knowledge.
- The bodiless-agent objection is answered by a dilemma.
- Janet, Lotze and Martineau are the Western parallels; but they make God the source of existence, Nyāya only of order.
- Cārvāka, Mīmāṃsā, Buddhism, Jainism and Advaita each reject the proofs on distinct grounds.
- Śaṅkara's dilemma of active/inactive atoms attacks the whole Vaiśeṣika cosmology.
- Chatterjee-Datta conclude with Kant and Lotze that no proof proves God; direct experience is required.
- Sharma's redundancy objection - Nyāya "could have easily done away with a God" - is the sharpest internal criticism.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - NYĀYA'S COSMIC DIVISION OF LABOUR

START / CONCEPT: NYĀYA'S COSMIC DIVISION OF LABOUR

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v

EXACT TERMS: Nyāya's Cosmic Division Of Labour • Recommended opening definition • preserver • destroyer • omnipotent • omniscient

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MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: ANALYSIS: Nyāya's God is the efficient, never the material, cause.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: God is creator, preserver and destroyer - hence theism, not deism.

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: FACT: God is the creator of the world in the sense of being the first efficient cause of the world and not its material cause - "a sort of demiurgus or a builder of the ordered universe". FACT: He is also the preserver, in so far as the world is kept in existence by the will of God, and the destroyer, who lets loose the forces of destruction when the exigencies of the moral world require it.

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v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Nyāya's Īśvara is an eternal, omniscient, omnipotent special self, never bound by karma.

SESSION 7 - TWO COMPLETELY DIFFERENT SENSES OF "GOD" IN THE INDIAN DEBATE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: ANALYSIS: This is the single most important interpretive move in the entire subtopic.

Technical definition: Creator-denial must not be equated with denial of every religious ideal, because Jainism rejects a creator while affirming achieved godhead.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Creator-denial must not be equated with denial of every religious ideal, because Jainism rejects a creator while affirming achieved godhead.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- High-value transition
- Creator-denial
- Jainism
- ANALYSIS: This
- UPSC's
- 2019

How to use them: Use High-value transition to define the issue, connect Creator-denial with Jainism to explain it, and use ANALYSIS: This to distinguish or qualify the conclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: Creator-denial must not be equated with denial of every religious ideal, because Jainism rejects a creator while affirming achieved godhead.

SENSE 1 : GOD AS WORLD-MAKER (jagat-kartā)

Affirmed by : Nyaya-Vaisesika (efficient cause), theistic Vedanta

DENIED by : JAINA · BAUDDHA · MIMAMSA · SANKHYA · CARVAKA

▲
+-- denial on METAPHYSICAL grounds (karma/conditions suffice) ▲
+-- on EPISTEMIC grounds (no perception)

SENSE 2 : GOD AS PERFECTED BEING (paramatman / siddha / arhat)

AFFIRMED by JAINISM : "Jainism denies God, but does not deny GODHEAD.
EVERY LIBERATED SOUL IS A GOD."

Godhood is ACHIEVED, not eternal · PLURAL, not unique ·
a MODEL, not a maker.

=> THEREFORE the 2019 question "proofs for the existence of God as propounded in Jainism" is answered in SENSE 2, together with Jainism's refutation of SENSE 1. Answering only "Jainism is atheistic" mis-reads the question.

ANALYSIS: This is the single most important interpretive move in the entire subtopic. UPSC's 2019 wording presupposes that Jainism has *something* to prove; the mature answer explains which sense of "God" Jainism proves and which it refutes.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - TWO COMPLETELY DIFFERENT SENSES OF "GOD" IN THE INDIAN DEBATE

START / CONCEPT: TWO COMPLETELY DIFFERENT SENSES OF "GOD" IN THE INDIAN DEBATE

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v

EXACT TERMS: High-value transition · Creator-denial · Jainism · ANALYSIS: This · UPSC's · 2019

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MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: ANALYSIS: This is the single most important interpretive move in the entire subtopic.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: UPSC's 2019 wording presupposes that Jainism has something to prove; the mature answer explains which sense of "God" Jainism proves and which it refutes.

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Creator-denial must not be equated with denial of every religious ideal, because Jainism rejects a creator while affirming achieved godhead.

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ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Creator-denial must not be equated with denial of every religious ideal, because Jainism rejects a creator while affirming achieved godhead.

SESSION 8 - PART I - JAINISM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: FACT: Jainism is "a religion without God" in the sense of a creator. FACT: There is no necessity of bringing in God to explain creation, for the world was never created: production, destruction and permanence characterise all substances; things have creation and dissolution because of their modes (paryāya), while the substances themselves are eternal.

Technical definition: Jainism rejects a creator God but affirms liberated, omniscient souls as achieved godhead attained through self-effort.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Jainism rejects a creator God but affirms liberated, omniscient souls as achieved godhead attained through self-effort.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Part I
- Jainism
- Recommended opening definition
- creator
- modes (paryāya)
- Terminological caution that impresses examiners

How to use them: Use Part I to define the issue, connect Jainism with Recommended opening definition to explain it, and use creator to distinguish or qualify the conclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening definition: Jainism rejects a creator God but affirms liberated, omniscient souls as achieved godhead attained through self-effort.

1. What Jainism denies

FACT: Jainism is "a religion without God" in the sense of a **creator**. FACT: There is no necessity of bringing in God to explain creation, **for the world was never created**: production, destruction and permanence characterise all substances; things have creation and dissolution because of their **modes (paryāya)**, while the substances themselves are eternal. The six *dravyas* - *jīva*, *pudgala*, *dharma*, *adharma*, *ākāśa* and *kāla* - are beginningless.

FACT: ANALYSIS: **Terminological caution that impresses examiners:** *nāstika* in Indian philosophy standardly means "one who denies the authority of the Veda", not "one who denies the spirit". In that Vedic sense Jainism and Buddhism are *nāstika*; but they are intensely spiritual and ethical, and denial of God does not amount to atheism in the Western sense - otherwise Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā, which likewise do not believe in a creator God, could not have been counted orthodox.

2. What Jainism affirms - godhood, and the proofs for it

FACT: **"Though Jainism denies God, it does not deny godhead. Every liberated soul is a god."** FACT: The Tirthaṅkaras, who were mortal beings like us but obtained liberation through personal effort, are always there to inspire us. **We are all potential Jinas, for what man has done man can do.** Jainism is a religion of self-help.

ANALYSIS: **The Jaina "proofs" are therefore proofs of the possibility and actuality of divine perfection in the soul, arranged as follows:**

PROOF 1 - FROM THE INTRINSIC NATURE OF THE JIVA (svabhava-siddhi)

1. Every jiva intrinsically possesses infinite knowledge, infinite perception, infinite bliss and infinite power (ananta-catustaya).
2. Empirically these are obscured, not absent, since we observe DEGREES of knowledge, not its total absence.
3. Obscuration is caused by karmic matter (pudgala) adhering to the soul.
4. Remove the obscuring karma completely and the native perfections manifest completely.
5. Godhood is the soul's own nature recovered, not a status conferred from outside. [RECOVERY, not creation]

PROOF 2 - FROM DEGREES OF KNOWLEDGE TO OMNISCIENCE (sarvajna-siddhi)

1. Knowledge occurs in graded kinds: mati, sruta, avadhi, manahparyaya.
2. The gradation maps the progressive removal of karmic obstruction.
3. A graded series of obstruction-removal has a limiting case: COMPLETE removal.
4. At that limit knowledge is total, direct and unobstructed = KEVALA-JNANA.
5. An omniscient being (kevalin) is possible, and the Tirthaṅkaras are its actual instances.

PROOF 3 - FROM THE TESTIMONY OF THE OMNISCIENT (apta / agama)

1. Right faith rests on the teaching of the omniscient Tirthaṅkaras.
2. Their teaching is internally coherent, ascetically verified and transmitted through the Agama.
3. Their attained godhood is credible on the strength of apta-vacana.

ANALYSIS: FACT: Sharma states the epistemic role of Proof 3 exactly: faith is necessary because the deepest truths rest on the word "of the omniscient Tirthaṅkaras"; and right faith, right knowledge and right conduct - the **tri-ratna** - jointly constitute the path.

FACT: The resulting concept of God: plural (infinitely many *siddhas*), achieved (not eternal in status), non-creative (no cosmic function), non-interventionist (a *siddha* does not answer prayer or dispense karma), and purely exemplary. **ANALYSIS:** Sharma notes the historical tension frankly: strictly there is no room for devotion in Jainism, since asceticism must burn all emotion to ashes; yet the ordinary Jaina, under Brahmanical influence, has deified the Tirthankaras, built temples and worshipped their images.

3. Jaina refutation of a creator God

ANALYSIS: The classical Jaina anti-creator arguments (developed in the Digambara tradition and standard in Indian philosophical summaries) run:

#	Argument	Force
1	ANALYSIS: From what did God create? If from pre-existing matter, matter is uncreated and God is not the sole ultimate; if from nothing, anything could be produced anywhere at any time.	Attacks the coherence of creation
2	ANALYSIS: Why did God create? A perfect being has no unfulfilled desire; a motive implies lack.	Attacks divine perfection
3	ANALYSIS: If out of compassion, the world should contain only happiness.	Empirical refutation
4	ANALYSIS: If in sport (līlā), God is childish, and cruel toward the suffering.	Moral refutation
5	ANALYSIS: Who created God? If God is self-existent, the world may equally be self-existent - the theist's own concession destroys the argument.	Regress / parity
6	FACT: Karma suffices. The world-order and the distribution of pleasure and pain are explained by each soul's own karmic matter; no external allocator is required.	Explanatory economy

FACT: The Jaina positive alternative: the universe is eternal and uncreated; *utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya* (origination, decay, permanence) is the structure of every substance; change is real without a changer standing outside.

4. Solved PYQ - 2019, Q5(e), 10 marks

FACT: Exact question: "State and evaluate the proofs for the existence of God as propounded in Jainism."

- 1 min : Disambiguate "God" - Jainism denies jagat-karta but affirms GODHEAD.
- 4 min : The three Jaina routes - intrinsic ananta-catustaya of the jiva; the gradation of knowledge culminating in kevala-jnana; the testimony of the omniscient Tirthankaras (apta-vacana).
- 2 min : The refutation of a creator - motive, material, compassion, sport, regress, karmic sufficiency.
- 2 min : EVALUATE - the proofs succeed in establishing an ideal of attainable perfection, but they are internal to Jaina metaphysics: they presuppose the soul's intrinsic omniscience and material karma. They do NOT prove, and do not attempt to prove, a cosmic God.
- 1 min : Verdict - Jaina theology is a soteriological, not a cosmological, theism; "God" names the terminus of the path, not its author.

ANALYSIS: Evaluation lines available from within the Indian tradition (use one, not all): Sharma presses the classic realist-pluralist difficulty - if ignorance and karma are inseparable from the soul, liberation is impossible; if they are external to it, bondage is impossible - and holds that the Jainas have no real answer. If the soul is by nature pure consciousness and power, how can it be really tinged with ignorance, passion and karma? This objection strikes at the very premise on which Proof 1 rests.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - PART I - JAINISM

START / CONCEPT: PART I - JAINISM

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v

EXACT TERMS: Part I · Jainism · Recommended opening definition · creator · modes (paryāya) · Terminological caution that impresses examiners

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: FACT: Jainism is "a religion without God" in the sense of a creator. FACT: There is no necessity of bringing in God to explain creation, for the world was never created: production, destruction and permanence characterise all substances; things have creation and dissolution because of their modes (paryāya), while the substances themselves are eternal.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: FACT: "Though Jainism denies God, it does not deny godhead.

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: In that Vedic sense Jainism and Buddhism are nāstika; but they are intensely spiritual and ethical, and denial of God does not amount to atheism in the Western sense - otherwise Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā, which likewise do not believe in a creator God, could not have been counted orthodox.

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v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Jainism rejects a creator God but affirms liberated, omniscient souls as achieved godhead attained through self-effort.

SESSION 9 - PART II - BUDDHISM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: FACT: If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change. FACT: If God creates from desire or purpose, that suggests lack, preference or incompleteness. FACT: The presence of suffering and evil sits uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator. FACT: Dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator unnecessary.

Technical definition: Buddhism rejects a permanent creator and explains suffering through conditioned arising rather than divine production.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Buddhism rejects a permanent creator and explains suffering through conditioned arising rather than divine production.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Part II
- Buddhism
- Recommended opening definition
- Four core lines
- eternal and unchanging
- from desire or purpose

How to use them: Use Part II to define the issue, connect Buddhism with Recommended opening definition to explain it, and use Four core lines to distinguish or qualify the conclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening definition: Buddhism rejects a permanent creator and explains suffering through conditioned arising rather than divine production.

5. The Buddhist arguments against a creator God

FACT: **Four core lines**, as recorded in the authored knowledge file:

1. FACT: If God is **eternal and unchanging**, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change.

2. FACT: If God creates **from desire or purpose**, that suggests lack, preference or incompleteness.
3. FACT: The presence of **suffering and evil** sits uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator.
4. FACT: **Dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda)** already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator unnecessary.

ANALYSIS: **Three further lines that raise a 15-marker to distinction level:**

5. ANALYSIS: **The doctrinal-method argument.** Questions about a first beginning belong to the *avyākṛta* (undeclared) questions; the Buddha's refusal to answer them is not evasion but a judgement that they are soteriologically idle - the parable of the man wounded by an arrow, who dies while demanding to know the archer's caste before allowing the arrow to be drawn.
6. ANALYSIS: **The moral-agency argument.** If God determines all, karma and moral effort are meaningless; if God does not determine all, God is not the sufficient cause and the theistic explanation is redundant.
7. ANALYSIS: **The Dharmakīrti / Śāntarakṣita line.** A permanent, partless, immutable cause cannot produce *successive* effects, since a cause that is unchanging and fully present must produce its effect all at once and always; therefore an eternal God cannot be the cause of a temporally ordered world.

FACT: **Philosophical force, stated correctly:** the Buddhist critique is not mere atheistic denial; it is a **systematic refusal of explanatory surplus**. If conditioned arising explains the world-process, God is not needed. It is Ockhamite before Ockham.

ANALYSIS: **Presupposition to expose:** the critique assumes (i) that explanation should proceed through conditional relations rather than through a substratum or an external agent, and (ii) that what matters philosophically is not an absolutely first beginning but the structure by which bondage is maintained here and now.

6. Solved PYQ - 2018, Q8(b), 15 marks

FACT: **Exact question:** *"Critically evaluate the Buddhist arguments against the existence of God as the creator of the world."*

FRAME : Buddhism denies a creator without denying the sacred; the target is jagat-karta, not spiritual ultimacy.

STATE : (a) eternal unchanging cause cannot create; (b) creation from desire implies lack; (c) suffering tells against a benevolent omnipotent creator; (d) pratītyasamutpāda makes a creator explanatorily redundant; (e) the avyakṛta silence; (f) the freedom/karma dilemma; (g) Dharmakīrti: a permanent cause cannot yield successive effects.

CRITIQUE: - (i) Nyaya replies that unconscious karma cannot intelligently allot determinate fruits, so dependent origination explains sequence but not desert-appropriate ALLOCATION.

- (ii) The change objection assumes a temporal model of divine willing; classical theism replies with an eternal act producing a temporal effect.

- (iii) The desire objection assumes creation must satisfy a lack; theists appeal to gratuitous diffusive goodness.

- (iv) Explanatory economy is a methodological preference, not a disproof.

ASSESS : the arguments are strong AGAINST an anthropomorphic, purposive, benevolent world-maker; weaker against a metaphysically refined classical theism. They shift the burden rather than close the case.

CONCLUDE: Buddhism establishes that a coherent, ethically serious cosmology is possible without a creator - which is a substantial result even if it is not a demonstration of atheism.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - PART II - BUDDHISM

START / CONCEPT: PART II - BUDDHISM

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EXACT TERMS: Part II · Buddhism · Recommended opening definition · Four core lines · eternal and unchanging · from desire or purpose

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v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: FACT: If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change. FACT: If God creates from desire or purpose, that suggests lack, preference or incompleteness. FACT: The presence of suffering and evil sits uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator. FACT: Dependent origination (pratityasamutpāda) already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator unnecessary.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: If God determines all, karma and moral effort are meaningless; if God does not determine all, God is not the sufficient cause and the theistic explanation is redundant.

ANALYSIS: The Dharmakīrti / Śāntarākṣita line.

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: FACT: Philosophical force, stated correctly: the Buddhist critique is not mere atheistic denial; it is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus.

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ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Buddhism rejects a permanent creator and explains suffering through conditioned arising rather than divine production.

SESSION 10 - PART III - MĪMĀṂSĀ

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: FACT: The direct counter to Nyāya's proof 3: Mīmāṃsā objects that the Nyāya route is cumbersome - first prove God exists, then prove God is omniscient, then prove God intends truth, each stage needing independent support.

Technical definition: FACT: The Veda is authoritative because it is *apauruṣeya* - eternal, authorless and self-valid.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Mīmāṃsā (school of inquiry into ritual duty) treats the Veda (sacred revealed knowledge) as authorless and karma (morally consequential action) as self-fructifying, thereby displacing the need for God.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Part III
- Mīmāṃsā
- Recommended opening definition
- *apauruṣeya*
- The direct counter to Nyāya's proof 3
- And the direct counter to Nyāya's *adṛṣṭa* proof

How to use them: Use Part III to define the issue, connect Mīmāṃsā with Recommended opening definition to explain it, and use *apauruṣeya* to distinguish or qualify the conclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening definition: Mīmāṃsā (school of inquiry into ritual duty) treats the Veda (sacred revealed knowledge) as authorless and karma (morally consequential action) as self-fructifying, thereby displacing the need for God.

7. Why Mīmāṃsā needs no God

FACT: The Veda is authoritative because it is *apauruṣeya* - eternal, authorless and self-valid. It is not authored by any human, **nor is a divine author needed**. FACT: Authorlessness protects it from personal defects: a personal author may deceive, or may lack complete knowledge; if the Veda had an author, its authority would depend on first proving that author's competence and sincerity.

FACT: The direct counter to Nyāya's proof 3: Mīmāṃsā objects that the Nyāya route is cumbersome - first prove God exists, then prove God is omniscient, then prove God intends truth, each stage needing independent support. Authorlessness avoids the entire dependence. **FACT:** Coupled with *svataḥ-prāmāṇya* (intrinsic validity of cognition), this blocks scepticism at the starting point without theological guarantee.

FACT: And the direct counter to Nyāya's adṛṣṭa proof: *apūrva* is the unseen potency produced by correctly performed ritual; it persists after the act and matures into future fruit. This allows Mīmāṃsā to explain ritual efficacy **without God as fruit-dispenser**. Prābhākara adds *niyoga*: the injunction itself creates obligation, so one ought to act because the Veda commands, not because a deity rewards.

FACT: Chatterjee-Datta's report of the wider debate: the Mīmāṃsā rejects the proofs of God's existence, like the Jains, without replacing them by others. They also record Max Müller's contention that if God were supposed to be the creator, He would be liable to the charges of **cruelty and partiality**; and Müller's further point that rejection of a *creator*-God is not necessarily rejection of God, since pantheisms such as Advaita and Spinoza's do not accept the reality of creation and yet are not fairly called atheistic. **ANALYSIS:** Their own verdict is more sceptical: judged by what the Mīmāṃsā itself does and says, the Vedic deities are not treated as objects of worship and are not believed to exist anywhere except in the *mantras* that describe them - "eternal and self-manifesting concepts", like the immortal characters of classical epics. **ANALYSIS:** In its anxiety to maintain the supremacy of the Vedas, the Mīmāṃsā "relegates God to an ambiguous position".

8. Cārvāka - and the Nyāya replies to all three

FACT: Cārvāka: the existence of God is a myth; God cannot be perceived; the world is made by the **automatic combination of the material elements** and not by God; no faith should be put in the Vedas. **ANALYSIS:** Perception alone is a *pramāṇa*, so inference - on which every theistic proof depends - is unreliable.

Objec tor	Core claim	ANALYSIS: Nyāya's reply	Assessment
Cārvā ka	No perception of God; inference invalid	Inference is an independent <i>pramāṇa</i> ; the Cārvāka's own general denial itself requires inference	ANALYSIS: The dispute is about the scope of <i>pramāṇas</i> , not about God directly
Buddh ism	Conditions suffice; a permanent cause cannot produce successive effects	An unconscious causal nexus explains sequence but not desert-appropriate allocation	CAUTION: Rival metaphysics; no knock-down
Jainis m	Karma is material and self-operating; creation never happened	Material karma still requires an intelligent principle to allot determinate fruits	ANALYSIS: Nyāya's reply presupposes what Jainism denies
Mīmā ṃsā	Veda is <i>apauruṣeya</i> ; <i>apūrva</i> self-matures	Unconscious <i>apūrva</i> cannot intelligently proportion fruit to desert; authorless language is normatively unexplained	CAUTION: The deepest and most evenly matched Indian dispute
Advait a	Nyāya's Īśvara is only <i>saguṇa</i> , empirically valid; atomism is incoherent	Realist pluralism denies the <i>mithyā</i> verdict on the empirical order	ANALYSIS: A level-distinction dispute

India-West comparison

Objection type	Indian instance	Western counterpart
Explanatory economy	FACT: <i>Pratītyasamutpāda</i> ; karma; <i>apūrva</i>	FACT: Darwinian natural selection; Hume's Epicurean hypothesis
Coherence of attributes	ANALYSIS: Immutable cause cannot produce successive effects	FACT: Omnipotence paradoxes; immutability vs responsiveness
Evil	FACT: Suffering vs a benevolent creator; Müller's cruelty/partiality charge	FACT: Hume's fifth front; the evidential problem of evil
Epistemic restriction	FACT: Cārvāka's perception-only	FACT: Logical positivist verificationism
Authority without an author	FACT: Mīmāṃsā <i>apauruṣeya</i>	ANALYSIS: No close Western analogue - a genuinely distinctive Indian contribution

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: **Jainism denies God but not godhead.** Answering the 2019 question with "Jainism is atheistic" misreads it.
2. ANALYSIS: Jaina godhood is plural, achieved and non-creative; a *siddha* has no cosmic function.
3. ANALYSIS: Jaina karma is **material (pudgala)**; do not equate it with Nyāya's *adr̥ṣṭa* or a generic moral force.
4. ANALYSIS: *Nāstika* means denier of Vedic authority, not denier of spirit.
5. ANALYSIS: Buddhism's critique is a refusal of explanatory surplus, not a proof of atheism.
6. ANALYSIS: The *avyākṛta* silence is a methodological judgement, not agnostic evasion.
7. ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā's Veda is authorless - **not** God-authored; this is the exact contradictory of Nyāya's third proof.
8. ANALYSIS: *Apūrva* is Mīmāṃsā's substitute for a fruit-dispensing God; do not call it "karma" loosely.
9. ANALYSIS: Do not say Sāṃkhya "has no view"; classical Sāṃkhya is *nirīśvara* and also denies a creator.
10. ANALYSIS: Do not present these schools as a single "Indian atheism". Their grounds differ - economy, coherence, epistemic restriction.

MEMORY: Mnemonic - "E-C-E": every Indian anti-creator argument is an **E**conomy, **C**oherence or **E**pistemic move.

Revision notes

- Jainism denies a creator God but affirms godhood: every liberated soul is a god.
- The world was never created; substances are eternal and change through modes.
- *Utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya* - origination, decay and permanence characterise all substances.
- Jaina proof 1: the *jīva*'s intrinsic *ananta-catuṣṭaya* is obscured, not absent.
- Jaina proof 2: graded knowledge (*matī, śruta, avadhi, manaḥparyāya*) has a limiting case in *kevala-jñāna*.
- Jaina proof 3: the testimony of the omniscient Tīrthaṅkaras (*āpta-vacana*).
- Tīrthaṅkaras were mortals who attained liberation by personal effort - "we are all potential Jinas".
- Jaina anti-creator arguments: material of creation, motive, compassion, sport, regress, karmic sufficiency.
- Sharma's internal objection: if karma is inseparable from the soul, liberation is impossible; if external, bondage is.
- *Nāstika* means denier of Vedic authority; Jainism and Buddhism are *nāstika* only in that sense.
- Buddhism: an immutable eternal cause cannot create; creation from desire implies lack.
- Buddhism: suffering counts against a benevolent creator; dependent origination makes God redundant.
- The *avyākṛta* questions and the arrow parable show the critique is soteriological in motive.
- Dharmakīrti-type argument: a permanent cause cannot produce successive effects.
- Mīmāṃsā: the Veda is *apauruṣeya*, eternal and authorless; no divine author is needed.
- Authorlessness protects the Veda from an author's deceit or ignorance.
- Mīmāṃsā's objection to Nyāya: proving God, then omniscience, then truthfulness, is cumbersome.
- *Apūrva* explains ritual fruit without a divine dispenser; *niyoga* grounds obligation in injunction.
- Max Müller: a creator God would face charges of cruelty and partiality.
- Cārvāka: God is unperceived; the world results from the automatic combination of elements.
- All Indian anti-creator arguments reduce to economy, coherence or epistemic-restriction moves.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - PART III - MĪMĀṂSĀ

START / CONCEPT: PART III - MĪMĀṂSĀ

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Part Iii · Mīmāṃsā · Recommended opening definition · apauruṣeya · The direct counter to Nyāya's proof 3 · And the direct counter to Nyāya's adṛṣṭa proof

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v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: FACT: The Veda is authoritative because it is apauruṣeya - eternal, authorless and self-valid.

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v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: They also record Max Müller's contention that if God were supposed to be the creator, He would be liable to the charges of cruelty and partiality; and Müller's further point that rejection of a creator-God is not necessarily rejection of God, since pantheisms such as Advaita and Spinoza's do not accept the reality of creation and yet are not fairly called atheistic.

ANALYSIS: Their own verdict is more sceptical: judged by what the Mīmāṃsā itself does and says, the Vedic deities are not treated as objects of worship and are not believed to exist anywhere except in the mantras that describe them - "eternal and self-manifesting concepts", like the immortal characters of classical epics. ANALYSIS: In its anxiety to maintain the supremacy of the Vedas, the Mīmāṃsā "relegates God to an ambiguous position".

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v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Prābhākara adds niyoga: the injunction itself creates obligation, so one ought to act because the Veda commands, not because a deity rewards.

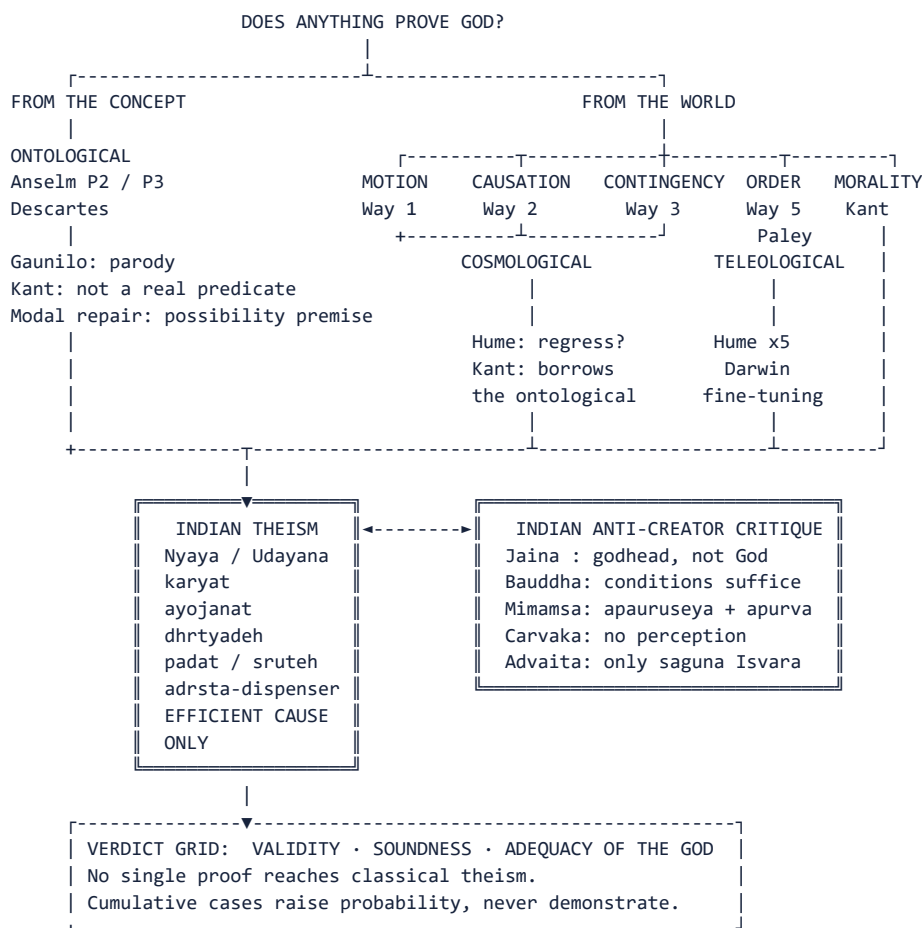
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v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Mīmāṃsā (school of inquiry into ritual duty) treats the Veda (sacred revealed knowledge) as authorless and karma (morally consequential action) as self-fructifying, thereby displacing the need for God.

VISUAL: MASTER CONCEPT MAP - THE WHOLE SYLLABUS ITEM ON ONE PAGE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Final verdict: No proof is demonstrative unless it survives validity, soundness and adequacy, and most arguments underdetermine the rich God of religion.



1. The master comparison table

Proof	Starting point	Conclusion claimed	Indian parallel	Main critic	What actually survives
Ontological	FACT: Concept of maximal being	Necessary existence	ANALYSIS: No exact classical analogue	Gaunilo, Kant	ANALYSIS: A conditional: <i>if</i> possible, then necessary
Cosmological	FACT: Motion, causation, contingency	First / necessary cause	FACT: Nyāya <i>kāryāt</i>	Hume, Kant	ANALYSIS: An explanatory demand, not a demonstration
Design	FACT: Order, adaptation, fine order	Intelligent designer	FACT: Nyāya <i>āyojanāt</i>	Hume, Darwin	ANALYSIS: Inference to the best explanation, at best
Moral	FACT: Moral law and the highest good	Practical postulate	FACT: Nyāya <i>karmaphaladātā</i>	Naturalist axiology, Euthyphro	ANALYSIS: A rational hope internal to moral seriousness
Nyāya inference	FACT: World as composite <i>kārya</i>	Omniscient efficient cause	-	Mīmāṃsā, Buddhism, Jainism, Cārvāka	ANALYSIS: A cumulative theism vulnerable to the redundancy charge
Mīmāṃsā counter	FACT: Eternal Veda; self-operating <i>apūrva</i>	No creator required	-	Nyāya	FACT: A coherent non-theistic account of normativity
Jaina counter	FACT: Uncreated world; material karma	Godhood without God	-	Nyāya	FACT: A soteriological theism without cosmology

2. Criticisms and replies - the consolidated grid

Objection	Proof affected	Reply	Assessment
FACT: "Existence is not a predicate"	Ontological	ANALYSIS: Modal versions use <i>necessary</i> existence	ANALYSIS: The possibility premise now bears the burden
FACT: Fallacy of composition	Cosmological	ANALYSIS: The argument concerns dependence, not property-transfer	ANALYSIS: Must be framed as an essentially ordered series
FACT: Infinite regress may be acceptable	Cosmological	ANALYSIS: An infinite series of derivative causes supplies no actualising power	ANALYSIS: Requires proving the series is <i>per se</i>
FACT: Cosmological borrows the ontological	Cosmological	ANALYSIS: Thomists identify the necessary being with God by further argument	ANALYSIS: That further argument is disputable
FACT: Weak world-artefact analogy	Design, Nyāya	ANALYSIS: Treat as probabilistic rather than deductive	ANALYSIS: The conclusion becomes modest
FACT: Natural selection explains adaptation	Paley	ANALYSIS: Relocate to law-governedness and fine-tuning	ANALYSIS: Rivals (multiverse) remain available
FACT: Cause need not be one, personal or perfect	Cosmological, design	ANALYSIS: Cumulative arguments add attributes	FACT: No single proof reaches classical theism
FACT: Karma can operate without God	Nyāya	ANALYSIS: Intelligent allocation explains determinate desert	CAUTION: Tracks rival metaphysics
FACT: The Veda needs no author	Nyāya <i>padāt/śruteḥ</i>	ANALYSIS: Authorless normativity is itself unexplained	CAUTION: The most evenly matched Indian dispute
FACT: Moral values may be naturalistically explained	Moral	ANALYSIS: Kant postulates rather than infers	ANALYSIS: The postulate can still be declined
ANALYSIS: Divine redundancy (Sharma)	Nyāya	ANALYSIS: A supervisor who alone allots is not dispensable	ANALYSIS: Nyāya's hardest challenge

3. Four verdicts you may safely defend

ANALYSIS: Choose **one** as the thesis of any answer, and defend it; do not hedge across all four.

- V1 MINIMAL : No proof is demonstrative; each fails on validity, soundness or adequacy. (Chatterjee-Datta, following Kant and Lotze.)
- V2 CUMULATIVE: Individually weak, jointly they raise the probability of theism. (Udayana; Swinburne; the 2025-26 literature.)
- V3 DIVERGENT : Different proofs establish different things - necessity, agency, intelligence, moral government - and no single one was ever meant to deliver the whole God of religion.
- V4 EXPERIENTIAL: Proofs are "pleas put forward in justification of our faith" (Lotze); God must be known through direct experience, not through reasoning. (Chatterjee-Datta's own conclusion.)

4. India and the West - convergence and divergence

Axis	FACT: Convergence	FACT: Divergence
Method	Both build a posteriori inferences from order to intelligence	ANALYSIS: India has no a priori ontological route; Nyāya requires <i>vyāpti</i>
Object established	Both reach an intelligent cause	FACT: Aquinas' God causes <i>being</i> ; Nyāya's Īśvara causes only <i>order</i>
Material cause	-	FACT: Creation <i>ex nihilo</i> vs eternal atoms
Moral government	FACT: Providence $\approx$ <i>karmaphaladātā</i>	ANALYSIS: Kant postulates it; Nyāya infers it
Scriptural authority	Both invoke revelation somewhere	FACT: Nyāya makes God the Veda's author; Mīmāṃsā makes the Veda authorless - no Western analogue
Anti-theistic critique	FACT: Both traditions field economy, coherence and evil-based objections	ANALYSIS: India's critiques come from <i>within</i> orthodoxy (Mīmāṃsā, Sāṃkhya), not only from sceptics

ANALYSIS: **The best single comparative sentence in the topic:** "Nyāya and Western natural theology converge in inferring from order to intelligence, but diverge over material causation and karma - and where the West's sharpest critics stood outside religion, India's stood inside it."

5. Answer architecture

10 marks (≈150 words, 7-8 minutes)

Name and classify the proof -> state its premises in sequence -> identify ONE presupposition -> give the canonical objection -> one-sentence verdict on what the proof actually establishes.

15 marks (≈220-260 words, 12-13 minutes)

Frame the explanatory question the proof answers -> reconstruct the argument as numbered steps -> give the canonical example (watch, pot, stick-stone) -> the critic's strongest objection -> the proponent's best reply -> assess VALIDITY and the ADEQUACY OF THE CONCLUSION SEPARATELY.

20 marks (≈320-360 words, 17-18 minutes)

Classify the family of proofs -> full internal steps -> contrast the Indian/Western analogue -> TWO objections with replies -> the underdetermination of divine attributes -> a graded, criterion-named conclusion.

6. PYQ routing - the complete 2018-2025 map

Year	Q	Marks	Demand	Session route
2018	Q6(c)	15	Does the concept of God entail the existence of God? (ontological)	Subtopic 2 §8
2018	Q8(a)	20	Compare Aquinas' five ways with Nyāya's arguments	Subtopics 3 + 6
2018	Q8(b)	15	Critically evaluate the Buddhistic arguments against a creator God	Subtopic 7 Part II
2019	Q5(e)	10	State and evaluate the Jaina proofs	Subtopic 7 Part I

Year	Q	Marks	Demand	Session route
2020	Q6(a)	20	Is Anselm's ontological proof logical?	Subtopic 2
2021	Q7(b)	15	Critical account of the moral argument	Subtopic 5
2022	Q6(a)	20	Critical exposition of the Five Ways; which is most interesting?	Subtopics 3 + 4
2022	Q8(a)	20	A priori vs a posteriori; which is preferable?	Subtopic 1 §2
2023	Q7(a)	20	Critically examine Nyāya's arguments	Subtopic 6
2024	Q7(c)	15 (10+5)	Exposition of the ontological proof with criticism	Subtopic 2
2025	Q6(a)	20	Design argument with Hume's criticism	Subtopic 4
2025	Q7(b)	15	What proofs do Nyāya philosophers offer?	Subtopic 6

7. "Which Way is philosophically most interesting?" - handling the 2022 evaluative demand

ANALYSIS: The question invites a **defended personal judgement**. The two strongest defensible answers:

Choice	Why defensible	What you must then show
ANALYSIS: Way 3 (contingency)	It alone asks the deepest question - why is there anything at all rather than nothing? - and connects to the live PSR/brute-fact debate	That you can state the quantifier-shift objection and the <i>ab alio / a se</i> distinction
ANALYSIS: Way 5 (purposiveness)	It generates the richest downstream tradition - Paley, Hume, Darwin, fine-tuning - and is the one still being fought over	That you can separate Aquinas' regularity premise from Paley's analogy

ANALYSIS: **What loses marks:** choosing Way 2 and describing it as "the first cause who started the universe", which is not Aquinas' argument at all.

9. Model philosophical conclusion

ANALYSIS: **"The proofs for God's existence fail as demonstrations but succeed as diagnostics. The ontological argument shows that God, if real, cannot be a contingent item in the world; the cosmological arguments show that contingent reality does not explain itself; the design argument shows that order invites, without compelling, an intentional explanation; the moral argument shows what a serious moral agent must hope; and Nyāya shows that the same inferential path was walked in India, and met the same objections from Mīmāṃsā and Buddhism that Hume and Kant later pressed in Europe. What no proof delivers is the passage from the being it establishes to the God actually worshipped - which is why every tradition, Indian and Western alike, eventually supplements proof with experience, testimony or faith."**

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Premium diagnostics - [CORE PAPER II]

All 32 hard diagnostics and eight category-error repairs are retained. The 32 core answers rotate A -> B -> C -> D eight times; the remediations have been option-reordered without changing their correct content or explanation so that their answers continue A -> B -> C -> D twice.

Key discipline: Questions 1-32 follow the correct-answer sequence **A, B, C, D** repeated exactly **eight times**, with no deviation. Each question has four plausible options, a detailed explanation, and a one-line trap note.

MCQ 1 - The three tiers of assessment [CORE PAPER II]

A candidate argues: "Aquinas' Second Way is formally valid, its premises are defensible, and therefore it proves the God of classical theism." Which tier of assessment has the candidate omitted?

A. Adequacy - whether the being established possesses the unity, infinity, personality and goodness attributed to God by developed religion

- B. Validity - whether the conclusion follows from the premises
- C. Soundness - whether the causal premise is true
- D. Consistency - whether the argument contradicts other arguments in the same system

Answer: A

Explanation: Validity and soundness are the two tiers the candidate has addressed. The missing third tier is adequacy - Kant's charge that the passage from "a necessary being" to "the most real being" is not supplied by cosmological reasoning, and Hume's principle that a cause need only be proportioned to its effect, both live here. D is not a standard tier and would not capture the objection.

MEMORY: Trap: a proof may be valid *and* sound and still fail to establish God.

MCQ 2 - Classifying the proof-families [CORE PAPER II]

Consider the following statements:

1. The ontological argument is the only classical *a priori* proof of God's existence.
2. Nyāya's *Īśvara-anumāna* is an *a priori* argument because it establishes an omniscient being.
3. Kant's moral argument begins from a feature of human experience and is therefore *a posteriori* in its starting point.
4. Aquinas' Fourth Way begins from the concept of maximal perfection and is therefore *a priori*.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 4 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 4 only

Answer: C

Explanation: Statement 1 is correct - no other classical proof reasons from the concept alone. Statement 3 is correct: Kant begins from the fact of the moral law and the structure of obligation, an experiential starting point, even though his conclusion is a postulate rather than an inference. Statement 2 is false: Nyāya begins from the world as a composite effect and requires *vyāpti* established by observation. Statement 4 is false: the Fourth Way begins from **observed degrees** of goodness and truth, not from a concept.

MEMORY: Trap: the *modality of the conclusion* does not determine whether an argument is *a priori*; the *source of the premises* does.

MCQ 3 - Anselm's two forms [CORE PAPER II]

Which statement correctly captures the difference between the arguments of *Proslogion 2* and *Proslogion 3*?

- A. Both establish exactly the same conclusion, the second being merely a rhetorical restatement
- B. *Proslogion 2* argues that existing in reality is greater than existing in the understanding alone, while *Proslogion 3* argues that a being which cannot be thought not to exist is greater, thereby establishing **necessary** existence and aseity
- C. *Proslogion 2* is directed at Gaunilo, while *Proslogion 3* is directed at Kant
- D. *Proslogion 2* establishes necessary existence, while *Proslogion 3* establishes existence in the understanding

Answer: B

Explanation: The second form upgrades the modal status of the conclusion from bare existence to necessary existence, grounded in God's self-existence; since God as infinitely perfect is not limited by time, both coming-to-be and ceasing-to-be are excluded. D inverts the two forms. A misses the point on which Anselm's whole reply to Gaunilo depends. C is anachronistic in both directions - Gaunilo replies *after* the *Proslogion*, and Kant is seven centuries later.

MEMORY: **Trap:** omitting *Proslogion* 3 makes Anselm's reply to Gaunilo unintelligible.

MCQ 4 - Gaunilo and Anselm's reply [CORE PAPER II]

Assertion (A): Gaunilo's perfect-island parody does not defeat the second form of Anselm's argument. **Reason (R):** An island is by definition a contingent, dependent part of the physical world and can without contradiction be thought not to exist, whereas God is defined as having eternal and independent existence.

- A. Both A and R are true, but R is not the correct explanation of A
- B. A is true, but R is false
- C. Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A
- D. A is false, but R is true

Answer: C

Explanation: Anselm's reply is precisely that the element present in the concept of God and absent from the concept of any island is necessary existence; the island, being "a piece of land surrounded by water", is by definition a contingent reality, so Anselm's principle does not apply to it. R therefore explains B exactly. B is not false, and R is not false, ruling out B and D; and the explanatory link is direct, ruling out A.

MEMORY: **Trap:** the reply saves the second form only by transferring the burden to the coherence of maximal greatness.

MCQ 5 - Kant on existence [CORE PAPER II]

Kant's claim that existence is not a "real predicate" is best illustrated by which of the following?

- A. The stick moves the stone only while the hand moves the stick
- B. A triangle must have three angles equal to two right angles, so its properties are necessary
- C. A hundred real thalers contain not one coin more in their concept than a hundred merely possible thalers; existence posits the object rather than enriching the concept
- D. A watch found on a heath obliges us to postulate a watchmaker

Answer: C

Explanation: The thaler illustration is Kant's own, and it isolates precisely the step Anselm and Descartes need - that adding existence to a concept makes it *greater*. Chatterjee and Datta restate the same point with a hundred rupees imagined in one's pocket. B is Descartes' analogy *for* the argument, not against it; D is Paley; A is Aquinas' illustration of an essentially ordered series.

MEMORY: **Trap:** Kant's objection is a diagnosis of the concept of existence, not a parody like Gaunilo's.

MCQ 6 - The modal ontological argument [CORE PAPER II]

Which statement most accurately describes the philosophical situation created by modal versions of the ontological argument?

- A. They abandon necessary existence in favour of contingent existence to escape Kant
- B. They are formally valid but relocate the entire burden onto the **possibility premise**, since a symmetrical premise that a maximally great being is possibly non-existent yields the opposite conclusion by the same logic
- C. They are versions of the cosmological argument, since they begin from the actual world
- D. They demonstrate God's existence in system S5 and are therefore immune to all objections

Answer: B

Explanation: The modal argument's inference is valid given its modal system, but premise 1 - that maximal greatness is possible - is exactly what is in dispute, and its negation is equally available. The dispute therefore shifts from bare existence to the coherence of maximal greatness. D ignores this; A reverses the argument's central device, which is

necessary existence; C confuses starting points, since the modal argument's premises are wholly modal-conceptual.

MEMORY: **Trap:** "valid" is not "compelling" - validity in S5 is cheap when the possibility premise is contested.

MCQ 7 - Descartes and Anselm [CORE PAPER II]

Which pair correctly matches a philosopher with the specific device his version of the ontological argument employs?

- A. Anselm - essence-containment; Descartes - *reductio* from a comparative
- B. Anselm - inference from the idea of the infinite in a finite mind; Descartes - the perfect-island parody
- C. Anselm - the possibility premise in S5; Descartes - the second-order analysis of existence
- D. Anselm - *reductio* using the comparative "greater"; Descartes - existence as a perfection contained in the essence of a supremely perfect being

Answer: D

Explanation: Anselm's machinery is a *reductio* driven by the comparative "greater"; Descartes' is essence-containment, illustrated by the triangle and the mountain-and-valley. A simply swaps them. In B, the first item is Descartes' *separate* causal proof in *Meditations* III, and the second is Gaunilo's. C attributes twentieth-century apparatus to both.

MEMORY: **Trap:** Descartes' *Meditations* III causal proof is not his ontological argument.

MCQ 8 - Essentially ordered series [CORE PAPER II]

Which of the following is an **essentially ordered** (*per se*) causal series of the kind Aquinas argues cannot regress infinitely?

- A. Great-grandfather begets grandfather, who begets father, who begets son
- B. One domino falls and topples the next, which topples the next, over several minutes
- C. A historian's account of successive dynasties, each replacing the last
- D. A hand moves a stick, which moves a stone - where removing the hand stops the entire series at once, because the intermediate members have only derivative causal power

Answer: D

Explanation: In a *per se* series the members act simultaneously and the intermediates have no independent causal power, so an infinite series of such members would supply no actualising power at all. A and C are accidentally ordered: the earlier members may perish and the effect continues. B is likewise accidentally ordered, since each fallen domino is finished with before the next falls.

MEMORY: **Trap:** Aquinas does not need to exclude infinite *per accidens* regresses, and elsewhere allows that the world may be eternal.

MCQ 9 - Mapping the Five Ways [CORE PAPER II]

Which of the following correctly maps Aquinas' Ways to their starting points?

- A. Way 1 from change; Way 2 from efficient causation; Way 3 from contingency; Way 4 from degrees of perfection; Way 5 from purposive regularity in things lacking cognition
- B. Way 1 from the concept of maximal greatness; Way 2 from motion; Way 3 from moral obligation; Way 4 from scripture; Way 5 from design
- C. Way 1 from the Big Bang; Way 2 from contingency; Way 3 from purposiveness; Way 4 from motion; Way 5 from degrees
- D. Way 1 from contingency; Way 2 from degrees; Way 3 from motion; Way 4 from purposiveness; Way 5 from efficient causation

Answer: A

Explanation: This is the standard order of *Summa Theologiae* I, q.2, a.3. B and D scramble the order; C imports the ontological argument, the moral argument and scriptural authority, none of which appear among the Ways - Aquinas presents all five as arguments from reason, *praeambula fidei*.

MEMORY: Trap: Way 4 (degrees) is easily forgotten; omitting it in a Five-Ways question is an immediate content loss.

MCQ 10 - The Third Way's weak step [CORE PAPER II]

Consider the following criticisms of Aquinas' Third Way:

1. It may commit a quantifier shift in moving from "for each contingent thing there is a time at which it does not exist" to "there is a time at which nothing exists".
2. It fails because Aquinas assumes the universe began in time, which modern cosmology denies.
3. It requires the further distinction between what is necessary *ab alio* and what is necessary *a se*.
4. It is an a priori argument and therefore falls to Kant's objection that existence is not a real predicate.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 4 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 2 and 4 only
- D. 1 and 3 only

Answer: D

Explanation: Criticism 1 is the standard logical objection to step 3 of the Way. Criticism 3 is correct: without distinguishing necessity derived from another from necessity of itself, the argument terminates too early. Criticism 2 is false - Aquinas holds that the world's temporal beginning is known by faith, not demonstration, and his argument does not require it. Criticism 4 is false: the Third Way is a posteriori, beginning from observed generation and corruption.

MEMORY: Trap: never say Aquinas argues for a temporal beginning; that is the Kalām.

MCQ 11 - Aquinas on the eternity of the world [CORE PAPER II]

Which statement is correct about Aquinas' position on whether the universe had a beginning in time?

- A. He demonstrates a temporal beginning from the impossibility of an actual infinite
- B. He holds that the universe could, so far as philosophical reason alone can determine, be eternal; that it began is held by faith, and his Ways therefore argue to explanatory rather than temporal priority
- C. He denies any beginning and holds the universe to be necessarily eternal
- D. He regards the question as meaningless, on the ground that time is a category of the understanding

Answer: B

Explanation: Aquinas himself acknowledges the difficulty of excluding an endless regress of events, and treats creation in time as revealed rather than demonstrated; neo-Thomists accordingly reinterpret the excluded series as one of simultaneous dependence. A describes the Kalām tradition; C misstates Aquinas, who holds the world contingent; D is Kantian, not Thomist.

MEMORY: Trap: this single fact separates a first-class Aquinas answer from a textbook one.

MCQ 12 - Kalām versus Aquinas [CORE PAPER II]

Which of the following correctly distinguishes the Kalām cosmological argument from Aquinas' Second Way?

- A. The Kalām concerns degrees of perfection while Aquinas' Second Way concerns motion
- B. The Kalām concludes to an impersonal principle while Aquinas concludes to a personal creator
- C. The Kalām is a priori while Aquinas' Second Way is a posteriori

D. The Kalām argues that the universe **began** to exist and therefore has a cause of its beginning, whereas Aquinas' Way argues from present dependence to explanatory priority and does not require a temporal beginning

Answer: D

Explanation: This is the structural difference. Because the Kalām's second premise asserts a temporal beginning, it engages directly with cosmology; Aquinas' argument is deliberately neutral on that question. C is false - both are a posteriori. A misdescribes both. B reverses the usual position, since Kalām defenders typically argue that only agency explains a temporal effect from a timeless cause.

MEMORY: Trap: merging Kalām and Aquinas is the commonest structural error in cosmological answers.

MCQ 13 - Kant against the cosmological argument [CORE PAPER II]

Kant's objection that the cosmological argument "rests on the ontological argument" is best understood as the claim that:

- A. The step from "there exists a necessary being" to "that being is the *ens realissimum*, i.e. God" cannot be made by cosmological reasoning alone and requires the ontological identification of supreme perfection with necessary existence
- B. The cosmological argument's premises are all analytic
- C. Aquinas borrowed his argument from Anselm's *Proslogion*
- D. The cosmological argument is invalid because infinite regresses are possible

Answer: A

Explanation: Kant's objection operates at the adequacy tier: the cosmological argument delivers "something necessary" and then imports, without acknowledgement, the theologically decisive identification. B is false, since the argument's first premise is empirical. C is a historical claim Kant does not make. D is Hume's objection, not Kant's.

MEMORY: Trap: Hume attacks the regress; Kant attacks the identification. Keep the two critics distinct.

MCQ 14 - Aquinas' Fifth Way and Paley [CORE PAPER II]

Which of the following statements is correct?

- A. Aquinas' Fifth Way argues by analogy from human artefacts to the universe, exactly as Paley later does
- B. Aquinas' Fifth Way argues that things lacking cognition act regularly for ends and must therefore be directed by an intelligence - the archer-and-arrow model - whereas Paley's argument is an analogy from artefacts, such as the watch, to organisms
- C. Paley's argument is identical to the modern fine-tuning argument, since both are probabilistic
- D. Neither Aquinas nor Paley offers a teleological argument; both are cosmological

Answer: B

Explanation: The Fifth Way's premise is the *regular directedness of non-cognitive nature*, which is why Darwinian selection is a less direct competitor to it than to Paley. A collapses the distinction; C confuses an analogical argument with a probabilistic one, and ignores that fine-tuning concerns pre-biological constants; D is simply false.

MEMORY: Trap: attributing the watch analogy to Aquinas is explicitly listed among this topic's standard traps.

MCQ 15 - Paley's supplementary points [CORE PAPER II]

Which of the following was **not** among Paley's supplementary points defending the watch analogy?

- A. The inference is not weakened if we have never actually seen a watch being made
- B. The inference is not invalidated if the mechanism sometimes fails to work perfectly
- C. The inference is not undermined if some parts have functions we cannot discover
- D. The inference is strengthened by the fact that the universe contains no evil or waste whatever

Answer: D

Explanation: Paley's three riders are exactly A, B and C - designed to pre-empt the obvious replies. D is not Paley's claim and is manifestly false; indeed the mixed character of the world is precisely Hume's fifth line of attack, and Paley's second rider is an attempt to blunt it.

MEMORY: Trap: Paley concedes imperfection; he does not deny it.

MCQ 16 - Hume's Epicurean hypothesis [CORE PAPER II]

Hume's argument that "any universe capable of persisting must exhibit mutual adaptation of its parts" functions in the *Dialogues* as:

- A. An undercutting objection showing that apparent adaptation is a **precondition** of any persisting order rather than evidence of design - reinforced by the Epicurean hypothesis that particles in random motion will, in unlimited time, realise a stable combination
- B. An argument that evil disproves a benevolent designer
- C. A concession that design is probable but not certain
- D. A theological argument for a limited deity

Answer: A

Explanation: This is Hume's first front. It does not concede probability (B), does not argue for a limited deity (C), and is distinct from the argument from evil (A), which is a separate, adequacy-tier front. Hick presents the point with the example that there could not be birds that grew wings but, like fish, could not live in air.

MEMORY: Trap: front 1 attacks the evidence; the evil argument attacks the designer's attributes. Different tiers.

MCQ 17 - Hume on the analogy [CORE PAPER II]

Hume's objection that the universe resembles "a great inert animal such as a crustacean, or a vegetable" at least as much as it resembles a machine is intended to show that:

- A. The design inference lacks the strong analogy with a known artefact that alone would license inferring an intelligent designer, since whether vegetables and crustaceans are designed is precisely the point at issue
- B. The universe is alive and therefore divine
- C. Biological organisms cannot be explained mechanistically
- D. Design arguments must be replaced by cosmological arguments

Answer: A

Explanation: The objection is about the strength of the analogy that the argument requires. B and C misread a critical device as a positive cosmology. D proposes a substitution Hume nowhere endorses; his critique of the cosmological argument is separate and equally severe.

MEMORY: Trap: Hume's alternative analogies are dialectical devices, not his own metaphysics.

MCQ 18 - Proportioning cause to effect [CORE PAPER II]

Hume's illustration of a pair of scales, where an unseen weight outweighing ten ounces may be inferred to exceed ten ounces but never to be infinite, supports which conclusion?

- A. That the design argument is formally invalid
- B. That even if a designer may be inferred, from a **finite** world one can never infer an **infinite**, perfectly good and unique creator - an objection to the adequacy of the conclusion rather than to the evidence
- C. That the universe must have had many designers working in succession
- D. That natural selection explains adaptation without design

Answer: B

Explanation: The scales illustration formalises the principle that a cause need only be proportioned to the effect from which it is inferred. A misidentifies the tier of the objection; C is Hume's fourth front, a distinct argument; D is Darwin's contribution, not Hume's.

MEMORY: Trap: this objection *grants* the inference and then denies its reach - the classic adequacy move.

MCQ 19 - The exact scope of Darwin's defeat [CORE PAPER II]

Which statement most accurately describes what Darwinian natural selection removes from the design debate?

- A. It removes the possibility of any teleological reasoning whatever
- B. It removes the fine-tuning of cosmological constants as evidence for design
- C. It removes Aquinas' Fifth Way, since that argument depends on the adaptation of organisms
- D. It removes **biological adaptation** - Paley's central evidence - as a datum requiring intelligent design, while leaving untouched the law-governedness of nature and the pre-biological fine-tuning of physical constants

Answer: D

Explanation: Hick's ozone illustration makes the point vividly: life fitted itself to the radiation that penetrates the ozone layer, rather than the layer being installed to protect pre-existing life. A overstates; B is precisely wrong, since fine-tuning is pre-biological and untouched by biological selection; C misstates the Fifth Way, whose premise is the regular directedness of non-cognitive nature, not organic adaptation.

MEMORY: Trap: Darwin defeats Paley, not teleology as such.

MCQ 20 - Fine-tuning and its rivals [CORE PAPER II]

Which of the following best characterises the contemporary fine-tuning argument and the principal objection to it?

- A. It is an a priori argument from the concept of a designer, refuted by Kant
- B. It is a deductive proof from the constants of physics, refuted by the fallacy of composition
- C. It is a probabilistic inference to the best explanation from the narrow life-permitting range of physical constants, and its principal rivals are multiverse hypotheses combined with observation-selection effects, or brute physical necessity
- D. It is an analogical argument from artefacts, refuted by Darwin

Answer: C

Explanation: Fine-tuning arguments are Bayesian or explanatory rather than analogical or deductive, and their live competitors are cosmological rather than biological. D confuses fine-tuning with Paley; A misclassifies it as a priori; B misdescribes both its logical form and the relevant objection.

MEMORY: Trap: mention fine-tuning as a modern extension; never let it displace Paley and Hume in a UPSC answer.

MCQ 21 - Kant's postulates [CORE PAPER II]

Which set correctly lists Kant's postulates of practical reason?

- A. God, the moral law and the categorical imperative
- B. Freedom, immortality and God
- C. Freedom, the highest good and the *ens realissimum*
- D. Immortality, providence and grace

Answer: B

Explanation: Freedom is presupposed by obligation itself; immortality is postulated because holiness is unattainable in finite time; God is postulated because nature does not proportion happiness to virtue. In B, the moral law is a *fact of reason*, not a postulate, and the categorical imperative is its formulation. C mixes an object of the will with a term from theoretical theology. D imports Christian theological categories Kant does not postulate.

MEMORY: **Trap:** listing only God loses the systematic architecture of the argument.

MCQ 22 - The role of "ought implies can" [CORE PAPER II]

In Kant's moral argument, the principle that "ought implies can" functions to establish that:

- A. Since reason commands us to promote the **highest good**, the highest good must be really possible - which in turn requires conditions (endless moral progress, and a cause of nature able to proportion happiness to virtue) that only the postulates supply
- B. Every moral agent is capable of achieving the highest good unaided
- C. Moral obligation is conditional upon belief in God
- D. God's existence follows deductively from the existence of moral obligation

Answer: A

Explanation: The principle secures the *real possibility* of the commanded object, and the postulates are the conditions of that possibility. B is exactly what Kant denies, which is why the postulates are needed. C reverses Kant's doctrine of autonomy - obligation is unconditional and independent of theology. D describes the inferential first form, not Kant's postulational one.

MEMORY: **Trap:** the highest good must be *promotable*, not single-handedly *achievable*.

MCQ 23 - Newman's conscience argument [CORE PAPER II]

Hick's central objection to the inferential form of the moral argument, exemplified by Newman's *Grammar of Assent*, is that it:

- A. Confuses the moral law with the categorical imperative
- B. Assumes that moral values admit of no naturalistic explanation in terms of human needs, desires, social structures or the constitution of human nature - and thereby **begs the question** against the very sceptic it addresses
- C. Relies on an unestablished possibility premise
- D. Contradicts the doctrine of divine simplicity

Answer: B

Explanation: The inference from conscience to a divine addressee requires that conscience not be naturalistically explicable, which is precisely what is in dispute; from the naturalistic sceptic's standpoint nothing has been established. D is irrelevant; A confuses two Kantian items; C belongs to the modal ontological argument.

MEMORY: **Trap:** Kant's second form escapes this objection because it postulates rather than infers.

MCQ 24 - The target of the Euthyphro dilemma [CORE PAPER II]

The Euthyphro dilemma - is the good good because God wills it, or does God will it because it is good? - is a serious objection to:

- A. Kant's postulate of God as the condition of the highest good's possibility
- B. Anselm's second form of the ontological argument
- C. Nyāya's inference from the composite character of the world
- D. Divine-command theories that make God's will the source and standard of moral goodness

Answer: D

Explanation: The dilemma forces divine-command theorists to choose between arbitrariness (anything God willed would be good) and a standard independent of God (which demotes God from the source of morality). Kant is insulated, since for him the moral law is autonomous and God guarantees only the proportioning of happiness to virtue; B and C are not moral arguments at all.

MEMORY: **Trap:** aiming Euthyphro at Kant is a misapplied objection and is penalised.

MCQ 25 - Nyāya's divine causation [CORE PAPER II]

Which statement correctly describes God's causal role in Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika?

- A. God creates the world at a moment and thereafter has no concern with it, intervening only in emergencies
- B. God is both the efficient and the material cause, the world and selves forming His body
- C. God is the intelligent **efficient** cause who orders eternally existing atoms, preserves the world by His will and destroys it when the moral order requires - atoms remaining the material cause
- D. God transforms His own essence into atoms, souls and space

Answer: C

Explanation: Nyāya's God is a *demiurgus* or builder, not a material source. D is a Vedāntic transformation model; A is deism, which Chatterjee and Datta explicitly distinguish from Nyāya theism on the ground that God maintains a continuous relation with the world; B is Rāmānuja's Viśiṣṭādvaita.

MEMORY: **Trap:** calling Nyāya's God the material cause is the topic's most heavily penalised factual error.

MCQ 26 - The kāryāt argument's internal steps [CORE PAPER II]

Consider the following statements about the Nyāya causal argument:

1. Composite objects are known to be effects because they are made of parts and possess intermediate magnitude.
2. Space, time, ether and self are treated as effects because they are perceptible.
3. The intelligent cause must be omniscient, because only an omniscient being can have direct knowledge of atoms.
4. Atoms of earth, water, light and air are excluded from the class of effects because they are simple, indivisible and infinitesimal.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1, 2 and 3 only
- B. 1, 3 and 4 only
- C. 2 and 4 only
- D. 1 and 2 only

Answer: B

Explanation: Statements 1, 3 and 4 reproduce the argument exactly: *sāvayava* and *avāntara-mahattva* are the marks of effect-hood; atoms and *manas* are excluded as simple infinitesimals; and the derivation of omniscience turns on the requirement of directly knowing atoms. Statement 2 is false - space, time, ether and self are excluded from effect-hood precisely because they are **infinite substances not made up of parts**, and they are not perceptible in the required way.

MEMORY: **Trap:** the omniscience step is what lifts the argument from "an intelligent artisan" to "God"; omitting it guts the proof.

MCQ 27 - The argument from adrṣṭa [CORE PAPER II]

The Nyāya argument from *adrṣṭa* concludes to God because:

- A. Without God the law of karma would produce no effects at all
- B. The Vedas declare that *adrṣṭa* is created afresh by God at the start of each world-cycle
- C. *Adrṣṭa*, being an **unintelligent** principle, cannot by itself allot precisely the kind and degree of joy and sorrow deserved, while individual selves neither know their own *adrṣṭa* nor control it - so an omniscient dispenser is required
- D. *Adrṣṭa* is a divine attribute and therefore presupposes God

Answer: C

Explanation: *Adṛṣṭa* is the stock of merit (*puṇya*) and demerit (*pāpa*) generated by the soul's own past actions, introduced to bridge the time-gap between act and consequence. The argument turns on its unconsciousness. D inverts the doctrine; A overstates the claim, which concerns determinate allocation rather than efficacy as such; B contradicts *adṛṣṭa*'s origin in the agent's own karma.

MEMORY: Trap: the Mīmāṃsā counter - that *apūrva* matures by itself - is aimed exactly at this premise.

MCQ 28 - The Veda-God circularity [CORE PAPER II]

Nyāya's reply to the charge that it proves God from the Veda and the Veda from God is that:

- A. The charge is conceded, and the two arguments are therefore abandoned
- B. Scripture is not really used, since both arguments are purely inferential
- C. Circularity is acceptable in theology though not in logic
- D. The dependence runs in different orders: in the **order of existence** God creates the Veda and imparts its authority, while in the **order of knowledge** the Veda leads us to God - and reciprocal dependence across two different orders is not a vicious circle

Answer: D

Explanation: The reply adds that the Veda does not depend on God for our *knowledge* of it, since it may be learned from a competent teacher, while God does not depend on the Veda for His *existence*. Circularity would arise only within one and the same order or universe of discourse. A concedes what the tradition answers; B is false, since two of the standard proofs are explicitly scriptural; C is not a reply Nyāya offers.

MEMORY: Trap: conceding the circle throws away one of the most elegant replies in Indian philosophy of religion.

MCQ 29 - Jaina godhead [CORE PAPER II]

Which statement most accurately expresses the Jaina position on God?

- A. Jainism denies God as creator of the world but affirms **godhead**: every liberated soul is a god, and the Tīrthaṅkaras were mortals who attained that state by personal effort
- B. Jainism affirms a single eternal creator who arranges the six substances
- C. Jainism accepts the Vedic testimony to God while rejecting inference as a *pramāṇa*
- D. Jainism identifies God with the totality of material substance

Answer: A

Explanation: The world was never created; substances are eternal and change through modes, so no creator is required. Godhood is achieved, plural, non-creative and exemplary - "we are all potential Jinas". B contradicts the doctrine that the world is uncreated; C contradicts Jainism's rejection of Vedic authority; D describes a materialist pantheism alien to Jaina pluralism.

MEMORY: Trap: answering the 2019 PYQ with "Jainism is atheistic" misreads the question and forfeits most of the marks.

MCQ 30 - The Buddhist immutability argument [CORE PAPER II]

The Buddhist argument that a permanent, immutable God cannot be the creator of the world proceeds by claiming that:

- A. A cause that is eternal, unchanging and fully present at all times should produce its effect always and all at once, and therefore cannot account for a world of **temporally successive** events
- B. An immutable being cannot be omniscient, since knowledge of a changing world would change it
- C. An immutable being cannot be good, since goodness requires responsiveness to suffering

D. An immutable being could not have created atoms, since atoms are eternal

Answer: A

Explanation: This is the Dharmakīrti-type line, and it targets the compatibility of immutability with successive production. B and C are distinct objections about omniscience and goodness respectively, which the tradition raises separately. D is a Nyāya-internal thesis about material causation, not a Buddhist argument against a creator.

MEMORY: Trap: classical theism replies with a single eternal act producing a temporal effect; a "critically evaluate" answer must include that reply.

MCQ 31 - Mīmāṃsā's twin displacement of God [CORE PAPER II]

Which pair of Mīmāṃsā doctrines together dispenses with the two Nyāya arguments that appeal, respectively, to Vedic authority and to the dispensing of karmic fruit?

A. *Anekāntavāda* and *syādvāda*

B. **Apauruṣeya** - the Veda is eternal and authorless, so no divine author is needed - and **apūrva**, the unseen potency of correctly performed ritual that matures into future fruit without a divine dispenser

C. *Pratītyasamutpāda* and *anātman*

D. *Vivarta* and *māyā*

Answer: B

Explanation: These two doctrines strike Nyāya's third proof and its *adrṣṭa* proof simultaneously. Mīmāṃsā adds that Nyāya's route is cumbersome, requiring one first to prove God exists, then that God is omniscient, then that God intends truth. A is Jaina, C Buddhist, D Advaitic.

MEMORY: Trap: *apūrva* is Mīmāṃsā's technical substitute for a fruit-dispensing God; do not call it "karma" loosely.

MCQ 32 - Comparative synthesis [CORE PAPER II]

Which of the following is the most defensible comparative judgement about Western and Indian proofs for God?

A. Hume's analogy objection has no application to Nyāya, whose inference is not analogical

B. Indian philosophy possesses an ontological argument in Advaita's derivation of Brahman from the concept of pure being

C. Both traditions build a posteriori inferences from order to intelligence and face objections on the same tiers; but they diverge decisively over material causation - Aquinas' God confers **being**, whereas Nyāya's Īśvara only orders eternally existing atoms - and India's sharpest anti-theistic critiques come from within orthodoxy

D. Nyāya's *kāryāt* argument and Aquinas' Second Way are identical, since both terminate in a first cause of the world's existence

Answer: C

Explanation: D ignores the material-causation divergence, which is the single most important comparative point. B manufactures an Indian ontological argument; Brahman is disclosed through *śruti* and *anubhava*, not established by conceptual analysis. A is false - Nyāya's inference is expressly modelled on pot and potter (*ghaṭavat*) and is therefore squarely exposed to Hume's objection.

MEMORY: Trap: the phrase "India's critics stood inside religion, the West's outside it" is the highest-value comparative line in this topic.

Premium remediation - [CORE ANSWER]

These target the six category errors that cost the most marks in this syllabus item. Attempt them only after Part II.

Remedial R1 - "Proof", "postulate" and "inference"

A student writes: "Kant proved the existence of God from the moral law." Which correction is required?

- A. Kant proved immortality but not God
- B. Kant inferred God from the objectivity of moral values, as Newman did
- C. Kant **postulated** God as a condition of the real possibility of the highest good; a postulate of practical reason is theoretically undemonstrable and is an object of rational faith, not knowledge
- D. Kant demonstrated God's existence but only for practical purposes, which counts as a proof

Answer: C · Note: the Critique of Pure Reason denies speculative theology; the Critique of Practical Reason supplies postulates, not proofs. Writing "Kant proves God" is the topic's single most penalised sentence.

Remedial R2 - Efficient versus material causation

A student writes: "In Nyāya, God creates the atoms and then arranges them." Which correction is required?

- A. God creates neither atoms nor souls; **atoms are eternal and are the material cause**, while God is the intelligent **efficient** cause who orders them, and also preserves and destroys the world
- B. God is the material cause and the atoms are His modes
- C. God creates the atoms but not the souls
- D. God neither creates nor orders; the atoms combine automatically

Answer: A · Note: D is the Cārvāka position; C is Vedāntic. The efficient/material distinction (nimitta- versus upādāna-kāraṇa) must appear in the opening lines of any Nyāya answer.

Remedial R3 - Which critic said what

Match the objection to its author: (i) the perfect-island parody; (ii) "existence is not a real predicate"; (iii) the scales illustration; (iv) the archer and the arrow.

- A. (i) Kant, (ii) Gaunilo, (iii) Paley, (iv) Hume
- B. (i) Hume, (ii) Gaunilo, (iii) Kant, (iv) Paley
- C. (i) Gaunilo, (ii) Hume, (iii) Kant, (iv) Paley
- D. (i) Gaunilo, (ii) Kant, (iii) Hume, (iv) Aquinas

Answer: D · Note: the archer-arrow belongs to Aquinas' Fifth Way, not to Paley, whose image is the watch. Misattribution here is the fastest way to lose examiner confidence.

Remedial R4 - Aquinas versus Kalām

A student writes: "Aquinas' Second Way proves that the universe began to exist and that God caused the beginning." Which correction is required?

- A. Aquinas' argument concerns **present, simultaneous dependence** and explanatory priority; he holds that the temporal beginning of the world is known by faith rather than demonstrated, and it is the **Kalām** argument that asserts a beginning
- B. Aquinas's argument is a priori and therefore says nothing about time
- C. Aquinas proves an infinite regress is possible
- D. Aquinas proves a beginning, but by the Third Way rather than the Second

Answer: A · Note: if you write only one sentence about Aquinas, make it this one.

Remedial R5 - What Hume actually establishes

A student writes: "Hume proved that the universe has no designer." Which correction is required?

- A. Hume proved there are many designers rather than one

- B. Hume's target is the **strength of the inference** and the **attributes** of the being inferred; in the *Dialogues*, Philo himself concedes a remote and undefined analogy between the cause of order and human intelligence
- C. Hume abandoned the design argument in favour of the cosmological argument
- D. Hume proved that natural selection explains adaptation

Answer: B · Note: B is Darwin, seventy years later. A is one of Hume's dialectical alternatives, not his conclusion.

Remedial R6 - Jainism, Buddhism and Mīmāṃsā are not one position

Which statement correctly differentiates the three Indian anti-creator positions?

- A. All three deny God because none accepts inference as a *pramāṇa*
- B. All three deny God because they accept the eternity of the Veda
- C. All three deny God because they deny the reality of the external world
- D. Jainism denies a creator because the world is uncreated and karma is material and self-operating, while affirming godhood in the liberated soul; Buddhism denies a creator because dependent origination explains arising through conditions and an immutable cause cannot yield succession; Mīmāṃsā denies a creator because the Veda is *apauruṣeya* and *apūrva* matures without a dispenser

Answer: D · Note: A confuses them with Cārvāka; B is false of all three; C is true only of Mīmāṃsā and is flatly denied by the other two, which reject Vedic authority altogether.

Remedial R7 - Validity, soundness, adequacy

Which objection operates at the **soundness** tier rather than the adequacy tier?

- A. From a finite world one may infer only a finite cause
- B. A first cause need not be morally good
- C. The universe resembles a vegetable as much as a machine, so the analogy required by the argument is too weak to support the inference
- D. The cause established need not be one rather than many

Answer: C · Note: A, C and D all grant an inference and question the attributes of its terminus. Sorting objections by tier is the fastest route to an evaluative conclusion.

Remedial R8 - Register of the concluding verdict

Which concluding sentence would earn the most credit in a 20-mark answer?

- A. "Thus the arguments are interesting but inconclusive, and the matter remains a personal belief."
- B. "Thus God's existence is proved beyond doubt by the cumulative weight of the arguments."
- C. "Judged by evidential contact the a posteriori proofs are stronger, judged by modal strength the a priori is; but neither closes the gap between the being established and the God of developed religion, which is why every tradition - Thomist, Kantian and Nyāya alike - eventually supplements proof with experience or testimony."
- D. "Thus no argument works and religion is irrational."

Answer: C · Note: D names its criteria, grades its verdict and is comparative. C is the "safe" conclusion most candidates write; it earns few evaluative marks because it names no criterion.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified-question status - [CORE ANSWER]

All 12 items below are direct verified owner PYQs. Exact wording, years and marks are retained. Demand decoding, full model solutions, marks rationale, timing skeletons and examiner traps are pedagogic answer support, not an official answer key.

Corpus note: FACT: The audited Paper II corpus for 2018-2025 contains **12 primary-owned question-parts** for this syllabus item, out of 112 parts overall. The corpus is continuous across all eight years. Cross-linked questions owned by *Notions of God, Reason-Revelation-Faith or Soul, Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation* are not duplicated here.

#	Year	Q	Marks	Theme
1	2018	Q6(c)	15	Ontological - concept and existence
2	2018	Q8(a)	20	Aquinas' Five Ways vs Nyāya
3	2018	Q8(b)	15	Buddhist arguments against a creator
4	2019	Q5(e)	10	Jaina proofs
5	2020	Q6(a)	20	Is Anselm's proof logical?
6	2021	Q7(b)	15	Moral argument
7	2022	Q6(a)	20	Five Ways; most interesting
8	2022	Q8(a)	20	A priori vs a posteriori
9	2023	Q7(a)	20	Nyāya arguments
10	2024	Q7(c)	15 (10+5)	Ontological proof with criticism
11	2025	Q6(a)	20	Design argument with Hume's criticism
12	2025	Q7(b)	15	Nyāya proofs

PYQ 1 - 2018, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact question

"Does the concept of God entail the existence of God? Examine from the perspective of ontological argument."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Examine</i> - analyse the entailment claim and deliver a reasoned verdict; not a narrative of Anselm's life
Core issue	Whether conceptual analysis can establish instantiation
Scope boundary	Stay inside the ontological family; do not drift into Aquinas or Nyāya
Ideal thesis	The concept entails necessary existence conditionally - if God exists, God exists necessarily - but conceptual entailment cannot deliver instantiation
Non-negotiables	Both forms of Anselm; Descartes; Gaunilo; Kant; the modal repair and its possibility-premise burden

Model answer (~240 words)

The ontological argument claims a unique entailment: that the very concept of God contains, and therefore yields, God's existence. Anselm defines God as **"that than which nothing greater can be conceived"**, where "greater" means more perfect. In *Proslogion* 2 he argues by *reductio*: if this being existed only in the understanding, a greater

could be conceived - namely the same being existing in reality as well - which contradicts the definition. In *Proslogion* 3 the claim is strengthened: a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater than one that can; God therefore exists **necessarily**, by aseity. Descartes recasts this through essence-containment: existence belongs to a supremely perfect being as three angles belong to a triangle.

The entailment fails at a precise point. **Gaunilo's** perfect-island parody shows the form proves too much; Anselm replies that only God is defined with necessary, non-contingent existence, which an island by definition lacks. That reply protects the second form but shifts the burden onto the coherence of maximal greatness. **Kant's** objection is decisive: existence is not a real predicate. A hundred real thalers contain no more concept than a hundred possible ones; existence posits an object rather than enriching a concept. Chatterjee and Datta restate this in the Indian idiom of a hundred rupees imagined in one's pocket.

Modal reconstructions retain necessary existence but transfer the whole weight to the **possibility premise**, which a parallel possibility-of-non-existence can offset.

Verdict: the concept entails existence **hypothetically**, not **actually**. Conceptual analysis yields a conditional, never an instantiation.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- **Structure:** state the entailment claim -> both Anselmian forms -> Descartes -> Gaunilo and reply -> Kant -> modal repair -> conditional verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *aliquid quo nihil maius cogitari possit*; aseity; necessary versus contingent existence.
- **Argument:** the *reductio* must be reproduced as steps, not paraphrased as a slogan.
- **Distinction:** conceptual entailment versus instantiation; Anselm's comparative form versus Descartes' essence-containment form.
- **Technical terms:** real predicate, determining predicate, necessary existence, possibility premise.
- **Criticism:** Gaunilo attacks the *form*; Kant attacks the *logic of existence*. Do not merge them.
- **Comparison:** one line noting that Indian philosophy has no a priori analogue, for *pramāṇa*-theoretic reasons.
- **Conclusion:** a conditional entailment verdict - the strongest available and the one the question invites.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : State the entailment claim precisely
 4 min : Proslogion 2 and 3 as numbered steps; Descartes
 3 min : Gaunilo + Anselm's reply; note the shifted burden
 3 min : Kant - existence is not a real predicate; thaler illustration
 2 min : Modal repair; possibility-premise burden
 1 min : Verdict - hypothetical entailment, not instantiation
 Total : 14 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing only *Proslogion* 2 and omitting necessary existence: **loses Anselm's reply to Gaunilo entirely**.
- Attributing the island to Kant or the thaler to Gaunilo: **factual error, heavily penalised**.
- Answering "yes, God exists" or "no, God does not exist": **the question is about entailment, not theology**.
- Importing the cosmological argument: **out of scope**.
- Saying the modal version "refutes Kant": **overstatement; the burden merely migrates**.
- Concluding without distinguishing conceptual from actual entailment: **the whole point of the question missed**.

PYQ 2 - 2018, Q8(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Compare St. Thomas Aquinas' five ways of knowing God with the arguments of the Nyāya School of Indian Philosophy for the existence of God."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Compare</i> - a sustained axis-by-axis comparison, not two separate essays

Element	Requirement
Core issue	Whether two independent a posteriori natural theologies reach the same God by the same route
Scope boundary	Both sets of arguments must be reconstructed; neither may be reduced to a label
Ideal thesis	Structural convergence in inferring intelligence from order; decisive divergence over material causation and the role of karma
Non-negotiables	All five Ways named; at least four Nyāya arguments named in Sanskrit; the efficient/material cause distinction

Model answer (≈345 words)

Aquinas and the Naiyāyikas both practise a **a posteriori** natural theology: each begins from a general feature of the world and argues to an ultimate intelligent reality. Their convergence is real, and so is their divergence.

Aquinas' **Five Ways** (Summa Theologiae I, q.2, a.3) argue from change to a prime mover; from efficient causation to a first cause; from contingency to a necessary being; from degrees of perfection to a maximum; and from purposive regularity in non-cognitive nature to a divine intelligence. The regress he excludes is **essentially ordered** - the stick moves the stone only while the hand moves the stick - so "first" means **explanatory priority**, not the earliest event in time.

Nyāya's Īśvara-anumāna proceeds through several routes. **Kāryāt**: composite objects are effects, since they are made of parts (*sāṃyava*) and possess intermediate magnitude (*avāntara-mahattva*); material causes cannot achieve the required order and co-ordination without an intelligent maker, who must be **omniscient**, since only such a being can directly know atoms. **Āyojanāt**: inert atoms need purposive combination. **Dhṛtyādeḥ**: the world's support and dissolution require governance. **Padāt / śruteḥ**: Vedic authority presupposes an omniscient author. Finally, the argument from **adr̥ṣṭa**: the unconscious stock of merit and demerit cannot allot determinate joys and sorrows, so God is **karmaphaladātā**.

The **convergence**: both infer intelligence from order; both add attributes stepwise rather than by definition; both are cumulative rather than single-inference systems, Udayana multiplying routes exactly as Aquinas multiplies Ways.

The **divergence** is decisive. Aquinas' God is the cause of *being*, creating *ex nihilo*; Nyāya's Īśvara is the **efficient cause only**, ordering eternal, uncreated atoms while souls, space, time and *adr̥ṣṭa* remain co-present with Him. Aquinas' proofs are *praeambula fidei* drawn from reason alone; two Nyāya arguments are explicitly scriptural. Aquinas' God is unconditioned; Nyāya's is morally constrained by *adr̥ṣṭa*.

Consequently the critiques differ in weight. Hume's analogy objection strikes Nyāya hardest, since its inference is expressly artefact-modelled on pot and potter; while the redundancy objection - that karma and atoms could operate without a supervisor - is uniquely Indian and, as C. D. Sharma presses it, uniquely damaging.

Verdict: the same inferential architecture, but not the same God: Aquinas' terminus is metaphysically ultimate, Nyāya's is cosmically administrative.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- **Structure**: a comparative frame first, then axis-by-axis treatment - never two disconnected halves.
- **Doctrine**: all five Ways correctly identified; at least four Nyāya routes with Sanskrit terms.
- **Argument**: the essentially ordered series and the *sāṃyava* / *avāntara-mahattva* criteria of effect-hood must both appear.
- **Distinction**: *nimitta-kāraṇa* versus *upādāna-kāraṇa*; explanatory versus temporal priority.
- **Technical terms**: *kāryāt*, *āyojanāt*, *dhṛtyādeḥ*, *padāt*, *śruteḥ*, *adr̥ṣṭa*, *karmaphaladātā*, *praeambula fidei*.
- **Comparison**: the Janet-Lotze-Martineau parallel, plus the observation that Western theists make God the source of existence and Nyāya only of order.
- **Criticism**: Hume's analogy objection on Nyāya; the redundancy objection; Kant's ontological-borrowing charge on Aquinas.
- **Conclusion**: same architecture, different terminus - stated as a criterion-named judgement.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Comparative frame - two a posteriori natural theologies
 4 min : Five Ways, with the per se series and "first = explanatory"
 5 min : Nyaya routes with Sanskrit terms and the omniscience step
 3 min : Convergence - inference from order; cumulative structure
 4 min : Divergence - material causation, scripture, moral constraint
 2 min : Differential critique - Hume on Nyaya; redundancy; Kant on Aquinas
 1 min : Criterion-named verdict
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing Aquinas for ten minutes and Nyāya for ten with no comparison: **the directive is unanswered; heavy loss.**
- Calling Nyāya's God the material cause: **the topic's most penalised factual error.**
- Reducing the Five Ways to "first cause": **collapses four distinct arguments.**
- Omitting Sanskrit terminology: **loses the Optional's technical premium.**
- Claiming Nyāya is "the Indian Aquinas" without qualification: **false equivalence.**
- Ending with "both are similar": **an ungraded conclusion earns no evaluative marks.**

PYQ 3 - 2018, Q8(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"Critically evaluate the Buddhistic arguments against the existence of God as the creator of the world."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically evaluate</i> - state the arguments, then judge their force, including where they fail
Core issue	Whether conditioned arising renders a creator explanatorily and morally unnecessary
Scope boundary	The target is <i>jagat-kartā</i> , a world-maker; Buddhism's rejection of the sacred is not at issue
Ideal thesis	The arguments are decisive against an anthropomorphic purposive world-maker, weaker against a metaphysically refined classical theism
Non-negotiables	At least four canonical lines, plus the theistic replies

Model answer (≈245 words)

Buddhism rejects a creator God (*jagat-kartā*) without rejecting spiritual ultimacy; its critique is a systematic refusal of **explanatory surplus** rather than bare atheism.

Four canonical lines recur. First, if God is **eternal and unchanging**, genuine creation is hard to explain, since willing or producing appears to involve change; Dharmakīrti-type reasoning sharpens this - a permanent, immutable cause fully present at all times should produce its effect always and at once, never in temporal succession. Second, if God creates **from desire or purpose**, this implies lack, preference or incompleteness, which is inconsistent with perfection. Third, **suffering and evil** sit uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator. Fourth, **dependent origination** already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, so a creator is redundant. To these may be added the methodological point that questions of a first beginning fall among the *avyākṛta*, undeclared because soteriologically idle - the wounded man who insists on knowing the archer before the arrow is removed.

Evaluation must be even-handed. The change objection assumes a **temporal model of divine willing**; classical theism answers with a single eternal act producing a temporal effect. The desire objection assumes creation must remedy a lack; theists appeal to gratuitous diffusive goodness. Most importantly, Nyāya replies that dependent origination explains **sequence** but not **desert-appropriate allocation**: an unconscious nexus cannot proportion determinate fruit to determinate merit. Explanatory economy, moreover, is a methodological preference, not a disproof.

Verdict: Buddhism establishes that a coherent, ethically serious cosmology is possible without a creator. That is a substantial philosophical achievement - but it shifts the burden of proof rather than closing the question.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- **Structure:** clarify the target -> four to six arguments as reconstructions -> theistic replies -> graded verdict.

- **Doctrine:** *pratītyasamutpāda*; the *avyākṛta* questions; anti-*Īśvara* argumentation in Dharmakīrti and Śāntarakṣita.
- **Argument:** the immutability-succession incompatibility must be stated as an argument, not as an assertion.
- **Distinction:** rejecting a creator ≠ atheism in the Western sense; *nāstika* = denier of Vedic authority.
- **Technical terms:** *jagat-kartā*, *pratītyasamutpāda*, *avyākṛta*, explanatory parsimony.
- **Comparison:** one line linking Buddhist economy to Hume's Epicurean hypothesis and Darwinian sufficiency.
- **Criticism:** the Nyāya allocation reply is the strongest counter and must appear.
- **Conclusion:** decisive against a purposive anthropomorphic maker; inconclusive against refined theism.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Clarify the target - jagat-karta, not the sacred
 6 min : Immutability/succession · desire implies lack · evil ·
 dependent origination · avyakṛta silence · freedom-karma dilemma
 4 min : Replies - eternal act, diffusive goodness, Nyaya on allocation,
 economy is methodological
 2 min : Note that nastika means denial of Vedic authority
 1 min : Graded verdict
 Total : 14 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Treating the arguments as a proof of atheism: **misstates their logical status**.
- Writing a devotional account of the Buddha instead of arguments: **no philosophical content**.
- Omitting the replies in a "critically evaluate" question: **the directive is half-answered**.
- Calling Buddhism *nāstika* in the sense of "spiritually nihilistic": **terminological error**.
- Confusing the Buddhist argument from evil with the full problem of evil: **scope drift**.
- Ending with "hence God does not exist": **unwarranted and penalised**.

PYQ 4 - 2019, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact question

"State and evaluate the proofs for the existence of God as propounded in Jainism."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>State and evaluate</i> - exposition plus judgement, in 150 words
Core issue	In what sense Jainism has a God at all, and what it proves about that God
Scope boundary	Do not write a general essay on Jaina metaphysics
Ideal thesis	Jainism denies God as creator but affirms godhead ; its proofs establish attainable perfection, not a cosmic maker
Non-negotiables	The denial/affirmation disambiguation; at least two positive proofs; one evaluative limit

Model answer (≈160 words)

Jainism denies God as **creator**: the world was never created, since all substances are eternal and change only through modes (*utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya*). But **"Jainism denies God, and yet does not deny godhead. Every liberated soul is a god."**

Its proofs are accordingly proofs of attainable divinity. First, from the **intrinsic nature of the jīva**: every soul possesses infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and power (*ananta-catuṣṭaya*), obscured by material karma rather than absent - for we observe degrees of knowledge, not its absence. Second, from **gradation to a limiting case**: *matī*, *śrūta*, *avadhi* and *manaḥparyāya* mark progressive removal of karmic obstruction, whose complete removal is **kevala-jñāna**, omniscience. Third, from the **testimony of the omniscient Tirthaṅkaras** (*āpta-vacana*), mortals who won liberation by personal effort - "we are all potential Jinas".

Evaluation: these establish a plural, achieved, non-creative godhood and rest wholly on Jaina premises - intrinsic omniscience and material karma. They neither prove nor attempt a cosmic God. Sharma's dilemma bites: if karma is

inseparable from the soul, liberation is impossible; if separable, bondage is.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- **Structure:** disambiguate "God" -> three proofs -> one internal criticism -> verdict, all within 150 words.
- **Doctrine:** *ananta-catuṣṭaya*; the five knowledges; *kevala-jñāna*; *siddha* and Tīrthaṅkara.
- **Argument:** the gradation-to-limiting-case inference must be visible as an inference.
- **Distinction:** God as world-maker versus God as perfected being; Jaina karma is **material (pudgala)**, not *adrṣṭa*.
- **Technical terms:** *utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya*, *āpta-vacana*, *tri-ratna*, *nāstika* correctly glossed.
- **Comparison:** one clause contrasting this with Nyāya's efficient-cause creator.
- **Criticism:** the bondage/liberation dilemma, or the internality of the premises.
- **Conclusion:** a soteriological rather than cosmological theism.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Denies creator, affirms godhead - the controlling distinction
4 min : Three proofs, compressed but as arguments
2 min : Evaluation - premises internal to Jaina metaphysics; Sharma's dilemma
1 min : Verdict - soteriological, not cosmological, theism
Total : 8 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing "Jainism is atheistic, so there are no proofs": **misreads the question and forfeits most marks.**
- Substituting a general account of *anekāntavāda* or the *tri-ratna*: **off-question.**
- Equating Jaina karma with Nyāya's *adrṣṭa*: **doctrinal error.**
- Calling the *siddha* a creator or governor: **contradicts the doctrine.**
- Exceeding the word limit at the cost of the evaluation: **the second directive verb is lost.**

PYQ 5 - 2020, Q6(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Is the ontological proof for the existence of God by St. Anselm logical? Discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Discuss</i> an evaluative question - you must take a position on logicality , not merely on truth
Core issue	Whether the argument is formally valid, and whether its validity is purchased by an illegitimate use of "exists"
Scope boundary	Anselm centrally; Descartes and modal versions only as extensions
Ideal thesis	The argument is formally coherent as a reductio , but it is not <i>logically compelling</i> , because its crucial premise misclassifies existence
Non-negotiables	Both forms; the validity/soundness distinction; Gaunilo; Kant; a stated verdict

Model answer (≈350 words)

Whether Anselm's proof is "logical" must be split into two questions: is it **valid**, and is its key premise **legitimate**?

Anselm's *Proslogion* 2 argument is a *reductio*. Suppose that than which nothing greater can be conceived exists in the understanding alone. Existing in reality is greater than existing in the understanding alone. Then a greater than the greatest conceivable could be conceived - a contradiction. Therefore it exists in reality. Formally this is impeccable: given the definition and the comparative premise, the conclusion follows. *Proslogion* 3 strengthens it: a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater than one that can, so God exists **necessarily**; since God as infinitely perfect is not limited by time, both coming-to-be and ceasing-to-be are excluded.

The difficulty is not the inference but the **comparative premise**. Gaunilo, in *In Behalf of the Fool*, constructs a parallel for the most perfect conceivable island; if the form is valid, it manufactures islands. Anselm replies that only God is defined as having eternal and independent existence, whereas an island - a piece of land surrounded by water - is by

definition contingent and can without contradiction be thought not to exist. The reply succeeds for the second form, but it transfers the burden: it must now be shown that **maximal greatness is a coherent notion with an intrinsic maximum**, whereas island-perfections plainly are not.

Kant supplies the decisive diagnosis. Existence is not a real predicate: it adds nothing to a concept but posits its object. A hundred real thalers contain no more concept than a hundred possible ones. If so, "existing in reality is greater" is not a legitimate comparison of concepts at all, and the argument is valid only in the trivial sense that it correctly draws out what was illicitly built in. Modern quantificational analysis reinforces this by treating existence as second-order.

Modal reconstructions by Malcolm, Hartshorne and Plantinga preserve necessary existence and are formally valid in S5; but their **possibility premise** - that a maximally great being is possible - is precisely what is disputed, and a symmetrical possibility-of-non-existence yields the opposite conclusion.

Verdict: Anselm's proof is **logically well-formed but not logically compelling**. It is valid in form, question-begging in premise, and at best establishes a conditional: if a maximally great being is possible, it exists necessarily.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- **Structure:** split "logical" into validity and legitimacy -> both forms -> Gaunilo -> Kant -> modal -> explicit verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the *reductio* structure; aseity; necessary existence.
- **Argument:** the comparative premise must be isolated as the load-bearing step.
- **Distinction:** validity versus soundness; a well-formed argument versus a compelling one.
- **Technical terms:** real predicate, determining predicate, S5, possibility premise, second-order quantification.
- **Comparison:** one line noting Chatterjee-Datta's parallel hundred-rupees formulation in the Indian tradition.
- **Criticism:** Gaunilo attacks the form's generality; Kant attacks the concept of existence. Both are needed.
- **Conclusion:** an explicit, defended answer to "is it logical?" - hedging is penalised here more than anywhere else in this topic.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Split the question - valid? legitimate premise?
 5 min : Proslogion 2 as a reductio; Proslogion 3 and necessary existence
 4 min : Gaunilo, Anselm's reply, and the transferred burden
 5 min : Kant's diagnosis; the quantificational reinforcement
 3 min : Modal versions and the possibility premise
 2 min : Explicit verdict - well-formed, not compelling
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Answering "no, because God cannot be proved": **does not engage logicity at all**.
- Treating validity and soundness as one thing: **the question's whole hinge is missed**.
- Omitting *Proslogion* 3: **Anselm's reply to Gaunilo becomes unintelligible**.
- Presenting Kant's objection as "Kant said God does not exist": **serious misattribution**.
- Refusing to give a verdict: **"Discuss" with an evaluative stem requires a position**.

PYQ 6 - 2021, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"Give a critical account of moral argument to prove the existence of God."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critical account</i> - full exposition plus sustained criticism
Core issue	Whether moral experience can establish, or rationally require, belief in God
Scope boundary	Both forms of the moral argument; the other proofs only as contrast

Element	Requirement
Ideal thesis	The inferential form begs the question; Kant's postulational form is defensible but is not a proof
Non-negotiables	Kant's three postulates; the highest good; "ought implies can"; Euthyphro correctly aimed

Model answer (~250 words)

The moral argument claims that ethical experience presupposes the reality of God. It takes two very different forms.

The **first form** is a straightforward inference: from objective moral laws to a divine Law Giver, or from conscience to a God whose voice it is. Newman's Grammar of Assent argues that feeling shame and fear before conscience implies One before whom we are ashamed. The objection is fatal: this assumes that moral values admit of **no naturalistic explanation** in terms of human needs, social structure or practical reason. That assumption is precisely what is in dispute, so the argument **begs the question**.

The **second form**, Kant's, is not strictly a proof. Having demolished the speculative proofs in the *Critique of Pure Reason* - the ontological by denying that existence is a real predicate, the cosmological by showing it borrows the ontological - Kant reinstates God in the *Critique of Practical Reason*. The moral law obligates us to promote the **highest good**, virtue together with proportionate happiness. "Ought implies can" requires that the highest good be really possible. But holiness is unattainable in finite time, and nature does not proportion happiness to desert. Hence three **postulates of practical reason**: freedom, immortality and God - objects of rational faith, practically necessary and theoretically undemonstrable.

Criticism cuts several ways. The postulate may be a projection of a desire for cosmic fairness, though Kant answers that it arises from the structure of moral reason, not from reward-seeking, which would be heteronomy. If morality is autonomous, God's role is confined to realisability, not obligation - which also insulates Kant from the **Euthyphro dilemma**, whose real target is divine-command theory. Adequacy remains the deepest problem: as Hick notes, moral values cannot be said to point all the way to the infinite, self-existent personal creator.

Verdict: as a proof it fails, and Kant never offered it as one; as an account of what moral seriousness rationally presupposes, it retains genuine force. Nyāya's *karmaphaladātā* addresses the same problem but claims knowledge where Kant claims only hope.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- **Structure:** two forms distinguished -> Kant's derivation as steps -> four to five criticisms -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *summum bonum*; the three postulates; *Vernunftglaube*; autonomy.
- **Argument:** "ought implies can" must be shown doing work, not merely quoted.
- **Distinction:** postulate versus demonstration versus empirical hypothesis.
- **Technical terms:** heteronomy, practical reason, fact of reason, Euthyphro.
- **Comparison:** the Nyāya *karmaphaladātā* parallel, with the epistemic contrast.
- **Criticism:** projection, autonomy tension, adequacy; and Euthyphro aimed at divine-command theory, not Kant.
- **Conclusion:** it establishes a rational hope, not a demonstrated being.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Two forms flagged at once
2 min : Newman's inferential form and the question-begging objection
5 min : Kant - CPR demolition, then the highest good and three postulates
4 min : Criticism - projection, autonomy, Euthyphro's real target, adequacy
2 min : Nyaya comparison
1 min : Graded verdict
Total : 15 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing "Kant proves God through morality": **the single most penalised error in this topic**.
- Listing only one postulate: **loses the systematic structure**.
- Aiming Euthyphro at Kant: **misapplied objection**.
- Treating the postulate as a reward-motive: **contradicts Kant's own doctrine of autonomy**.

- Omitting the first form entirely: **"critical account" of the moral argument requires both.**
- Omitting any Indian comparison in a Paper II answer: **loses the comparative premium.**

PYQ 7 - 2022, Q6(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Present a critical exposition of different arguments offered by St. Thomas Aquinas to prove the existence of God also known as 'Five Ways'. Which one of them do you find philosophically most interesting? Give reasons in support of your answer."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two directives: <i>critical exposition</i> of all five, and a defended personal judgement
Core issue	Whether the Ways are distinct arguments, and which best withstands scrutiny
Scope boundary	All five must appear; the chosen Way must then be developed further
Ideal thesis	The Ways are five distinct arguments; Way 3 (or Way 5) is most interesting, for stated philosophical reasons
Non-negotiables	The <i>per se / per accidens</i> distinction; "first" as explanatory; a reasoned choice with objections handled

Model answer (≈350 words)

Aquinas' Five Ways (ST I, q.2, a.3) are **five distinct a posteriori arguments**, not one argument restated. Each begins from a general feature of the world and concludes with the cautious formula "and this everyone understands to be God" - itself an admission that further work is needed to identify the terminus with the God of religion.

Way 1 argues from motion, understood as the reduction of potentiality to actuality: whatever is moved is moved by another, and an essentially ordered series of movers cannot regress infinitely, so there is an unmoved mover. **Way 2** argues from an order of efficient causes to a first efficient cause. **Way 3** argues from contingency: if everything were merely possible, at some time nothing would have existed, and nothing would exist now; hence there is a necessary being, and ultimately one necessary of itself. **Way 4** argues from degrees of goodness and truth to a maximum which causes all perfection. **Way 5** argues from the regular goal-directed activity of things lacking cognition to a directing intelligence, as the arrow is directed by the archer.

Critically, the excluded regress is **essentially ordered** - the stick moves the stone only while the hand moves the stick - so "first" denotes **explanatory priority**, not chronological firstness. Aquinas himself concedes the difficulty of excluding an endless series of *events*, and holds that the world's temporal beginning is known by faith, not demonstration; neo-Thomists accordingly recast the excluded series as simultaneous dependence. Way 3 is vulnerable to a quantifier shift at the step from "each thing at some time is not" to "at some time nothing is". Way 4 requires the Platonic machinery of participation, since degrees of heat do not entail a hottest object. Way 5 is exposed to Hume's analogy objection and, in Paley's later form, to Darwin. Kant's overarching charge is that the passage from "a necessary being" to "the most real being" is the ontological argument in disguise.

Most interesting: Way 3. It alone poses the deepest question - why is there anything at all rather than nothing? - and it is the only Way whose central premise, the Principle of Sufficient Reason, remains a live philosophical dispute against brute-fact naturalism. Its conclusion is also modally strongest: not merely a first mover but a being whose non-existence is impossible. That it is simultaneously the most vulnerable, at the quantifier-shift step, makes it philosophically the richest rather than the weakest - a bad argument for the best question is more instructive than a safe argument for a smaller one.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- **Structure:** all five expounded compactly -> critical apparatus -> a defended choice with its own objection answered.
- **Doctrine:** act and potency; *per se* causal series; contingency and necessity; participation.
- **Argument:** each Way in one or two premise-steps, never as a bare label.

- **Distinction:** explanatory versus temporal priority; Way 2 (causal dependence) versus Way 3 (modal status).
- **Technical terms:** *per se* / *per accidens*, PSR, *ab alio* / *a se*, quantifier shift.
- **Comparison:** one line on Nyāya's parallel cumulative structure, or on the Kalām's contrasting temporal claim.
- **Criticism:** Hume, Kant and one internal weakness per Way where space allows.
- **Conclusion:** the personal judgement must be argued, with a criterion named - depth of question, modal strength, or contemporary liveness.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Frame - five distinct a posteriori arguments
 7 min : Ways 1-5, each as premises
 5 min : Critical apparatus - per se series, Aquinas on eternity, quantifier shift, participation, Hume/Darwin, Kant
 5 min : The chosen Way, defended, with one objection met
 2 min : Conclusion naming the criterion of choice
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Presenting the Ways as one "first cause" argument: **destroys the exposition mark.**
- Choosing a Way but giving no philosophical reasons: **the second directive is unanswered.**
- Choosing Way 2 and glossing it as "God started the universe": **misrepresents Aquinas.**
- Introducing Paley's watch as Aquinas': **factual error.**
- Asserting that Aquinas proves a temporal beginning: **contradicts ST I q.46 a.2.**
- Omitting all criticism in a "critical exposition": **half the directive lost.**

PYQ 8 - 2022, Q8(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Discuss the main points of distinction between a priori and a posteriori arguments for the existence of God. Which one according to you should be preferred over the other? Give reasons and justifications for your answer."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Discuss</i> the distinction, and defend a preference with reasons
Core issue	The trade-off between modal strength and evidential contact
Scope boundary	Use exemplars from both families, Indian and Western; do not merely define
Ideal thesis	A criterion-relative preference: a posteriori for evidential respectability, a priori for modal strength, neither for religious adequacy
Non-negotiables	A multi-axis distinction table in prose; at least three exemplars; an explicit preference

Model answer (≈345 words)

The distinction is not merely one of subject matter but of **evidential source, method, modal outcome and characteristic vulnerability.**

An **a priori** argument reasons from the concept of God alone, without empirical premises. The ontological argument is the sole classical instance: Anselm derives existence, and then necessary existence, from the concept of that than which nothing greater can be conceived; Descartes derives it from the essence of a supremely perfect being. Its method is conceptual analysis, and its promised reward is enormous - if it works, it yields a **necessary** God, immune to empirical revision.

An **a posteriori** argument reasons from some general feature of the world. Aquinas' Ways begin from motion, causation, contingency, degrees and purposive order; Paley begins from means-end adjustment; Kant's moral argument begins from the structure of moral obligation; and Nyāya's Īśvara-anumāna begins from the world as a composite effect requiring an omniscient intelligent maker. Their method is inference from effect to cause, or inference

to the best explanation, and their conclusions are correspondingly **probable** rather than necessary.

Their vulnerabilities differ accordingly. The a priori route faces Kant's charge that existence is not a real predicate, and Gaunilo's demonstration that the form proves too much; modal repairs shift the burden to an unestablished possibility premise. The a posteriori route faces Hume: the world-artefact analogy is weak, and from a finite effect one may infer only a finite cause. It is also exposed to scientific advance - Darwin against Paley, cosmological alternatives against the Kalām - whereas the a priori route is immune to empirical developments precisely because it is empirically empty.

Preference. I prefer the **a posteriori** route, on three grounds. First, **dialectical**: it begins from premises the opponent already grants - that things change, that order exists, that we are obligated - whereas the a priori route asks the opponent to grant a contested concept. Second, **epistemic**: it does not require the illegitimate treatment of existence as a determining predicate. Third, **traditional convergence**: two independent civilisations, Thomist Europe and Nyāya India, arrived at structurally similar a posteriori arguments, which suggests the route tracks something real in the explanatory demand.

But the preference must be **graded**. The price is that a posteriori arguments deliver at most a probable, possibly finite cause, and never the God of developed religion. If the criterion were modal strength rather than evidential contact, the ranking would reverse. **Neither route alone secures religious adequacy** - which is why every tradition eventually supplements proof with experience, testimony or faith.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- **Structure**: multi-axis distinction -> exemplars on both sides -> differential vulnerabilities -> a preference with three named reasons -> a graded qualification.
- **Doctrine**: ontological versus cosmological/teleological/moral/Nyāya families.
- **Argument**: the trade-off between modal strength and evidential contact must be made explicit.
- **Distinction**: conceptual entailment versus inference to a cause; necessity versus probability.
- **Technical terms**: real predicate, *vyāpti*, inference to the best explanation, underdetermination.
- **Comparison**: Nyāya must appear as an a posteriori exemplar - this is a Paper II answer.
- **Criticism**: Kant and Gaunilo on one side; Hume and Darwin on the other.
- **Conclusion**: criterion-relative preference, explicitly named, never a bare "both are useful".

Compact skeleton and timing

3 min : Four axes of distinction - source, method, modality, vulnerability
5 min : A priori exemplars - Anselm, Descartes, and the modal repair
5 min : A posteriori exemplars - Ways, Paley, Kant, Nyaya
3 min : Differential vulnerabilities
4 min : Preference with three reasons
1 min : Graded qualification naming the alternative criterion
Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Defining the terms and stopping: **the second directive is ignored**.
- Equating a priori with "certain" and a posteriori with "uncertain": **conceptual error**.
- Omitting Nyāya: **a Paper II answer with no Indian material is under-marked**.
- Preferring one without naming a criterion: **an unjustified preference**.
- Claiming a priori arguments are Western and a posteriori Indian: **historically false**.
- Concluding "both are equally good": **fails the explicit demand for a preference**.

PYQ 9 - 2023, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Critically examine the arguments of Nyāya for the existence of God."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically examine</i> - full reconstruction, then rigorous evaluation

Element	Requirement
Core issue	Whether Nyāya's inferences establish an omniscient efficient cause
Scope boundary	The arguments , though a brief statement of the nature of Īśvara is needed to make them intelligible
Ideal thesis	Individually inconclusive and jointly cumulative; the redundancy objection is the deepest threat
Non-negotiables	Four to five arguments in Sanskrit; the efficient/material cause thesis; Indian critics before Western ones

Model answer (≈350 words)

Nyāya offers a rational, inferential theism. Īśvara is an eternal, omniscient special self, the **first efficient cause** - a demiurgus or builder of the ordered universe - **not its material cause**; He is also preserver and destroyer, which distinguishes Nyāya theism from deism.

Kāryāt - the causal argument. All composite objects of the world are effects, since they are made of parts (*sāvayava*) and possess intermediate magnitude (*avāntara-mahattva*); space, time, ether and self are excluded as partless infinities, and atoms and *manas* as simple infinitesimals. Material causes alone cannot attain the order, direction and co-ordination that produce such effects. The intelligent cause must therefore have direct knowledge of the atoms, a desire for an end, and the will to realise it - and must be **omniscient**, since only an omniscient being can directly know entities so simple and infinitesimal as atoms.

Āyojanāt - inert atoms cannot combine purposively of themselves. **Dhṛtyādeḥ** - the world's support, maintenance and dissolution require governance. **Padāt / āptaprāmāṇya** - the Veda's authority derives from an omniscient author, as a science's authority derives from its founder; the jīva cannot be that author, since supramundane realities exceed ordinary cognition. **Śruteḥ** - scripture directly testifies to God. Finally, the argument from **adrṣṭa**: differences of lot require causes; karma supplies them; but the time-gap requires a persisting stock of merit and demerit; and adrṣṭa, being **unintelligent**, cannot allot precisely the joy and sorrow deserved, while individual selves neither know nor control it. Hence God is *karmaphaladātā*.

Critically: the **circularity** charge against the last two arguments is answered by distinguishing the order of existence (God creates the Veda) from the order of knowledge (the Veda discloses God); the **bodiless-agent** objection is met by a dilemma. But the deeper objections stand. Mīmāṃsā holds the Veda *apauruṣeya* and *apūrva* self-maturing, which dissolves two arguments at once. Buddhism and Jainism hold that conditions and material karma suffice. Cārvāka denies inference's reach. Śāṅkara presses a dilemma on whether atoms are active or inactive, and treats Nyāya's God as merely *saguṇa*. C. D. Sharma's redundancy objection is sharpest: this God is "reduced to the status of a supervisor", His hands and feet "chained by the shackles of the Law of Karma unfolding itself as the *Adrṣṭa*".

Verdict: the arguments are individually inconclusive but cumulatively serious, in Udayana's manner. They share the limits of all a posteriori theism - Chatterjee and Datta themselves conclude, with Kant and Lotze, that God cannot be deduced from anterior premises and must be known through direct experience.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- **Structure:** nature of Īśvara in two lines -> four to five arguments as reconstructions -> internal replies -> external critiques -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** efficient not material cause; *ṣaḍ-aiśvarya*; *prayojaka kartā*; *karmaphaladātā*.
- **Argument:** the *sāvayava* / *avāntara-mahattva* criteria and the derivation of omniscience must both be present.
- **Distinction:** order of existence versus order of knowledge; theism versus deism.
- **Technical terms:** *kāryāt*, *āyojanāt*, *dhṛtyādeḥ*, *padāt*, *śruteḥ*, *adrṣṭa*, *apauruṣeya*, *apūrva*, *saguṇa*.
- **Comparison:** Janet, Lotze and Martineau as parallels - with the divergence over existence versus order.
- **Criticism:** Indian critics first (Mīmāṃsā, Buddhist, Jaina, Cārvāka, Advaita), then the redundancy objection.
- **Conclusion:** cumulative but not demonstrative; note the textbook tradition's own experiential turn.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Īśvara - efficient cause, preserver, destroyer; theism not deism

7 min : Karyat (with omniscience derivation), ayojanat, dhrtiyadeh, padat/sruteh, adrsta
 4 min : Internal replies - circularity, bodiless agent
 5 min : External critiques - Mimamsa, Bauddha, Jaina, Carvaka, Sankara, Sharma's redundancy
 3 min : Graded verdict + Chatterjee-Datta's experiential conclusion
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Calling God the material cause: **the single worst error available here.**
- Listing the proofs without reconstructing any: **descriptive, not analytical.**
- Using only Hume and Kant as critics: **ignores the Indian debate the question presupposes.**
- Conceding the Veda-God circularity: **the classical reply exists and should be given.**
- Confusing *adr̥ṣṭa* with Jaina material karma: **doctrinal error.**
- Concluding "hence Nyāya proves God": **ungraded and indefensible.**

PYQ 10 - 2024, Q7(c), 15 marks (10 + 5)

Exact question

"Present an exposition of ontological proof for the existence of God along with its criticism."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Explicitly split: 10 marks exposition + 5 marks criticism
Core issue	Faithful reconstruction, then targeted objection
Scope boundary	Allocate roughly two-thirds of the space to exposition
Ideal thesis	A clear reconstruction of both Anselmian forms and Descartes, criticised through Gaunilo and Kant
Non-negotiables	The mark split must be visibly respected in the answer's proportions

Model answer (~250 words)

Exposition (10). The ontological proof is the sole classical **a priori** argument: it moves from the concept of God to God's existence without any empirical premise. Anselm defines God as **"that than which nothing greater can be conceived"**, where "greater" means more perfect - and deliberately not as "the most perfect being that there is", which would guarantee nothing. In *Proslogion* 2 he argues by *reductio*: even the fool who denies God understands the concept; but if this being existed in the understanding alone, we could conceive a greater - the same being existing in reality as well - which contradicts the definition; therefore it exists in reality. In *Proslogion* 3 he strengthens the conclusion: a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater than one that can; and since God as infinitely perfect is not limited by time, both coming-to-be and ceasing-to-be are excluded. God therefore exists **necessarily**, by aseity. Descartes reformulates it in *Meditations* V: existence belongs to the essence of a supremely perfect being as three angles belong to a triangle, or a valley to a mountain; a perfect being lacking existence would lack a perfection.

Criticism (5). **Gaunilo**, in *In Behalf of the Fool*, parodies the form with the most perfect conceivable island; Anselm replies that only God is defined with necessary existence, an island being by definition contingent - but the reply then requires that maximal greatness be coherent. **Kant's** objection is decisive: existence is not a real predicate; a hundred real thalers add no concept to a hundred possible ones. Modal repairs preserve validity but relocate the burden onto an unestablished **possibility premise**.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- **Structure:** the 10 + 5 split must be visible, ideally with the exposition twice the length of the criticism.
- **Doctrine:** both Anselmian forms plus Descartes; the fool; aseity.
- **Argument:** the *reductio* reproduced as steps.
- **Distinction:** "greatest conceivable" versus "greatest that there is" - a mark-winning nuance.
- **Technical terms:** real predicate, necessary existence, possibility premise.

- **Comparison:** optional single line that Indian philosophy has no a priori analogue.
- **Criticism:** Gaunilo on form, Kant on the concept of existence - both, in that order.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives: a conditional, not an instantiation.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : A priori status and Anselm's definition, precisely worded
 5 min : Proslogion 2, then Proslogion 3; then Descartes
 1 min : Note the "conceivable" vs "that there is" nuance
 4 min : Gaunilo + reply; Kant; modal burden
 1 min : What survives - a conditional
 Total : 12 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Ignoring the 10 + 5 split and writing a balanced essay: **structural penalty**.
- Giving criticism first: **inverts the stated weighting**.
- Reproducing only Descartes: **the question says "ontological proof", whose primary text is Anselm**.
- Confusing Gaunilo's and Kant's objections: **factual error**.
- Omitting *Proslogion* 3: **the reply to Gaunilo cannot then be stated**.

PYQ 11 - 2025, Q6(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"Present an account of Design argument to prove the existence of God along with its criticism by David Hume."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Exposition plus a named critic - Hume specifically, not general criticism
Core issue	Whether order and adaptation license an inference to an intelligent, single, infinite, good designer
Scope boundary	Hume must dominate the critical half; Darwin and fine-tuning are extensions, not substitutes
Ideal thesis	Hume defeats the argument as a demonstration and blocks the passage to the God of theism, without disproving a designer
Non-negotiables	Aquinas' Way 5 distinguished from Paley; Paley's three riders; at least four Hume fronts; the 1779/1802 chronology

Model answer (≈355 words)

The design or teleological argument runs from Plato's *Timaeus* through Aquinas to the modern period. Two forms must be distinguished. **Aquinas' Fifth Way** argues that things lacking cognition act for an end, and do so always or nearly always in the same way; such directedness cannot be chance, so they are directed by an intelligent being, as the arrow by the archer. **Paley's** argument, in *Natural Theology* (1802), is instead an **analogy**: finding a watch on a heath, with wheels, cogs, springs and balances all working together to measure time, I cannot attribute it to wind and rain as I could a stone; I must postulate an intelligent maker. Paley adds three riders - the inference survives never having seen a watch made, imperfect working, and parts whose function we cannot discover - and then builds a long **cumulative** case from the eye, the bird's wing, the fish's fin, planetary motion and the seasons.

Hume's critique, in the *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion*, was published in **1779, twenty-three years before Paley**, who took no apparent account of it. It attacks on five fronts. First, **any** universe capable of persisting must display mutual adaptation - there could not be birds with wings unable to live in air - so adaptation is a precondition of order, not evidence of design; Hume offers the **Epicurean hypothesis**, that a finite number of particles in random motion will in unlimited time pass through every combination, one of which is a stable order. Second, the **analogy is weak**: the universe resembles a vegetable or a crustacean as much as a machine, and whether those are designed is the very question at issue. Third, **cause must be proportioned to effect**: from a finite world one may infer only a finite cause - his illustration of the scales, where an unseen weight can be inferred to exceed ten ounces but never to

be infinite. Fourth, the evidence equally supports **many** designers, an inferior one, an infant or senile deity, or an abandoned first attempt. Fifth, **evil and disorder** count against a good and powerful designer.

Darwin later supplies a mechanism that removes Paley's biological premise; Hick's ozone example inverts the intuition, since life fitted itself to the filter rather than the filter to life. Modern fine-tuning arguments relocate design to pre-biological constants, answering Hume's first two fronts while remaining fully exposed to the last three, and facing multiverse rivals.

Verdict: Hume does **not** disprove a designer - Philo himself concedes a remote analogy - but he destroys the argument's demonstrative pretension and blocks the passage from an orderer to the one, infinite, perfectly good God of theism. Design survives only as an inference to the best explanation.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- **Structure:** distinguish the two forms -> Paley in full -> Hume's five fronts -> Darwin and fine-tuning -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** Way 5's archer-arrow; Paley's watch and three riders.
- **Argument:** the analogy must be displayed as an analogy, with its two relata named.
- **Distinction:** Aquinas ≠ Paley ≠ fine-tuning; and evidential objections (fronts 1-2) versus adequacy objections (fronts 3-5).
- **Technical terms:** Epicurean hypothesis, proportioning cause to effect, means-end adjustment, anthropic selection.
- **Comparison:** Nyāya's *āyojanāt* and the pot-potter model as the Indian analogue.
- **Criticism:** Hume must be given in his own examples, not paraphrased generically.
- **Conclusion:** demonstrative failure plus surviving explanatory force, stated as a graded verdict.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Two forms distinguished - Way 5 vs Paley
 5 min : Paley - the watch, three riders, cumulative evidence
 7 min : Hume's five fronts with his own illustrations; note 1779 vs 1802
 3 min : Darwin (ozone) and fine-tuning; exact scope of each
 2 min : Nyaya's ayojanat as Indian analogue
 2 min : Graded verdict - inference to the best explanation
 Total : 21 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Attributing the watch to Aquinas: **factual error, and it wastes the best distinction available.**
- Writing "Hume disproved the design argument": **misstates his conclusion.**
- Giving only two Hume objections in a 20-marker: **thin criticism.**
- Letting Darwin displace Hume: **the question names Hume.**
- Treating fine-tuning as the same argument as Paley's: **category error.**
- Omitting the Indian analogue in Paper II: **loses comparative credit.**

PYQ 12 - 2025, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"What proofs do Nyāya philosophers offer for the existence of God? Discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>What proofs... Discuss</i> - exposition-weighted, with evaluation attached
Core issue	The content and structure of the Nyāya proof-set
Scope boundary	Narrower than 2023's "critically examine": more exposition, less polemic
Ideal thesis	A structured set of mutually reinforcing inferences to an omniscient efficient cause, cumulatively rather than individually persuasive

Element	Requirement
Non-negotiables	Sanskrit terminology; the efficient-cause thesis; a note that enumerations vary; a short evaluation

Model answer (≈250 words)

Nyāya offers not one proof but an array - the tradition claims as many as ten, though enumerations vary across texts and summaries, so an answer should present the principal ones and say so.

Kāryāt, the causal argument, is central. All composite objects - mountains, seas, sun and moon - are effects, since they are made of parts (*sāvayava*) and possess intermediate magnitude (*avāntara-mahattva*). Space, time, ether and self are excluded as partless infinities; atoms and *manas* as simple infinitesimals. Material causes cannot by themselves attain the order and co-ordination required to produce such effects, so an intelligent maker is needed, possessing direct knowledge of the atoms, a desire for an end, and the will to realise it. He must be **omniscient**, since only an omniscient being can directly know entities so simple and infinitesimal as atoms.

Āyojanāt: inert atoms require purposive combination. **Dhṛtyādeḥ**: the world's support, maintenance and destruction imply governance. **Padāt / āptaprāmānya**: the Veda's authority presupposes an omniscient trustworthy author, since no jīva can know supramundane realities. **Śruteḥ**: scripture testifies directly. The argument from **adrṣṭa** completes the set: the unconscious stock of merit and demerit cannot itself allot the precise joy and sorrow deserved, nor do selves know or control it; hence God is *karmaphaladātā*, the impartial dispenser.

Throughout, Īśvara is the **efficient, not material, cause**: atoms are eternal, and God orders rather than produces them; He also preserves and destroys, which makes Nyāya theistic rather than deistic.

Discussion: the proofs are mutually reinforcing in Udayana's cumulative manner, but each is contested - Mīmāṃsā by *apauruṣeya* and *apūrva*, Buddhism and Jainism by karmic sufficiency, Cārvāka by restricting *pramāṇas*. They establish a probable cosmic administrator rather than a demonstrated absolute.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- **Structure**: note the plurality of proofs -> present five or six with Sanskrit names -> state the efficient-cause thesis -> short evaluation.
- **Doctrine**: *sāvayava*, *avāntara-mahattva*, the omniscience derivation, *adrṣṭa*, *karmaphaladātā*.
- **Argument**: *kāryāt* must be a reconstruction; the others may be compressed to one or two lines each.
- **Distinction**: efficient versus material cause; theism versus deism.
- **Technical terms**: all six Sanskrit route-names, correctly glossed.
- **Comparison**: one line on the Western parallels (Janet, Lotze, Martineau) and the existence/order divergence.
- **Criticism**: at least three Indian objectors, briefly.
- **Conclusion**: cumulative persuasiveness with a modest terminus.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Plurality of proofs; enumerations vary
6 min : Kāryāt in full; āyojanāt, dhṛtyādeḥ, padāt/sruteḥ compressed
3 min : Adrṣṭa argument and karmaphaladātā
2 min : Efficient not material cause; theism not deism
2 min : Evaluation - Mīmāṃsā, Bauddha/Jaina, Carvaka; cumulative verdict
Total : 14 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Answering with the *nature* of Nyāya's God instead of the proofs: **question substitution - a distinct 2021 PYQ**.
- Giving only *kāryāt*: **the question says "proofs", plural**.
- Omitting the omniscience derivation: **loses the argument's most distinctive step**.
- Asserting a fixed canonical list of exactly four or exactly ten: **enumerations genuinely vary; say so**.
- No evaluation at all: **"Discuss" requires some**.

Six non-duplicative original Mains models - [CORE ANSWER]

These retained models extend coverage rather than repeat a direct verified PYQ.

Original 10-marker 1

Question: Distinguish an essentially ordered from an accidentally ordered causal series, and explain why the distinction is indispensable to Aquinas' Second Way. (10 marks, 150 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Distinguish and explain why</i> - a conceptual distinction put to argumentative work
Core issue	Why Aquinas may exclude one infinite regress without excluding all
Ideal thesis	The distinction shows that "first" means explanatory, not temporal, priority

Model answer (≈155 words)

An **accidentally ordered (per accidens)** series is one in which each cause, having produced its effect, may perish while the effect continues - as a grandfather begets a father who begets a son. Its members possess causal power in their own right, and an infinite backward series of such causes is not obviously incoherent; Aquinas indeed holds that reason alone cannot exclude an eternal world.

An **essentially ordered (per se)** series is one in which the members act simultaneously and the intermediates possess only **derivative** power: the hand moves the stick, which moves the stone. Remove the hand and the whole series stops at once.

The distinction is indispensable because Aquinas' exclusion of infinite regress applies only to the second kind. An unlimited series of borrowers with no owner explains nothing, since no member supplies non-derivative actualising power. Hence "first cause" denotes **explanatory priority here and now**, not the earliest event in time - which is why the Second Way is not an argument for a temporal beginning.

Top-answer checklist

- Both series named in Latin and illustrated.
- Simultaneity and derivative power identified as the marks of the *per se* series.
- The hand-stick-stone example present.
- "First" explicitly glossed as explanatory.
- One line noting that Aquinas permits an eternal world philosophically.

Original 10-marker 2

Question: "Jainism denies God but not godhead." Examine. (10 marks, 150 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Examine</i> - test the accuracy and implications of the formula
Core issue	Two senses of "God": world-maker and perfected being
Ideal thesis	The formula is accurate: Jainism rejects <i>jagat-kartā</i> and affirms attainable divinity

Model answer (≈160 words)

The formula is accurate and philosophically precise. Jainism denies God as **creator**: the world was never made, since all six substances are eternal and reality is characterised by origination, decay and permanence (*utpāda-vyaya-dhauvya*); change belongs to modes, not to a divine act. It reinforces this with anti-creator arguments - a perfect being can have no motive to create; creation from compassion is refuted by suffering; creation as sport is childish and cruel; and if God is self-existent, the world may equally be so.

Yet **godhead** is affirmed. Every *jīva* intrinsically possesses infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and power, obscured by material karma; complete removal of that obscurity yields *kevala-jñāna*, and the liberated soul is a *siddha* - a

god. The Tīrthaṅkaras were mortals who reached this by personal effort: "we are all potential Jinas."

Jaina divinity is therefore **plural, achieved, non-creative and exemplary**. It answers the soteriological question, not the cosmological one - which is why the label "atheism" misdescribes it.

Top-answer checklist

- The two senses of "God" separated in the opening line.
- *Utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya* cited for the uncreated world.
- At least two anti-creator arguments.
- *Ananta-catuṣṭaya*, *kevala-jñāna*, *siddha* used accurately.
- The closing characterisation: plural, achieved, non-creative, exemplary.

Original 15-marker 1

Question: Does the modal version of the ontological argument escape Kant's objection? Discuss. (15 marks, 240 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Discuss</i> an evaluative question demanding a verdict
Core issue	Whether necessary existence is a modal status immune to the real-predicate objection
Ideal thesis	It escapes the letter of Kant's objection but not its spirit, because the burden migrates to the possibility premise

Model answer (≈250 words)

Kant's objection is that existence is not a real or determining predicate: it adds nothing to a concept but posits its object, as a hundred real thalers add no concept to a hundred possible ones. If so, Anselm's comparative - that existing in reality is *greater* - is illegitimate, and the argument builds its conclusion into its premise.

Modal reconstructions by Malcolm, Hartshorne and, most influentially, Plantinga work exclusively with Anselm's second form. Their claim is that the relevant property is not bare existence but **necessary existence**, a modal status. The argument runs: it is possible that a maximally great being exists; a maximally great being exists necessarily and is maximally excellent in every possible world; what is possibly necessary is, in S5, actually necessary; therefore such a being exists.

This does escape Kant's objection **as stated**: modal status is arguably a genuine property of a being, and the inference does not require existence to enhance a concept.

But it does not escape the objection's **spirit**. The entire weight now falls on the **possibility premise**. A symmetrical premise - that it is possible that no maximally great being exists - yields, in the same modal system, the contradictory conclusion. The premises are thus evidentially on a par, and the argument establishes nothing until it is independently shown that maximal greatness is **coherent**. That is precisely the question Kant's objection was raising in another form: whether the concept of God can be so specified that its analysis yields existence.

Verdict: the modal version converts an objection about the logic of existence into a dispute about the coherence of maximal greatness. This is philosophical progress, not vindication.

Top-answer checklist

- Kant's objection stated with the thaler illustration.
- The modal argument given as numbered steps, with S5 named.
- The escape acknowledged honestly before the counter is made.
- The symmetry of the possibility premise displayed.
- A graded verdict - progress, not vindication.

Original 15-marker 2

Question: Examine the Mīmāṃsā case that the authority of the Veda and the operation of karma together render a creator God redundant. (15 marks, 240 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Examine</i> - reconstruct the case and test it
Core issue	Whether normativity and desert can be secured without a divine guarantor
Ideal thesis	The case is coherent and internally powerful, but purchases economy at the cost of explaining normativity's ultimate ground

Model answer (≈250 words)

Mīmāṃsā's case has two limbs, each aimed at a distinct Nyāya proof.

The first concerns **authority**. The Veda is **apauruṣeya** - eternal, authorless and self-valid. Authorlessness is not a deficiency but a protection: a personal author may deceive or may lack complete knowledge, and if the Veda had an author, its authority would depend on first proving that author's competence and sincerity. Mīmāṃsā presses the point directly against Nyāya: the theistic route requires proving that God exists, then that God is omniscient, then that God intends truth, each stage needing independent support. Combined with **svataḥ-prāmāṇya**, the intrinsic validity of cognition, authorlessness blocks scepticism at the outset without theological machinery.

The second concerns **desert**. **Apūrva** is the unseen potency generated by correctly performed ritual; it persists after the act and matures into future fruit. Prābhākara adds **niyoga**: the injunction itself creates obligation, so one acts because the Veda commands, not because a deity rewards. Together these dissolve Nyāya's *adṛṣṭa* argument, whose whole force lay in the claim that an unconscious principle cannot allot determinate fruit.

Two criticisms remain. First, an eternal, authorless language that nevertheless carries determinate normative content is itself philosophically striking, and Nyāya charges that unexplained normativity is not the same as economical explanation. Second, Chatterjee and Datta observe that Mīmāṃsā's deities are not treated as objects of worship and are said to exist nowhere except in the *mantras* describing them, so God is left in an "ambiguous position" - economy achieved partly by evacuation.

Verdict: the case succeeds in showing that a rigorous account of duty and desert is possible without a creator; it does not show that such an account is explanatorily superior.

Top-answer checklist

- The two limbs separated and matched to the two Nyāya proofs they attack.
- *Apauruṣeya*, *svataḥ-prāmāṇya*, *apūrva* and *niyoga* all used correctly.
- The "cumbersome three-stage dependence" objection to Nyāya reproduced.
- At least one criticism from the Nyāya side and one from the textbook tradition.
- A graded verdict distinguishing possibility from superiority.

Original 20-marker 1

Question: "Hume did not disprove design; he dismantled the inference." Critically examine with reference to the Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion. (20 marks, 340 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically examine</i> a precise interpretive thesis
Core issue	The logical status of Hume's conclusions
Ideal thesis	The thesis is correct: Hume's attacks are undercutting and adequacy-directed, not disproofs

Model answer (≈350 words)

The thesis is correct, and defending it requires separating two waves of Hume's attack.

The design argument, in Paley's form, is an **analogy**: a watch on a heath, with wheels, cogs and springs adjusted to a purpose, obliges us to postulate a maker; organisms exhibit comparable means-end adjustment; therefore they too imply a designer. Paley's three riders pre-empt the obvious replies - the inference survives never having seen a watch made, imperfect working, and parts of unknown function - and he builds a long cumulative case from the eye, the wing, the fin, planetary motion and the seasons.

Hume's **first wave is undercutting**. He argues that any universe capable of persisting must display mutual adaptation, so adaptation is a precondition of order rather than evidence of design; the **Epicurean hypothesis** - a finite number of particles in random motion passing, in unlimited time, through every combination, one of which is stable - supplies a naturalistic model of order. He then attacks the analogy itself: the universe is as like a vegetable or a crustacean as a machine, and whether *those* are designed is the point at issue.

His **second wave is adequacy-directed**. Cause must be proportioned to effect, so from a finite world one may infer only a finite cause - the illustration of the scales, where an unseen weight may be inferred to exceed ten ounces but never to be infinite. The evidence equally supports many designers, an inferior deity, an infant or senile one, or a bungled first attempt; and the world's evil and disorder tell against a good and powerful designer.

Neither wave is a **disproof**. Undercutting objections show the evidence does not support the conclusion; they do not show the conclusion false. Adequacy objections *grant* an inference and deny only its reach. Hume's own Philo concedes a remote, undefined analogy between the cause of order in the universe and human intelligence. Darwin later supplies the mechanism Hume lacked, removing Paley's biological premise - Hick's ozone example inverts the intuition - but that too is an explanation, not a refutation. Modern fine-tuning arguments answer Hume's first wave by relocating the evidence to pre-biological constants, while remaining fully exposed to the second and facing multiverse rivals.

Verdict: the thesis stands. Hume destroyed the argument's demonstrative pretension and blocked the passage from an orderer to the one, infinite, perfectly good God of theism. What survives is design as an **inference to the best explanation** - contested, cumulative, and never compelling.

Top-answer checklist

- The two waves explicitly distinguished and labelled by tier.
- Paley's three riders present.
- At least four Hume fronts with his own illustrations.
- Philo's concession cited as the decisive textual evidence for the thesis.
- Darwin and fine-tuning placed with their exact scope.
- A verdict naming what survives, not merely what fails.

Original 20-marker 2

Question: "Every Indian argument against a creator God is either an economy move, a coherence move or an epistemic move." Critically examine this classification with reference to Jaina, Buddhist, Mīmāṃsā and Cārvāka positions. (20 marks, 340 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically examine</i> a proposed taxonomy - test its fit and its limits
Core issue	Whether four distinct schools share a common argumentative structure
Ideal thesis	The classification fits well and is analytically useful, but some arguments straddle categories and one school resists placement

Model answer (≈350 words)

The classification is largely accurate and analytically valuable, though it requires two qualifications.

Economy moves claim that the explanandum is already explained. Buddhism's **pratītyasamutpāda** accounts for the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator superfluous; the critique is a systematic refusal of

explanatory surplus rather than bare denial. Jainism holds that the world was never created - substances are eternal and change through modes - and that material karma, adhering to each jīva, accounts for the distribution of fortune. Mīmāṃsā's **apūrva** matures into its own fruit, displacing the need for a dispenser. Cārvāka holds that the world is made by the automatic combination of the material elements.

Coherence moves claim that the divine attributes are inconsistent with the act of creating. Buddhism argues that an eternal, immutable cause cannot produce **successive** effects, and that creation from desire implies lack. Jainism asks what God created from, why a perfect being would create at all, and why a compassionate creator's world contains suffering. Chatterjee and Datta record Max Müller's related point that a creator would be liable to charges of cruelty and partiality.

Epistemic moves deny that the required *pramāṇa* is available. Cārvāka restricts valid cognition to perception, which undercuts every inferential proof at the outset. Mīmāṃsā's **svataḥ-prāmāṇya** and **apauruṣeya** make Vedic authority intrinsic, so no divine certifier is needed; Nyāya's route, requiring one to prove God, then omniscience, then truthfulness, is dismissed as cumbersome.

Two qualifications. First, several arguments straddle categories: the Jaina "if God is self-existent, so may the world be" is simultaneously a parity argument and an economy argument, and Buddhism's *avyākṛta* silence is methodological rather than any of the three. Second, Jainism does not fit a purely negative taxonomy, since it also **affirms** godhood - every liberated soul is a god - so its position is not exhausted by objections to a creator.

Nyāya's replies fall into matching families: against economy, that an unconscious principle cannot allot determinate desert; against coherence, that divine agency need not be modelled on finite volition; against epistemic restriction, that inference is an independent *pramāṇa* which the Cārvāka's own general denial presupposes.

Verdict: the taxonomy is a genuine advance over school-by-school listing, because it exposes that Indian and Western critiques share the same three structures - Hume's Epicurean hypothesis is an economy move, his proportioning principle a coherence-adjacent adequacy move, and logical positivist verificationism an epistemic move. It should be used as a framework, not as a straitjacket.

Top-answer checklist

- All four schools placed, with at least one school appearing in two categories.
- Sanskrit terms deployed as analytical instruments.
- The Nyāya replies mapped onto the same three families.
- At least two honest limits to the classification.
- A Western cross-mapping in the verdict.

High-score proof-answer protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

1. Define with discrimination, not description

Open with a definition that already separates the doctrine from its nearest rival.

Weak : God is the cause of the world.

Strong: In Nyaya, Isvara is the intelligent EFFICIENT cause who orders eternal atoms; atoms remain the MATERIAL cause, and God also preserves and destroys - which distinguishes Nyaya theism from deism.

Term	The definition must distinguish it from
Ontological argument	Cosmological reasoning and Descartes' <i>Meditations</i> III causal proof
Necessary being	Whatever merely happens to be everlasting
<i>Per se</i> series	<i>Per accidens</i> series
Design (Way 5)	Paley's analogy and modern fine-tuning
Postulate	Demonstration and empirical hypothesis
<i>Adṛṣṭa</i>	Jaina material karma and Mīmāṃsā <i>apūrva</i>
<i>Apauruṣeya</i>	Divine revelation

2. Reconstruct arguments as premises

1. Composite objects are effects (savayava + avantara-mahattva).
2. Material causes alone cannot achieve the required order.
3. An intelligent cause must know the atoms, desire an end and will it.
4. Only an omniscient being can directly know atoms.
5. The cause is an omniscient God.

Then expose the **presupposition** - here, that world-wholes are relevantly like artefacts. Marks come from showing *why* the conclusion follows and *where* it can be resisted.

3. Sort every objection by tier

VALIDITY : does the conclusion follow? (quantifier shift in Way 3)
SOUNDNESS : are the premises true? (Hume fronts 1-2; Darwin)
ADEQUACY : is the being reached GOD? (Hume front 3; Kant on cosmological)

Announcing the tier in a single clause - "this is an objection to adequacy, not to validity" - signals control and saves words.

4. Use Sanskrit and Latin as instruments, not decoration

- Gloss on first use: *kāryāt* (from the effect), per se (essentially ordered).
- Preserve causal distinctions: *nimitta-kāraṇa* versus *upādāna-kāraṇa*.
- Preserve epistemic distinctions: *pratyakṣa*, *anumāna*, *śabda*, *vyāpti*.
- Preserve the three Kantian statuses: knowledge, postulate, idea of reason.

5. Never conflate these five relations

CONCEPTUAL ENTAILMENT : Anselm - the concept contains necessary existence
EXPLANATORY PRIORITY : Aquinas - the first cause acts here and now
ANALOGICAL INFERENCE : Paley, Nyaya - artefact to world
PRACTICAL POSTULATION : Kant - required for the highest good's possibility
SCRIPTURAL TESTIMONY : Nyaya sruteh - and its Mimamsa denial

6. Present objection and reply dialectically

OBJECTION -> BEST AVAILABLE REPLY -> RESIDUAL PRESSURE

Objection : An infinite regress of causes needs no first member.
Reply : The series is essentially ordered; derivative causes supply no actualising power however many they are.
Residual : It must still be shown that the actual causal order is per se rather than per accidens.

Steelman the critic before evaluating. Never introduce a weak objection merely to dismiss it.

7. Grade the verdict and name the criterion

Avoid "completely proved", "totally refuted", "both are equally valid". Prefer:

- "valid in form but question-begging in premise",
- "evidentially undercut, though not disproved",
- "explanatorily economical but normatively unexplained",
- "epistemically bolder and correspondingly more exposed",
- "adequate to a cosmic administrator, not to an absolute".

Name the criterion: coherence, evidential contact, modal strength, explanatory economy, religious adequacy, or compatibility with moral agency.

8. Marks-wise architecture

Marks	Working time	Architecture
10	7-8 min	Classify -> premises -> one presupposition -> canonical objection -> one-line verdict
15	12-13 min	Frame -> reconstruct -> canonical example -> strongest objection -> best reply -> assess validity and adequacy separately
20	17-18 min	Classify family -> full steps -> Indian/Western contrast -> two objections with replies -> underdetermination of attributes -> criterion-named verdict

- **10 marks ≈ 150 words.** One controlled comparison is enough; do not spend half the answer on background.
- **15 marks ≈ 220-260 words.** At least one technical distinction and one serious criticism.
- **20 marks ≈ 320-360 words.** A comparative matrix or compact diagram may precede the prose; two objections, or one developed through reply and residual pressure.

9. Avoid generic prose

Do not write:

"Belief in God gives peace and moral values to society."

Write:

"A moral governor can ground desert-appropriate allocation, but Mīmāṃsā's *apūrva* shows that an unconscious potency may be intrinsically fruit-directed - so the Nyāya inference must defend its premise that unconsciousness entails indeterminacy of outcome."

10. Final twenty-second audit

- Did I answer the **directive** - examine, compare, critically evaluate, discuss?
- Did I define the controlling term so as to exclude its nearest rival?
- Did I reconstruct at least one argument as numbered premises?
- Did I name the **tier** of each objection?
- Did I include Indian material in a Paper II answer?
- Did I state a **graded verdict with a named criterion**?

Part VI - Final Rapid Revision Matrix

Argument / doctrine	Thinker / school	Starting point	Terminus reached	Central criticism	Likely question form
Ontological, first form	Anselm, <i>Proslogion</i> 2	Concept of that than which nothing greater can be conceived	Existence in reality	Gaunilo's island; Kant's real predicate	Is the ontological proof logical?
Ontological, second form	Anselm, <i>Proslogion</i> 3	The same concept plus inconceivability of non-existence	Necessary existence, aseity	Coherence of maximal greatness	Does the concept entail existence?
Essence-containment	Descartes, <i>Meditations</i> V	Essence of a supremely perfect being	Existence as a perfection	Kant; second-order analysis of existence	Exposition with criticism
Island parody	Gaunilo	Any maximally perfect object	Absurd conclusions	Answered by necessary existence	Criticism of Anselm
Real-predicate objection	Kant, <i>CPR</i>	Logic of "exists"	Existence posits, does not enrich	Modal repair attempts	Criticism of the ontological proof
Modal ontological	Malcolm, Hartshorne, Plantinga	Possibility of maximal greatness	Necessary existence in S5	Possibility premise is symmetric	Advanced note only
Way 1	Aquinas	Motion / change	Unmoved mover	Regress exclusion	Five Ways exposition
Way 2	Aquinas	Order of efficient causes	First efficient cause	Hume on regress; Kant on identification	Five Ways; comparison with Nyāya
Way 3	Aquinas	Contingency	Necessary being, ultimately a se	Quantifier shift	Most interesting Way
Way 4	Aquinas	Degrees of perfection	Maximum, cause of all perfection	Degrees need no maximum	Five Ways completeness
Way 5	Aquinas	Regular directedness of non-cognitive nature	Directing intelligence (archer-arrow)	Hume's analogy; less exposed to Darwin	Design argument
Kalām	Islamic tradition; modern revival	Universe began to exist	Personal, timeless, powerful cause	Actual-infinite and cosmology disputes	Contrast with Aquinas
PSR version	Leibniz	Why anything rather than nothing	Necessary being	Brute-fact reply	Cosmological evaluation
Watch analogy	Paley, <i>Natural Theology</i> 1802	Means-end adjustment in organisms	Intelligent maker	Darwin; Hume's five fronts	Design with Hume's criticism
Five-front critique	Hume, <i>Dialogues</i> 1779	Analogy, adaptation, proportion, plurality, evil	Design inference dismantled	Does not disprove a designer	2025-type question
Natural selection	Darwin	Variation and differential survival	Adaptation without design	Does not touch fine-tuning or law	Extension of the design debate
Fine-tuning	Modern probabilistic theism	Life-permitting constants	Design as best explanation	Multiverse; observation selection	Contemporary note only
Moral, first form	Newman	Conscience and objective values	Divine Law Giver	Begs the question against naturalism	Critical account of the moral argument
Moral, second form	Kant, <i>CPrR</i>	Moral law and the highest good	God, immortality, freedom as postulates	Projection; autonomy; adequacy	Critical account; comparison with Nyāya
<i>Kāryāt</i>	Nyāya / Udayana	Composite world as effect (<i>sāṃvaya</i> , <i>avāntara-mahattva</i>)	Omniscient intelligent maker	World unlike an artefact	Nyāya proofs

Argument / doctrine	Thinker / school	Starting point	Terminus reached	Central criticism	Likely question form
<i>Āyōjanāt</i>	Nyāya	Purposive combination of inert atoms	Conscious arranger	Order may emerge unintentionally	Nyāya proofs
<i>Dhṛtyādeḥ</i>	Nyāya	Support, maintenance, destruction	Cosmic governor	Governance may be law-like	Nyāya proofs
<i>Padāt / āptapr āmāṇya</i>	Nyāya	Authority of the Veda	Omniscient trustworthy author	Mīmāṃsā <i>apauruṣeya</i>	Nyāya proofs; circularity
<i>Śruteḥ</i>	Nyāya	Scriptural testimony	God as attested	Circularity charge; philosophical weight of testimony	Nyāya proofs
<i>Adṛṣṭa</i> argument	Nyāya	Unequal fortunes; time-gap of desert	God as <i>karmaphaladātā</i>	Mīmāṃsā <i>apūrva</i> ; redundancy	Nyāya; comparison with Kant
Nyāya causation	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	Eternal atoms and souls	God as efficient, not material, cause	Sharma: "reduced to a supervisor"	Nature versus proofs - keep distinct
Jaina godhead	Jainism	<i>Ananta-catuṣṭaya</i> obscured by material karma	<i>Kevala-jñāna</i> ; the <i>siddha</i> as god	Bondage/liberation dilemma	Jaina proofs (2019)
Jaina anti-creator	Jainism	Uncreated world; modes	No creator needed	Presupposes Jaina metaphysics	Jaina proofs
Buddhist anti-creator	Buddhism	Dependent origination; immutability	Creator redundant and incoherent	Nyāya on determinate allocation	2018 Q8(b)
Mīmāṃsā	Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā	<i>Apauruṣeya</i> Veda; <i>apūrva</i>	Authority and desert without God	Normativity left unexplained	Critique of Nyāya proofs
Cārvāka	Cārvāka	Perception as sole <i>pramāṇa</i>	God unproven and unnecessary	Denial itself uses inference	Anti-theistic arguments
Advaita levelling	Śāṅkara	Levels of reality	Nyāya's God is only <i>saguṇa</i>	Level-distinction dispute	Comparative synthesis
Cumulative case	Udayana; modern theists	Multiple independent routes	Higher overall probability	Independence and logical type	20-mark evaluation

Last-minute memory spine

TIERS : validity -> soundness -> adequacy of the God established
 A PRIORI : ontological only | A POSTERIORI : cosmo · teleo · moral · Nyaya
 ANSELM : P2 existence · P3 NECESSARY existence · Gaunilo · Kant · modal burden
 AQUINAS : motion · causation · contingency · degrees · purpose
 per se (hand-stick-stone) · "first" = explanatory · eternity permitted
 DESIGN : Way 5 archer ≠ Paley watch ≠ fine-tuning constants
 HUME : A-A-P-P-E - adapted · analogy · proportion · plurality · evil
 (1779, BEFORE Paley 1802; Philo concedes a remote analogy)
 KANT : CPR destroys · CPR postulates · F-I-G · summum bonum · ought-implies-can
 NYAYA : K-A-D-P-S + adrsta · EFFICIENT cause only · karmaphaladata ·
 order-of-existence vs order-of-knowledge
 INDIA : Jaina godhead · Buddha conditions · Mimamsa apauruseya + apurva ·
 Carvaka perception · Advaita saguna · Sharma redundancy
 CLASSIFY : every Indian objection = Economy · Coherence · Epistemic
 VERDICT : classify -> reconstruct -> presuppose -> object -> reply -> GRADE

End of the premium solved-PYQ and practice workbook.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Everything below is enrichment after core learning and practice. It is not required for a competent core answer; deploy one refinement only when it earns an evaluative payoff.

Advanced cards moved from the complete learner source - [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: ANALYSIS: Anselm's argument is better read as *fides quaerens intellectum* — faith seeking understanding — than as a neutral proof aimed at converting the atheist.

BOOK: Advanced refinement

ANALYSIS: Anselm's argument is better read as *fides quaerens intellectum* - faith seeking understanding - than as a neutral proof aimed at converting the atheist. On that reading, its function is to display the internal grammar of the God-concept for one who already believes: God is not one more entity that happens to exist, but that whose non-existence is unthinkable. This does not save it as a proof, but it explains its extraordinary durability, and it is a mature line to deploy in the concluding paragraph of a 20-marker.

BOOK: Advanced refinement

ANALYSIS: Note the difference in **what the conclusion has to do**. Aquinas needs a being that is *ipsum esse subsistens* - subsistent existence itself - because his question is why anything at all is actual. Udayana needs only an omniscient agent capable of knowing atoms and combining them. Consequently Hume's "finite effect, finite cause" objection bites *harder* against Aquinas' identification with the infinite God and *differently* against Nyāya, whose God is explicitly limited by co-eternal atoms, souls and *adrṣṭa*. C. D. Sharma presses exactly this point from the Advaita side, complaining that the Vaiśeṣika God "has been reduced to the status of a supervisor" whose "hands and feet are chained by the shackles of the Law of Karma unfolding itself as the *Adrṣṭa*."

BOOK: Advanced refinement

ANALYSIS: There is a deep asymmetry between objections (1)-(2) and (3)-(5). The first two say *the evidence does not support design at all*; the last three concede an inference but say *it does not reach the God of religion*. A candidate who separates these two waves demonstrates control of the argument's logical structure - and can then make the mature observation that the modern fine-tuning revival answers the *first* wave (by relocating the evidence to the constants) while remaining fully exposed to the *second* (a fine-tuner need not be one, infinite or good).

BOOK: Advanced refinement

ANALYSIS: Kant's own later thought puts pressure on the postulate. If the highest good is redescribed as an *ethical commonwealth* achievable through human moral community, the theological postulate becomes less indispensable. Conversely, if the highest good genuinely requires a proportioning of nature to desert, no naturalistic substitute is available. So the argument's fate turns entirely on **how the highest good is specified** - a point worth one sentence in a 15-marker and a full paragraph in a 20-marker.

BOOK: Advanced refinement

ANALYSIS: **Udayana's cumulative strategy**. *Nyāyakusumāñjali* does not rest on one inference; it multiplies independent routes - effect, arrangement, sustenance, word-meaning convention, scriptural credibility, moral desert - so that the failure of any single route does not collapse the case. This is structurally the same move as the modern Western cumulative-case argument, and saying so is a genuinely advanced comparative observation. ANALYSIS: The counter is equally structural: a cumulation of individually weak inferences does not automatically yield a strong one unless the routes are evidentially independent.

BOOK: Advanced refinement

ANALYSIS: **The structural symmetry worth naming in a 20-marker**. Every Indian anti-creator argument is one of exactly three moves: (i) an **economy** move - the explanandum is already explained (dependent origination, karma, *apūrva*); (ii) a **coherence** move - the divine attributes are internally inconsistent with the act of creating (immutability vs willing, perfection vs motive); or (iii) an **epistemic** move - the required *pramāṇa* is unavailable (Cārvāka's restriction to perception; Mīmāṃsā's insistence that the Veda's authority is intrinsic). Classifying the objections this way, rather than listing them by school, is exactly what "critically evaluate" invites - and it lets you show that the Nyāya replies also

fall into three matching families.

Canonical advanced doctrine dossiers - [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: Doctrine statement. FACT: Anselm argues *a priori* from the concept of God as that than which no greater can be conceived to existence not merely in understanding but in reality.

8. ADVANCED DOCTRINE DOSSIERS

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: Doctrine statement. FACT: Anselm argues *a priori* from the concept of God as that than which no greater can be conceived to existence not merely in understanding but in reality.

8.1 Ontological argument

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Anselm argues *a priori* from the concept of God as that than which no greater can be conceived to existence not merely in understanding but in reality.
- **Argument.** FACT: (1) Even the denier understands the concept; (2) existing in reality is greater than existing only in understanding; (3) if God existed only in understanding, a greater could be conceived; (4) contradiction; therefore God exists. Descartes recasts existence as inseparable from supremely perfect being.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Existence can function in the relevant greatness/perfection ordering, and the concept of a maximally great being is coherent.
- **Distinction.** FACT: An *a priori* proof does not infer from observed effects; it analyses what is supposedly contained in the God-concept.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: Gaunilo's perfect-island parody tests whether the form can establish any unsurpassable object's existence.
- **Objection -> reply.** FACT: Kant denies that existence is a real predicate. A modal reply distinguishes ordinary existence from necessary existence, but it must independently justify the possibility of a maximally great being.

8.2 Cosmological arguments and Aquinas' Ways

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: From motion, efficient causation, contingency, gradation and purposive order, Aquinas argues to a first or ultimate explanatory source.
- **Argument.** FACT: Ways 1-3 move from actualisation, ordered causes and contingent beings to an unmoved mover, first efficient cause and necessary being. Way 4 moves from degrees to a maximum/source; Way 5 from regular goal-directed activity of non-rational things to intelligence.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Essentially ordered causal series require a here-and-now first member; the principle of sufficient reason has sufficient scope.
- **Distinction.** FACT: Aquinas' "first" is explanatory priority, not simply the earliest event in time.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: A stick moves a stone only while moved by a hand: the derivative causal power illustrates an essentially ordered series.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: Hume asks why the series cannot be brute or infinite. Thomists answer that even an infinite derivative series lacks non-derivative actualising power.

8.3 Design argument

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Regularity, adaptation or fine order is presented as evidence for intelligent purposive causation.
- **Argument.** FACT: Paley's analogical form: watches exhibit means-end adjustment and have designers; organisms exhibit complex adjustment; therefore organismic order points to design. Aquinas' Fifth Way is not identical: it concerns regular directedness of non-conscious nature.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Relevant natural order is improbable or explanatorily deficient under non-intentional processes.

- **Distinction.** FACT: Paley's artifact analogy differs from contemporary probabilistic/fine-tuning arguments; Darwin directly weakens biological adaptation as Paley used it.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: The watch on the heath; Nyāya's potter-pot inference is the closest Indian analogue.
- **Objection -> reply.** FACT: Hume attacks the analogy, inference to one perfect God, and immunity to counterevidence. A cumulative reply reduces the claim from demonstration to inference to the best explanation.

8.4 Nyāya-Udayana inference to Īśvara

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Nyāya infers an omniscient intelligent efficient cause who orders eternal atoms and dispenses karmic results. The classical locus is **Udayana's Nyāyakusumāñjali** (5th stabaka), *supported by his Ātmatattvaviveka*; *earlier statements are in Vātsyāyana, Uddyotakara and Jayanta's Nyāyamañjarī**.
- **Udayana's enumeration - the complete list, stated carefully.** FACT: Udayana compresses his grounds into a single mnemonic verse whose terms are conventionally unpacked as **eight hetus**. ANALYSIS: Translations and school-summaries differ in how they split and gloss the last four; the safe examination practice is to give the Sanskrit term, one clause of content, and to flag that enumerations vary.

#	Hetu (Sanskrit)	Inference offered	Status
1	kāryāt	The composite world is an <i>effect</i> ; every effect presupposes an intelligent maker who knows its material, means and purpose	FACT: Core
2	āyojanāt	Inert atoms cannot combine themselves; the initial conjunction (<i>samyoga</i>) of atoms requires a conscious agent's volition	FACT: Core
3	dhr̥tyādeḥ	Support, sustenance and periodic dissolution of the cosmos require a governing will (" <i>ādī</i> " carries the maintenance/destruction pair)	FACT: Core
4	padāt	The transmission of language, arts and crafts presupposes an original competent teacher	FACT:
5	pratyayataḥ	The validity (prāmānya) of the Veda as a body of knowledge requires a trustworthy (<i>āpta</i>) author	FACT:
6	śruteḥ	The Veda's own testimony to Īśvara counts as evidence within the system	FACT:
7	vākyāt	The Veda consists of <i>sentences</i> , and sentences are of the kind produced by persons - hence a personal author	FACT:
8	saṃkhyāviśeṣāt	The "special number": the <i>dyad</i> (<i>dvyanuka</i>) that begins creation requires the numerical cognition (<i>apekṣā-buddhi</i>) of a conscious being present at the start, when no finite self is embodied	CAUTION: Technically the hardest; state it only if you can state it correctly

ANALYSIS: **The adṛṣṭa argument runs beneath all of these:** unconscious merit and demerit cannot themselves select who receives which fruit, so an intelligent superintendent (*karmādhyakṣa*) is required. It is usually treated as the philosophical core of (3).

- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: World-wholes are relevantly analogous to artifacts; unconscious *adṛṣṭa* cannot administer itself; inference can range legitimately beyond the perceptible.
- **Distinction.** FACT: Īśvara is the **efficient**, never the material, cause in classical Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika; atoms (*paramāṇu*), space, time, ether and selves are eternal and uncreated. God arranges; he does not manufacture *ex nihilo*.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: A pot's ordered parts warrant inference to a potter; the world is treated as a vastly more complex *kārya*.
- **Objection -> reply.** FACT: **Mīmāṃsā** denies the need for a Vedic author (the Veda is *apauruṣeya* and self-validating) and treats karma as self-fructifying through *apūrva*; **Cārvāka** denies that inference can reach the supersensible at all; **Buddhists** (Dharmakīrti, Śāntarākṣita) attack the causal premise; **Advaita** grants Īśvara only *vyāvahārika* standing. Nyāya's standing reply is that unconscious merit cannot intelligently allot determinate fruits,

and that the dissimilarity between pot and cosmos affects the *strength*, not the *form*, of the inference.

- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "Udayana's is the most systematic Indian natural theology: it is a **cumulative** case, not a single demonstration, and it inherits exactly the Humean liabilities of the Western design argument - plus one of its own, that the artifact analogy is doing more work in (1)-(2) than the atomism can bear."

8.5 Moral argument

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Kant does not theoretically prove God; practical reason postulates God and immortality in relation to the highest good, where virtue and happiness are proportioned.
- **Argument.** FACT: (1) Moral law obligates pursuit of the highest good; (2) finite agents cannot secure harmony of virtue and happiness; (3) practical rational hope postulates conditions under which it is possible; (4) God and immortality are therefore practical postulates.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: "Ought implies can" applies to the highest good and moral rationality licenses postulation.
- **Distinction.** FACT: A postulate of practical reason is not a speculative demonstration or empirical hypothesis.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: The argument may project a desire for cosmic fairness. Kant's reply is that the postulate arises from moral reason's structure, not reward-seeking heteronomy.

8.6 Jainism: rejection of a creator, and what "God" then means (2019 Q5(e) owner-module)

ANALYSIS: **Read the question exactly.** "Proofs for the existence of God as propounded in Jainism" is a trap-shaped stem: Jainism offers **no proof of a creator God** - it offers (a) a battery of arguments *against* a creator, and (b) a positive doctrine of divinity as the **perfected soul**. A script that invents Jain theistic proofs loses the paper; a script that says only "Jainism is atheistic" loses half the marks.

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Jainism is **non-theistic but not irreligious**: the universe (*loka*) is uncreated, beginningless and eternal, running by its own six *dravyas* (jīva, pudgala, dharma, adharma, ākāśa, kāla) and by the karmic mechanism; there is no creator, sustainer or destroyer. Divinity is not a cosmic office but an **achieved state of the soul**.
- **The Jain arguments against a creator, reconstructed.** FACT: (classically assembled in Jinasena's *Mahāpurāṇa* and Hemacandra's works; also Haribhadra, Akalaṅka, Vidyānandi)
 1. **Motive argument (the strongest, and the one the examiner wants).** A perfect being is by definition complete - without unfulfilled desire, deficiency or need. Creation is an *action*, and every action presupposes a want or purpose. Therefore either God is perfect and had no motive to create, or God had a motive and is not perfect. FACT:
 2. **Regress argument.** If everything that exists needs a maker, the maker needs a maker; if the maker can be uncaused, so can the world - the premise defeats itself. FACT:
 3. **Instrument/material argument.** Before creation there was no matter, no space, no body and no instrument; an immaterial God with nothing to work on and nothing to work with cannot act. FACT:
 4. **Moral argument (theodicy in reverse).** If God created out of compassion, the world would not contain suffering, inequality and predation; if he created without compassion, he is not good. Karma, by contrast, explains the *distribution* of fortune without impugning anyone's goodness. FACT:
 5. **Redundancy argument.** Karmic matter, the six substances and the causal laws already explain order, bondage and release; a creator adds no explanatory work. FACT: (This is the *lāghava*/parsimony move.)
 6. **Nature (svabhāva) argument.** Things act according to their own nature - fire burns, water flows - so cosmic regularity needs no external superintendent. FACT:
- **What Jainism affirms instead - and the distinction you must not blur.** FACT:
- **Arihanta / Kevalin:** one who has destroyed the four *ghātiyā* (obscuring) karmas and attained *kevala-jñāna* (omniscience) **while still embodied**.
- **Tīrthaṅkara ("ford-maker"):** a special class of arihanta who, having attained omniscience, **re-establishes the tīrtha*** - the fourfold order of monks, nuns, laymen, laywomen - and preaches the path. There are **24 in each half-cycle**; Mahāvīra is the 24th of the present. A Tīrthaṅkara is thus defined by a **teaching-and-founding function**, not by a metaphysical rank above other Kevalins.

- **Siddha:** the soul that has additionally shed the four *aghātiyā* karmas at death, is **disembodied**, and rests at the *siddhaśilā* at the summit of the *loka* with the four infinitudes (*ananta-catuṣṭaya*: infinite knowledge, perception, bliss, energy). FACT:
- ANALYSIS: **Therefore:** every Tīrthaṅkara becomes a Siddha, but not every Siddha was a Tīrthaṅkara; and **neither creates, sustains, judges or answers prayer**. Worship of the Tīrthaṅkara (*vītarāga*, "one free of passion") is **commemorative and aspirational** - the object of worship does not respond, and cannot, since responsiveness would be a passion.
- FACT: The *Namokāra* mantra's five-fold salutation (arihanta, siddha, ācārya, upādhyāya, sādhu) salutes **qualities and stages**, not a deity.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: That perfection excludes motivated action; that parsimony favours an intrinsic karmic mechanism; that consciousness belongs intrinsically to an eternal plurality of jīvas.
- **Objection -> reply.** FACT: **Nyāya's objection:** unconscious karmic matter cannot allot determinate fruits to determinate persons, nor can inert atoms self-organise - an intelligent *adhyakṣa* is required. **Jain reply:** karmic influx and maturation are law-like properties of the jīva-pudgala relation, exactly as poison acts without a poisoner supervising it. ANALYSIS: **Counter-objection:** "God has no motive" assumes creation must be motivated as *human* action is - a classical theist replies that creation is a free, non-needy expression of goodness (*bonum diffusivum sui*), not the satisfaction of a lack. This exchange is the highest-yield paragraph in the answer.
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "Jainism supplies no proof of God; it supplies a proof-structure *against* a creator and a redefinition of divinity as the soul's achieved perfection. Its motive argument is genuinely powerful against an anthropomorphic creator, and genuinely weaker against a classical theism that denies creation is need-driven."

8.7 The Buddhist case against a creator God, reconstructed (2018 Q8(b) owner-module)

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Buddhism denies a creator (*Īśvara/Brahmā* understood as world-maker) on three independent fronts: **canonical-critical**, **causal-metaphysical**, and **moral**. It does not thereby deny the existence of *devas*, who are simply long-lived, impermanent beings inside *saṃsāra*.
- **(a) Canonical/critical stratum.** FACT: The *Brahmajāla Sutta* (DN 1) explains belief in a creator genetically: the being first reborn in an empty *Brahmā*-world, seeing others appear after his wish, mistakenly concludes "I am *Brahmā*, the Maker, the Creator" - and later arrivals, remembering him, transmit the error. The *Aggañña Sutta* (DN 27) replaces creation with a naturalistic-cyclic account of cosmic and social evolution. FACT: The **avyākata** (undeclared) questions and the parable of the man wounded by a poisoned arrow set aside speculative cosmogony as soteriologically useless. ANALYSIS: Note the honest limit: these are *diagnoses of the belief*, not refutations of the proposition.
- **(b) Causal-metaphysical stratum (Dharmakīrti, Śāntarakṣita's Tattvasaṃgraha with Kamalaśīla's commentary).** FACT: This is where the examinable argument lies.
 1. **Criterion of existence:** to be real is to be causally efficacious (*arthakriyā-kāritva*).
 2. **The dilemma of successive vs simultaneous production (krama-akrama-virodha):** a **permanent, unchanging** cause must produce its effects either all at once or successively. If all at once, the whole cosmos would arise in one instant and nothing would follow. If successively, then God must change - acquiring at t_1 some auxiliary condition he lacked at t_0 - and is therefore neither permanent nor self-sufficient.
 3. **Auxiliary-condition regress:** if God needs auxiliaries (material, karma, time), he is not the sole cause; if he does not, the temporal order of the world is unexplained.
 4. **Evidential objection:** God is neither perceived nor validly inferred; the inference from "effect" to "intelligent maker" fails because *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance) between "being an effect" and "having a conscious maker" is established only for artifacts, and generalising it is the very point at issue.
 5. **Explanatory redundancy:** *pratītyasamutpāda* - conditioned co-arising - already accounts for arising and cessation; a creator is an idle wheel.
- **(c) Moral stratum.** FACT: If a being had the power to create and ordered a world containing this quantity of suffering, that being is either not benevolent or not omnipotent; and if all is God's will, karma and moral effort are pointless. The *Devadaha Sutta* (MN 101) makes the parallel point against determinism generally: a doctrine that makes present effort ineffective destroys the moral life. ANALYSIS: The verse-form of this argument in the *Bhūridatta Jātaka* is standardly cited but the wording is translation-dependent - paraphrase it.

- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Causal efficacy is the mark of the real; permanence and productive activity are incompatible; soteriology sets the agenda for metaphysics.
- **Distinction.** FACT: Buddhism is **non-theistic**, not merely atheistic: it rejects a *creator*, not every divine being; it rejects *Īśvara-kāraṇa-vāda*, not devotion as such. Later Mahāyāna Buddha-fields and celestial bodhisattvas perform religious functions without an omnipotent creator ever entering the system.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: **Nyāya's reply:** God's willing is eternal while its *effects* are timed by the readiness of adṛṣṭa, so no change in God is required; and to demand perception of God is to beg the question against inference. **Buddhist rejoinder:** an eternal will whose efficacy is timed by something else is not the sole and sufficient cause the theist claimed. ANALYSIS: **Second objection:** if there is no self and no creator, what carries karma? - routed to Soul §8.3.
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "The Buddhist case is strongest where it is metaphysical - the permanence/production dilemma bites on any *unchanging* creator - and weakest where it is merely genetic, since explaining why people believe in Brahmā does not show there is none."

8.8 Cumulative-case logic: how the proofs are supposed to work together

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: No single theistic argument is standardly claimed to be demonstrative today; the live claim is that several independently weak arguments **jointly** raise the probability of theism - Richard Swinburne's programme in *The Existence of God*, and Basil Mitchell's in *The Justification of Religious Belief*.
- **Argument.** FACT: (1) Distinguish a **P-inductive** argument (premises make the conclusion *more probable than not*) from a **C-inductive** argument (premises *raise* the probability of the conclusion without making it more probable than not). (2) Cosmological, teleological, consciousness, providence, religious-experience and moral arguments are individually C-inductive at best. (3) On a Bayesian confirmation model, several independent C-inductive arguments can together yield a P-inductive result, provided the prior probability of theism is not vanishingly small and the evidence-items are genuinely independent. (4) Swinburne adds that theism has a high prior on grounds of **simplicity** - a personal explanation citing one agent with infinite (hence non-arbitrary) degrees of power, knowledge and freedom is simpler than any finite alternative.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: That confirmation is probabilistic rather than demonstrative; that the intrinsic simplicity of a hypothesis is evidentially relevant; that the pieces of evidence do not merely repeat one another.
- **Distinction.** FACT: A **cumulative case** is not a chain (as strong as its weakest link) but a **rope** or a legal brief (many strands, none sufficient alone). FACT: Distinguish it also from **inference to the best explanation**, which compares rival total hypotheses rather than accumulating probability.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: Basil Mitchell's analogy: a jury convicts on converging circumstantial evidence, none of which alone establishes guilt. FACT: Udayana's *Nyāyakusumāñjali* is structurally the same move made in the eleventh century - and should be presented that way in an Indian-Western comparison.
- **Objection -> reply.** FACT: **Antony Flew's "ten leaky buckets":** buckets that each leak hold no more water when stacked; zero plus zero is zero. **Reply:** the objection would be correct if each argument had *no* evidential force, but a C-inductive argument by definition has some; the correct image is strands of a rope, or Bayesian updating on successive independent evidence. ANALYSIS: **Second objection:** the same procedure would confirm rival hypotheses (a finite designer, a committee of gods, an axiarchic principle) - the cumulative case underdetermines *which* God. **Reply:** simplicity considerations are supposed to select the infinite single agent; critics reply that "simplicity" is doing contested metaphysical work. ANALYSIS: **Third:** evil is evidence on the other side, so the case must be run as a *net* balance, not a one-way sum - routed to Problem of Evil.
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "Individually the proofs fail as demonstrations; cumulatively they can at most establish a probability, and even then they underdetermine the personal, morally perfect God of worship. That gap - between the God of the arguments and the God of religion - is the standing conclusion of the entire clause."

9. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: Comparison earns marks only when thinkers are tested through a constant axis such as starting point, causal model, divine attributes, objection and final explanatory reach.

Proof	Starting point	Conclusion claimed	Indian parallel	Main critic
Ontological	FACT: Concept of maximal being	Necessary existence	ANALYSIS: No exact classical analogue	Gaunilo, Kant
Cosmological	FACT: Motion/causation/contingency	First/necessary cause	Nyāya <i>kāryāt</i>	Hume, Kant
Design	FACT: Order/purpose	Intelligent designer	Nyāya <i>āyojanāt</i>	Hume, Darwin
Moral	FACT: Moral law/highest good	Practical postulate	Karma-dispenser in theistic schools	Autonomy/Euthyphro
Mīmāṃsā critique	FACT: Eternal Veda and self-operating dharma	No creator required	-	Nyāya
Jain critique	FACT: Perfection excludes motive; karma is self-operating	No creator; divinity = perfected soul	-	Nyāya (adṛṣṭa needs an allocator)
Buddhist critique	FACT: Causal efficacy; <i>krama-akrama</i> dilemma	A permanent cause cannot produce a temporal world	-	Nyāya (eternal will, timed effects)
Cumulative case	FACT: Several C-inductive arguments	Probable theism	Udayana's eight-fold <i>stabaka</i>	Flew's leaky buckets

10. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Major criticism: A criticism should identify whether it attacks validity, a premise's truth or the adequacy of the conclusion, and the reply must answer that exact level.

Objection	Proof affected	Reply	Assessment
"Existence is not a predicate"	Ontological	Modal versions use necessary existence	ANALYSIS: Possibility premise bears the burden
Fallacy of composition	Cosmological	Argument concerns dependence, not shared property	ANALYSIS: Must state an essentially ordered series
Weak world-artifact analogy	Design/Nyāya	Treat as probabilistic, not deductive	ANALYSIS: Conclusion becomes modest
Cause need not be personal/perfect	Cosmological/design	Cumulative arguments add attributes	ANALYSIS: No single proof reaches classical theism
Karma can operate without God	Nyāya	Intelligent allocation explains specificity	CAUTION: Dispute tracks rival metaphysics

11. COMMON UPSC TRAPS

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Major criticism: The central examination trap is to collapse distinct doctrines or to claim that a criticism proves more than its argument actually establishes.

1. ANALYSIS: Do not merge Aquinas' five Ways into one temporal "first cause" argument.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute the watch analogy to Aquinas; it is associated with Paley.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not say Kant proves God through morality; he postulates God for practical reason.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not call Nyāya's God the material cause of atoms.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not present Hume as proving that no designer exists; his target is the inference's strength and conclusion.
6. ANALYSIS: Distinguish a proof's validity from the adequacy of the God it establishes.
7. ANALYSIS: **Do not invent Jain "proofs for God"**. Jainism proves no creator; it argues *against* one and relocates divinity in the perfected soul. Answer the printed stem by saying so in the first line.
8. ANALYSIS: Do not equate **Tirthaṅkara** and **Siddha**. Tirthaṅkara = an omniscient, still-embodied arihanta who re-founds the fourfold order and teaches (24 per half-cycle); Siddha = the disembodied liberated soul at the

siddhaśilā. Every Tīrthaṅkara becomes a Siddha; not every Siddha was a Tīrthaṅkara. Neither creates or responds.

9. ANALYSIS: Do not say Buddhism denies all gods. It denies a **creator**; devas are impermanent beings within saṃsāra.
10. ANALYSIS: Do not reduce the Buddhist case to "the Buddha was silent". The examinable argument is Dharmakīrti/Śāntarakṣita's **krama-akrama** dilemma about a permanent cause producing a temporal world.
11. ANALYSIS: Do not present Udayana's list as a fixed canonical eight without noting that glosses of *padāt/pratyayataḥ/vākyāt/saṃkhyāviśeṣāt* differ; give the Sanskrit term plus one clause of content.
12. ANALYSIS: Do not treat a cumulative case as a chain of deductions. It is Bayesian/rope-like; the standing objection is Flew's leaky buckets and the standing reply is that C-inductive arguments are not zero-valued.

12. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: Ontological arguments reason a priori from the God-concept, whereas cosmological, teleological and Nyāya (school of logic and realism) arguments reason a posteriori from experienced reality.

Keywords: FACT: *a priori* · *a posteriori* · ontological · necessary existence · real predicate · cosmological · essentially ordered series · contingency · sufficient reason · teleological · analogy · regularity · fine order · practical postulate · *summum bonum* · *kāryāt* · *āyojanāt* · *dhṛtyādeḥ* · *padāt* · *pratyayataḥ* · *śruteḥ* · *vākyāt* · *saṃkhyāviśeṣāt* · *apekṣā-buddhi* · efficient cause · *adrṣṭa* · *karmādhyakṣa* · *apauruṣeya* · *arthakriyā-kāritva* · *krama-akrama-virodha* · *pratītyasamutpāda* · *avyākata* · arihanta/kevalin · tīrthaṅkara · siddha · *ananta-catuṣṭaya* · *vītarāga* · *svabhāva* · *lāghava* (parsimony) · C-inductive/P-inductive · cumulative case · leaky buckets.

Safe formulations: ANALYSIS: "Most proofs underdetermine the rich God of religion." · "Nyāya and Western natural theology converge in inference from order, but diverge over material causation and karma." · "Jainism and Buddhism do not merely lack a proof of God; they supply arguments that a creator is either unmotivated or causally impossible." · "A cumulative case can raise probability; it cannot by itself select the God of worship."

CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (expanded PYQ audit)

- ANALYSIS: **Priority:** Primary ownership is 12 of 112 parts and now spans Indian and Western proof-families over the full eight years.
- FACT: **Required doctrinal depth:** The expanded burden includes Anselm, Jain proofs, the moral argument, Aquinas-Nyāya comparison and Buddhist anti-creator arguments, alongside Five Ways, design and Nyāya inference.
- WRONG: **Trap / answer consequence:** Do not list proofs without premises and target conclusion; distinguish critique of validity, soundness, divine attributes and the inference from a cause to the God of religion.

13. PYQ ROUTING (2018-2025)

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: ANALYSIS: Corpus signal: 12 primary-owned question-parts out of 112.

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** 12 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper II corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2018	Q6(c)	15 marks	Does the concept of God entail the existence of God? Examine from the perspective of ontological argument.
2018	Q8(a)	20 marks	Compare St. Thomas Aquinas' five ways of knowing God with the arguments of the Nyāya School of Indian Philosophy for the existence of God.
2018	Q8(b)	15 marks	Critically evaluate the Buddhist arguments against the existence of God as the creator of the world.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2019	Q5(e)	10 marks	State and evaluate the proofs for the existence of God as propounded in Jainism.
2020	Q6(a)	20 marks	Is the ontological proof for the existence of God by St. Anselm logical? Discuss.
2021	Q7(b)	15 marks	Give a critical account of moral argument to prove the existence of God.
2022	Q6(a)	20 marks	Present a critical exposition of different arguments offered by St. Thomas Aquinas to prove the existence of God also known as 'Five Ways'. Which one of them do you find philosophically most interesting? Give reasons in support of your answer.
2022	Q8(a)	20 marks	Discuss the main points of distinction between a priori and a posteriori arguments for the existence of God. Which one according to you should be preferred over the other? Give reasons and justifications for your answer.
2023	Q7(a)	20 marks	Critically examine the arguments of Nyāya for the existence of God.
2024	Q7(c)	15 marks (10+5)	Present an exposition of ontological proof for the existence of God along with its criticism.
2025	Q6(a)	20 marks	Present an account of Design argument to prove the existence of God along with its criticism by David Hume.
2025	Q7(b)	15 marks	What proofs do Nyāya philosophers offer for the existence of God? Discuss.

See the Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018-2025.

14. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 MARKS)

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: A high-scoring answer moves from exact definition to argument reconstruction, objection and reply, comparison and a criterion-based graded verdict.

10 marks

Name and classify the proof -> state premises in sequence -> identify one presupposition -> give the canonical objection -> one-sentence verdict on what the proof actually establishes.

15 marks

Frame the explanatory question -> reconstruct argument -> canonical example -> critic's strongest objection -> proponent's reply -> assess validity and conclusion separately.

20 marks

Classify the family of proofs -> full internal steps -> contrast Indian/Western analogue -> two objections and replies -> underdetermination of divine attributes -> graded conclusion.

15. DIRECTIVE DECODER (what the verb obliges you to produce)

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: The directive fixes the answer's burden: exposition requires accurate reconstruction, comparison requires a constant axis, and critical examination requires objection, reply and verdict.

Directive	Examiner is buying	Structural consequence	Live example
Present an account of... along with its criticism	Two balanced halves, explicitly signposted	Split the page - exposition first, then critique; do not let critique eat exposition	2025 Q6(a) design + Hume; 2024 Q7(c) ontological (10+5 - obey the split)
Critically examine / evaluate	Reconstruction and verdict on validity <i>and</i> soundness	Premises -> presupposition -> objection -> reply -> graded verdict	2023 Q7(a) Nyāya; 2018 Q8(b) Buddhist

Directive	Examiner is buying	Structural consequence	Live example
Compare X with Y	A stated <i>tertium comparationis</i>	Announce the axes first, then run both down each axis	2018 Q8(a) Aquinas vs Nyāya -> use §5A
Which do you find most interesting? Give reasons	A defended personal selection with a criterion	Name the criterion (explanatory reach? least contested premise?) before choosing	2022 Q6(a) Five Ways
Does the concept entail the existence?	Engagement with the <i>predicate</i> question	Kant's premise must be stated, not just named	2018 Q6(c)
Which should be preferred? Give reasons	Ranking with a cost accounting	Prefer one, then state precisely what you lose	2022 Q8(a) a priori vs a posteriori
State and evaluate the proofs propounded in [school]	Fidelity to what the school actually holds	If the school holds none, say so <i>in line 1</i> and supply what it does hold	2019 Q5(e) Jainism -> §8.6
What proofs do X offer? Discuss	Enumeration with premises , not a list of labels	One line of content per named <i>hetu</i>	2025 Q7(b) Nyāya -> §8.4 table

MEMORY: **Rule:** for every proof, answer three separate questions - is it **valid**? are its premises **true**? and does its conclusion reach the **God of religion**? Most scripts answer only the first.

16. GRADED VERDICT LADDER

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Final verdict: A graded verdict should state what the argument establishes, what it fails to establish and which disputed premise determines the remaining uncertainty.

Band	What the script contains	Typical fault
Weak (≈40%)	Names the four Western proofs and "Nyāya's inference"; narrates the watch	No premises; critique reduced to "Kant disagreed"
Average (≈50%)	One proof reconstructed; standard critique attached	Indian side reduced to one sentence; no distinction between validity and soundness
Good (≈60%)	Premises numbered; presupposition named; one objection answered	Conclusion-gap (from "first cause" to "God") not noticed
Strong (≈65-70%)	Validity/soundness/adequacy separated; Indian parallel argued, not asserted; reply to the objection	Cumulative logic still treated as a chain
Top (≈70%+)	All the above + a discriminating distinction (essentially vs accidentally ordered series; C- vs P-inductive; Tīrthaṅkara vs Siddha; <i>krama-akrama</i>) + a statement of what evidence would change the verdict	-

Graded-verdict templates:

- ANALYSIS: *Single-proof stem*: "The argument is valid on reading X but its second premise is exactly what the critic denies; even if sound it delivers only ____, and the distance from that to the God of worship must be crossed by a separate argument."
- ANALYSIS: *Comparison stem*: "Aquinas and Udayana converge in form - both are cumulative inferences from the world's dependence and order - and diverge in content: Aquinas' God is the source of *being*, Udayana's the arranger of *eternal* atoms and the allocator of karma."
- ANALYSIS: *Anti-theistic stem*: "The school's negative case succeeds against the creator it targets - an anthropomorphic, motivated, changing maker - and leaves untouched the classical theist's non-needy, timeless creator; whether that surviving concept is intelligible is a different question."

17. FACTUAL AND QUOTATION DISCIPLINE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: Use quotations only with secure attribution, and prefer an accurate paraphrase to a decorative or uncertain formula.

Item	Status	Safe use
"That than which nothing greater can be conceived"	FACT: Anselm, <i>Proslogion</i> 2	Quote; then give the reductio form
"Existence is not a real predicate"	FACT: Kant, <i>Critique of Pure Reason</i> , A598/B626 region	Quote in this standard English form
Watch-and-watchmaker	FACT: Paley , <i>Natural Theology</i> (1802), ch. 1	Never attribute to Aquinas
Aquinas' Five Ways	FACT: <i>ST I</i> q.2 a.3	Way 5 is about regular directedness, <i>not</i> Paley's artifact analogy
Hume's design critique	FACT: <i>Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion</i> (posth. 1779), Parts II, V, VII, XI	Philo, not Cleanthes, carries the objections
Udayana's grounds	FACT: <i>Nyāyakusumāñjali</i> , 5th <i>stabaka</i>	Give Sanskrit term + one clause; flag that glosses vary CAUTION:
Jain anti-creator arguments	FACT: Assembled in Jinasena's <i>Mahāpurāṇa</i> and Hemacandra	Attribute to the tradition; avoid verbatim English "quotations"
Buddhist anti-Īśvara argument	FACT: Śāntarakṣita, <i>Tattvasaṃgraha</i> (with Kamalaśīla's <i>Pañjikā</i>); Dharmakīrti	Cite the <i>argument</i> , not an English sentence
<i>Brahmajāla</i> (DN 1), <i>Aggañña</i> (DN 27), <i>Devadaha</i> (MN 101)	FACT: Verified nikāya references	Paraphrase; translations differ
Bhūridatta Jātaka anti-creator verses	CAUTION: Widely cited, wording translation-dependent	Paraphrase only
"Ten leaky buckets"	FACT: Antony Flew, <i>God and Philosophy</i>	Pair it with the rope/Bayesian reply
C-inductive / P-inductive	FACT: Richard Swinburne's terminology, <i>The Existence of God</i>	Use precisely - they are not synonyms

18. LINK-OUTS

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: Notions of God — what kind of God the proofs are supposed to reach.

- Notions of God - what kind of God the proofs are supposed to reach
- Reason, Revelation and Faith - what follows when the proofs underdetermine
- Problem of Evil - the counter-evidence a cumulative case must net out
- Religion without God - Cārvāka on inference to the supersensible; Mīmāṃsā's *apūrva*
- Paper I: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika - *anumāna*, *vyāpti*, atomism, *adṛṣṭa*
- Paper I: Jainism - six *dravyas*, karmic matter, the *guṇasthāna* ladder
- Paper I: Buddhism - *pratītyasamutpāda*, momentariness, *arthakriyā*
- Paper I: Cārvāka - the attack on inference that undercuts every *anumāna*-based proof
- Paper I: Mīmāṃsā - *apauruṣeya* Veda against Udayana's *vākyāt/śruteḥ*
- Paper I: Kant - the predicate objection and the practical postulate
- Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018-2025

Philosophy of Religion dossier: Topic 2 - [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: ##### 2. Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique.

2. Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening definition: A proof of God is an argument from concept, world or moral experience to divine existence, and its critique must separately test validity, soundness and adequacy.

- **Core prerequisite:** Finish ontological, cosmological, teleological, moral, Nyāya proofs, the standard Hume/Kant/Mīmāṃsā/Buddhist critiques, a priori vs a posteriori, and the owner's answer architectures for 2018-2025 proof questions.

Optional advanced debate	Precise competing positions	Strongest extra objection -> counter-reply	Safe use in a 15/20-marker
ANALYSIS: Modal ontological argument vs Kantian/ parody critique	Modal defenders argue that if a maximally great being is possible, it exists necessarily; Kantian critics deny that conceptual analysis can secure existence, while parody critics attack the form.	Objection: the possibility premise quietly assumes what it must prove. -> Reply: the debate shifts from bare existence to the coherence of maximal greatness.	Use as a one-line "modern repair attempt" after Anselm/Descartes, never instead of the core ontological structure.
ANALYSIS: Principle of sufficient reason vs brute-fact universe	Rationalists and Thomists deny that contingent reality can be explanatorily ultimate; Humean or anti-PSR critics allow brute fact or infinite regress.	Objection: the total universe may simply be there. -> Reply: contingent totality still lacks self-explanation, so the explanatory demand does not disappear by enlarging the set.	Useful for the evaluative conclusion of cosmological arguments.
ANALYSIS: Fine-tuning / Bayesian cumulative case vs underdetermination	Some modern theists present design probabilistically through fine-tuning and cumulative evidence; critics appeal to multiverse hypotheses or underdetermination.	Objection: probabilistic design is too weak and rivals remain available. -> Reply: defenders present it as an inference-to-best-explanation supplement, not a knock-down proof.	Mention only as a modern extension of teleology; do not replace Paley, Aquinas, or Hume in UPSC exposition.
ANALYSIS: Udayana-style cumulative Nyāya theism vs Mīmāṃsā/Buddhist anti-creator lines	Udayana multiplies inferential routes to Īśvara; Mīmāṃsā, Buddhism, and anti-creator schools resist the need for a divine allocator or author.	Objection: karma, Veda, and order can function without a creator. -> Reply: Nyāya insists unconscious <i>adr̥ṣṭa</i> and authorless linguistic normativity cannot by themselves explain ordered allocation and intelligibility.	Strong optional finish in Nyāya answers to show that Indian debate is not just a single <i>kāryāt</i> inference.

- **What not to over-study:** Do not load answers with modal notation, probability equations, or every listed proof in *Nyāyakusumāñjali*.
- **Promotion trigger:** Promote if a PYQ asks modal versions, cumulative-case reasoning, or specialist Nyāya-Udayana reconstruction directly.
- **Credible source trail:** FACT: Anselm, *Proslogion*; FACT: Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* / *Summa Contra Gentiles*; FACT: David Hume, *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion*; FACT: Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*; FACT: Udayana, *Nyāyakusumāñjali*; FACT: B.K. Matilal, writings on Nyāya reasoning and Indian philosophical method.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Placement note: These register notes come **after** all teaching and practice, and cover **every one of the eight subtopics** taught in this session. They are the last-mile revision layer, not a substitute for the session above.

Register 1 - The architecture of theistic proof

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening definition: Theistic proofs are best classified by starting point, inferential form and the concept of God reached, then tested separately for validity, soundness and adequacy.

Item	Register entry
Syllabus wording	FACT: "Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique (Indian and Western)"
Three senses of "proof"	FACT: Demonstration · probable/explanatory inference · practical postulate
The assessment grid	ANALYSIS: Validity (does it follow?) -> Soundness (are the premises true?) -> Adequacy (is the being reached <i>God</i> ?)
A priori route	FACT: Ontological only (Anselm, Descartes)
A posteriori routes	FACT: Cosmological, teleological, moral, Nyāya <i>Īśvara-anumāna</i>
A priori strength / weakness	FACT: Yields necessity / ANALYSIS: commits the existence-predicate fallacy
A posteriori strength / weakness	FACT: Begins from conceded facts / ANALYSIS: reaches only a probable, finite cause
2022 verdict formula	ANALYSIS: Preference depends on the criterion: evidential contact -> a posteriori; modal strength -> a priori; religious adequacy -> neither alone
Mnemonic	MEMORY: O-C-T-M + N , critiqued by J-B-M

Register 2 - Ontological argument

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening definition: The ontological argument seeks to infer necessary existence from the concept of the greatest conceivable or maximally perfect being.

- FACT: **Anselm's definition**: "that than which nothing greater can be conceived"; "greater" = more perfect. Not "the most perfect being that there is".
- FACT: **First form (Proslogion 2)**: existing in reality is greater than existing in the mind alone; hence God exists in reality. Addressed to the Psalmist's "fool".
- FACT: **Second form (Proslogion 3)**: a being that cannot be thought not to exist is greater; hence God exists **necessarily**. Core notion = **aseity / self-existence**.
- FACT: **Descartes (Meditations V)**: existence belongs to the essence of a supremely perfect being as three angles to a triangle, or a valley to a mountain.
- ANALYSIS: Descartes' *Meditations* III causal proof is a **different** argument - do not merge.
- FACT: **Gaunilo, In Behalf of the Fool**: the perfect-island parody. ANALYSIS: He should have said "most perfect *conceivable* island".
- FACT: **Anselm's reply**: only God is defined with necessary existence; an island is by definition a contingent piece of land surrounded by water.
- FACT: **Kant**: "existence is not a real predicate"; a hundred real thalers contain no more concept than a hundred possible ones.

- FACT: **Chatterjee-Datta's Indian idiom**: the thought of a hundred rupees in my pocket involves the *idea* of their existence, not their real physical existence.
- ANALYSIS: **Post-Fregean objection**: existence is second-order (instantiation of a concept), so it cannot appear among perfections.
- ANALYSIS: **Modal repair (Malcolm, Hartshorne, Plantinga)**: if a maximally great being is possible, it exists necessarily - but the **possibility premise bears the whole burden**, and a parallel "possibly no such being" reverses the result.
- ANALYSIS: **2018 verdict**: the concept entails existence *conditionally*; it does not entail instantiation.
- ANALYSIS: **India**: no classical analogue; Indian epistemology grounds existence-claims in world-involving *pramāṇas*.
- MEMORY: **A-D-G-K-M**: Anselm defines · Descartes essentialises · Gaunilo parodies · Kant diagnoses · Modal logic repairs.

Register 3 - Cosmological arguments

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Core argument: FACT: Ways 1–3 are cosmological; Way 4 is henological; Way 5 is teleological.

- FACT: **Five Ways (ST I q.2 a.3)**: motion -> prime mover; causation -> first cause; contingency -> necessary being; degrees -> maximum; purposiveness -> designer. Each ends "and this everyone understands to be God".
- FACT: **Ways 1-3 are cosmological; Way 4 is henological; Way 5 is teleological.**
- ANALYSIS: **Essentially ordered (per se) series**: hand -> stick -> stone; derivative power throughout; removal stops the series *now*. This is what Aquinas terminates.
- ANALYSIS: **Accidentally ordered (per accidens) series**: grandfather -> father -> son; Aquinas need not stop it.
- FACT: **"First" = explanatory priority**, not the earliest event in time.
- FACT: Aquinas concedes the difficulty of excluding an endless regress of *events*; he holds the world's temporal beginning is known by faith, not demonstration.
- FACT: **Neo-Thomist reformulation**: the excluded series is simultaneous dependence, not backward time.
- ANALYSIS: **Way 3's weak steps**: possible quantifier shift at "at some time nothing would have existed"; and the *necessary ab alio / necessary a se* distinction at the end.
- ANALYSIS: **Way 4**: degrees imply a maximum - defensible only through the metaphysics of participation.
- ANALYSIS: **Kalām**: whatever begins to exist has a cause; the universe began; □ it has a cause. **Argues for a temporal beginning - Aquinas does not.**
- ANALYSIS: **Leibniz/PSR**: why is there something rather than nothing? Every fact needs a sufficient reason; a contingent totality is not self-explanatory.
- FACT: **Hume**: why not an infinite series? explaining each part may explain the whole; the cause need not be one, personal, infinite or good.
- FACT: **Kant**: the passage from "a necessary being" to "the ens realissimum" is the ontological argument in disguise - an **adequacy-tier** objection.
- ANALYSIS: **Composition charge** is met by framing dependence rather than property-transfer.
- MEMORY: **M-C-C-D-P**: Motion, Causation, Contingency, Degrees, Purpose.

Register 4 - Teleological argument

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Core argument: FACT: Paley's evidence is cumulative: the eye as a self-adjusting optical instrument, the bird's wing, the fish's fin, planetary rotation, the seasons.

- FACT: **Three distinct teleologies**: Aquinas' Way 5 (regular directedness of non-cognitive nature; **archer and arrow**) · Paley's **analogy** from artefact to organism · modern **fine-tuning** (probabilistic, pre-biological).
- FACT: The design argument runs from Plato's *Timaeus* through Aquinas to Paley's *Natural Theology* (1802).

- FACT: **Paley's watch on the heath**: wheels, cogs, axles, springs and balances working together for regular timekeeping oblige us to postulate an intelligent maker; a stone does not.
- FACT: **Paley's three riders**: the inference survives (i) never having seen a watch made, (ii) imperfect working, (iii) parts whose function we cannot discover.
- FACT: **Paley's evidence is cumulative**: the eye as a self-adjusting optical instrument, the bird's wing, the fish's fin, planetary rotation, the seasons.
- FACT: **Hume's Dialogues (1779) precede Paley (1802)**; Paley took no apparent account of them.
- FACT: **Hume front 1**: any persisting universe must exhibit adaptation - there could not be birds with wings unable to live in air. **Epicurean hypothesis**: finite particles in random motion pass through every combination in unlimited time; one is a stable order.
- FACT: **Hume front 2**: the universe is as like a vegetable or a crustacean as a machine; only strong analogy with a known artefact licenses the inference.
- FACT: **Hume front 3**: proportion cause to effect - from a finite world one can never infer an infinite creator (**the scales illustration**).
- FACT: **Hume front 4**: many designers, an inferior deity, an infant or senile one, or an abandoned first attempt fit the evidence equally.
- FACT: **Hume front 5**: evil and disorder count against a good and powerful designer.
- FACT: **Hume does not disprove a designer**; he attacks inference-strength and divine attributes.
- FACT: **Darwin**: random variation plus differential survival explains adaptation. **Ozone illustration**: life fitted itself to the filter, not the filter to life.
- ANALYSIS: **Darwin's exact scope**: defeats Paley's biological premise; does not touch law-governedness or the fine-tuning of constants.
- ANALYSIS: **Fine-tuning**: Bayesian/explanatory, not analogical; rivals are multiverse plus observation-selection, and brute necessity.
- FACT: **Indian analogue**: āyōjanāt, pot and potter; Chatterjee-Datta note the parallels in **Janet, Lotze and Martineau**, but stress that Western theists make God the source of *existence* while Nyāya makes God only the cause of *order*.
- MEMORY: **Hume's five fronts, A-A-P-P-E**: Any universe looks adapted · Analogy weak · Proportion cause to effect · Plurality/imperfection of designers · Evil.

Register 5 - Moral argument

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Core argument: FACT: Kant's structure: moral law obligates -> its complete object is the highest good (virtue + proportionate happiness) -> ought implies can -> holiness unattainable in finite time (immortality) and nature does not proportion happiness to virtue (God) -> plus freedom, presupposed by obligation.

- FACT: **Kant's two storeys**: *Critique of Pure Reason* destroys the ontological, cosmological and physico-theological proofs; *Critique of Practical Reason* reinstates God as a postulate.
- FACT: **First form (Newman, Grammar of Assent)**: conscience implies One before whom we are ashamed and responsible. FACT: **Hick's objection**: it assumes moral values resist naturalistic explanation - which **begs the question**.
- FACT: **Kant's structure**: moral law obligates -> its complete object is the **highest good** (virtue + proportionate happiness) -> ought implies can -> holiness unattainable in finite time (**immortality**) and nature does not proportion happiness to virtue (**God**) -> plus **freedom**, presupposed by obligation.
- FACT: **Three postulates: freedom, immortality, God**.
- ANALYSIS: A postulate is practically necessary, theoretically undemonstrable - *Vernunftglaube*, rational faith; subjectively sufficient, objectively insufficient assent.
- FACT: **Hick's verdict**: moral seriousness is "at least a move in the direction of belief in God", but moral values cannot be said to point all the way to the infinite, omnipotent, self-existent personal creator.

- ANALYSIS: **Objections:** projection/wish-fulfilment; autonomy tension; adequacy. **Euthyphro strikes divine-command theories, not Kant** - for Kant the moral law is autonomous and God guarantees proportion, not obligation.
- FACT: **Indian counterpart:** Nyāya's **karmaphaladātā**. Chatterjee-Datta write: "*Or, as Kant would say, it is God who combines happiness with virtue and misery with vice.*"
- ANALYSIS: **Key contrast:** Kant postulates a God who *could* proportion; Nyāya infers a God who *does* - epistemically bolder, correspondingly more exposed.
- MEMORY: **F-I-G:** Freedom · Immortality · God.

Register 6 - Nyāya-Udayana theism

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Recommended opening definition: FACT: Nature of Īśvara (Lord or personal God): first efficient cause, a demiurgus or builder — not the material cause; also preserver (the world is kept in existence by God's will) and destroyer (when the moral order requires).

- FACT: **Nature of Īśvara:** first **efficient** cause, a demiurgus or builder - **not the material cause**; also preserver (the world is kept in existence by God's will) and destroyer (when the moral order requires).
- FACT: One, infinite, eternal; the world is related to God as a body to the self residing in it; omnipotent yet **guided by the merit and demerit of human actions**; omniscient.
- FACT: **Eternal intelligence is an inseparable attribute of God, not His essence** - the explicit contrast with Advaita.
- FACT: Possesses the six perfections (*ṣaḍ-aiśvarya*).
- FACT: **God is prayojaka kartā** - efficient *directive* cause of human action; man is the efficient *instrumental* cause and is only relatively free, directed as a wise father directs a son.
- FACT: **God is karmaphaladātā** - impartial dispenser of the fruits of action, moral governor, supreme arbiter of joys and sorrows.
- FACT: **Theism, not deism:** the deist's God withdraws like a clock-maker; Nyāya's God maintains a continuous relation as creator, maintainer and destroyer.
- FACT: **Ten proofs are claimed; the more important are usually four or five.** CAUTION: Enumerations vary - say so.
- FACT: **Kāryāt:** composite objects are effects because they are **made of parts (sāvayava)** and possess **intermediate magnitude (avāntara-mahattva)**; space, time, ether and self are excluded as partless infinities, and atoms and manas as simple infinitesimals; material causes alone cannot achieve the required order, direction and co-ordination; the intelligent cause must know the atoms, desire an end and will its realisation; **and must be omniscient, since only an omniscient being can directly know atoms.**
- FACT: **Āyojanāt:** inert atoms require purposive combination.
- FACT: **Dhṛtyādeḥ:** support, maintenance and destruction require governance.
- FACT: **Padāt / āptaprāmānya:** the Veda's authority derives from an omniscient author, as a science's authority derives from its founder; the *jīva* cannot be that author because supramundane realities exceed ordinary knowledge.
- FACT: **Śruteḥ:** *Bṛhadāraṇyaka*, *Śvetāśvatara*, *Kauṣītaki* and the *Bhagavadgītā* testify to God.
- FACT: **Argument from adrṣṭa:** differences of lot require a cause -> karma -> the time-gap requires a persisting stock of **punya and pāpa = adrṣṭa** -> *adrṣṭa* is unintelligent and cannot allot the right kind and degree of joy and sorrow; individual selves neither know nor control it -> □ an eternal, omnipotent, omniscient dispenser.
- FACT: **Circularity objection answered:** in the **order of existence** God creates the Veda; in the **order of knowledge** the Veda leads to God. Reciprocal dependence across different orders is not a vicious circle.
- FACT: **Bodiless-agent objection answered** by a dilemma: if God's existence is already proved by śruti the objection is idle; if not, it presupposes what it disputes.
- FACT: **Western parallels:** Janet, Lotze, Martineau; FACT: **decisive divergence** - they make God the creative energy giving existence to things, Nyāya makes God the cause of order only.

- ANALYSIS: **Śaṅkara's atomism dilemma**: atoms active -> permanent creation; inactive -> no creation; both -> contradiction; neither -> an outside agency, itself problematic.
- ANALYSIS: **Sharma's redundancy objection**: Nyāya's God is "reduced to the status of a supervisor" with "hands and feet chained by the shackles of the Law of Karma unfolding itself as the *Adṛṣṭa*"; the system "could have easily done away with a God".
- FACT: **Chatterjee-Datta's own conclusion**: none of the proofs can prove God, because God, as ultimate reality, is the highest of all premises and cannot be deduced from an anterior one; **God must be known through direct experience**. Lotze: "all proofs that God exists are pleas put forward in justification of our faith."
- MEMORY: **K-A-D-P-Ś + adṛṣṭa** · MEMORY: **E-A-K-V**: Efficient cause · Atoms · Karma · Veda.

Register 7 - Jaina, Buddhist, Mīmāṃsā and Cārvāka critiques

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: FACT: Denies God as creator; the world was never created; substances are eternal and change through modes; *utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya*.

Jainism

- FACT: Denies God as **creator**; the world was never created; substances are eternal and change through **modes**; *utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya*.
- FACT: **"Jainism denies God, but does not deny godhead. Every liberated soul is a god."** Tīrthaṅkaras were mortals who won liberation by personal effort - "we are all potential Jinās". A religion of self-help.
- ANALYSIS: **Proof 1 (svabhāva)**: the *jīva* intrinsically possesses *ananta-catuṣṭaya* - infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and power - obscured, not absent.
- ANALYSIS: **Proof 2 (sarvajña-siddhi)**: mati, śruta, avadhi and manañparyāya map degrees of karmic obstruction; complete removal is the limiting case = **kevala-jñāna**.
- ANALYSIS: **Proof 3 (āpta-vacana)**: the testimony of the omniscient Tīrthaṅkaras, one leg of the **tri-ratna**.
- FACT: **Jaina God**: plural, achieved, non-creative, non-interventionist, exemplary.
- ANALYSIS: **Anti-creator arguments**: from what material? why create at all (a perfect being lacks nothing)? if from compassion, why suffering? if in sport, God is childish and cruel; who made God - and if God is self-existent, so may the world be; karma suffices.
- ANALYSIS: **Sharma's internal objection**: if ignorance and karma are inseparable from the soul, liberation is impossible; if external, bondage is impossible.
- ANALYSIS: **Nāstika** means denier of **Vedic authority**, not denier of spirit.

Buddhism

- FACT: An eternal unchanging God cannot create, since willing or producing involves change.
- FACT: Creation from desire or purpose implies lack or incompleteness.
- FACT: Suffering and evil sit uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator.
- FACT: **Dependent origination** already explains arising through conditions, making a creator unnecessary.
- ANALYSIS: The *avyākṛta* questions and the **arrow parable**: first-beginning questions are soteriologically idle.
- ANALYSIS: Freedom/karma dilemma: if God determines all, moral effort is empty; if not, God is not the sufficient cause.
- ANALYSIS: **Dharmakīrti-type argument**: a permanent, immutable cause cannot produce *successive* effects.
- FACT: The critique is a **systematic refusal of explanatory surplus**, not bare atheism.
- ANALYSIS: **Replies to note**: Nyāya on determinate allocation; the eternal-act/temporal-effect answer to the change objection; diffusive goodness against the desire objection; economy is a methodological preference, not a disproof.

Mīmāṃsā

- FACT: The Veda is **apauruṣeya** - eternal, authorless, self-valid; no human and **no divine** author is needed.
- FACT: Authorlessness protects it from an author's deceit or ignorance.

- FACT: Against Nyāya: proving God, then His omniscience, then His truthfulness, is a cumbersome three-stage dependence that authorlessness avoids.
- FACT: **Apūrva** - the unseen potency of correctly performed ritual - matures into future fruit **without a divine dispenser**; Prābhākara's **niyoga** grounds obligation in the injunction itself.
- FACT: Chatterjee-Datta record Max Müller's point that a creator God would face charges of **cruelty and partiality**, and his further point that denying a *creator* is not denying God.
- ANALYSIS: Their own criticism: Mīmāṃsā deities are not objects of worship and exist only in the *mantras* describing them - "eternal and self-manifesting concepts"; God is relegated to an ambiguous position.

Cārvāka

- FACT: God cannot be perceived; the world is made by the **automatic combination of the material elements**; the Vedas and priests are rejected.
- ANALYSIS: Perception alone is a *pramāṇa*, so every inferential proof is undercut at the outset.

Classification key

- MEMORY: **E-C-E**: every Indian anti-creator argument is an **E**conomy move, a **C**oherence move, or an **E**pistemic-restriction move.

Register 8 - Comparative synthesis and answer architecture

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Final verdict: Comparison is strongest when each position is judged through the same axes of ultimate reality, world relation, human relation, causation and religious function.

Item	Register entry
Convergence	FACT: India and the West both build a posteriori inferences from order to intelligence
Divergence 1	FACT: Aquinas' God causes being ; Nyāya's Īśvara causes only order
Divergence 2	FACT: Creation <i>ex nihilo</i> vs eternal atoms as material cause
Divergence 3	FACT: Nyāya makes God the Veda's author; Mīmāṃsā makes the Veda authorless - no Western analogue
Divergence 4	ANALYSIS: India's sharpest anti-theistic critiques come from <i>within</i> orthodoxy (Mīmāṃsā, Sāṃkhya)
Four defensible verdicts	ANALYSIS: V1 minimal (no proof is demonstrative) · V2 cumulative · V3 divergent (different proofs establish different things) · V4 experiential (Lotze/Chatterjee-Datta)
10-mark spine	Classify -> premises -> one presupposition -> canonical objection -> one-line verdict (≈150 words)
15-mark spine	Frame -> reconstruct -> canonical example -> strongest objection -> best reply -> assess validity and adequacy separately (≈220-260 words)
20-mark spine	Classify family -> full steps -> Indian/Western contrast -> two objections with replies -> underdetermination of attributes -> criterion-named graded conclusion (≈320-360 words)
2022 "most interesting Way"	ANALYSIS: Defend Way 3 (why anything at all; PSR debate) or Way 5 (richest downstream tradition); never describe Way 2 as "who started the universe"

Register 9 - The eleven master traps

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM Major criticism: ANALYSIS: Do not present Hume as proving that no designer exists; his target is the inference's strength and its conclusion's attributes.

1. ANALYSIS: Do not merge Aquinas' five Ways into one temporal "first cause" argument.

2. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute the watch analogy to Aquinas; it belongs to Paley.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not say Kant proves God through morality; he **postulates** God for practical reason.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not call Nyāya's God the **material** cause; atoms are the eternal material causes.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not present Hume as proving that no designer exists; his target is the inference's strength and its conclusion's attributes.
6. ANALYSIS: Distinguish a proof's **validity** from the **adequacy** of the God it establishes.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not omit Anselm's second form; the reply to Gaunilo depends on it.
8. ANALYSIS: Modal ontological versions carry a **possibility-premise burden**; they do not defeat Kant cleanly.
9. ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā's Veda is *apauruṣeya* and karma can be **self-operating** - the exact contradictory of Nyāya's third and *adṛṣṭa* proofs.
10. ANALYSIS: "Jainism is atheistic" misreads the 2019 question: Jainism denies God, not godhead.
11. ANALYSIS: Do not conflate the Kalām (temporal beginning) with Aquinas' Ways (explanatory priority).

Register 10 - Keyword and statement bank

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: Ontological arguments reason a priori from the God-concept, whereas cosmological, teleological and Nyāya (school of logic and realism) arguments reason a posteriori from experienced reality.

Keywords: FACT: *a priori* · *a posteriori* · ontological · necessary existence · aseity · real predicate · reductio · maximal greatness · possibility premise · cosmological · essentially ordered series (*per se*) · accidentally ordered series (*per accidens*) · contingency · principle of sufficient reason · Kalām · teleological · analogy · means-end adjustment · Epicurean hypothesis · natural selection · fine-tuning · multiverse · *summum bonum* · practical postulate · *Vernunftglaube* · autonomy · Euthyphro · *kāryāt* · *āyōjanāt* · *dhr̥tyādeḥ* · *padāt* · *śruteḥ* · *sāvayava* · *avāntara-mahattva* · *nimitta-kāraṇa* vs *upādāna-kāraṇa* · *adṛṣṭa* · *punya* / *pāpa* · *karmaphaladātā* · *prayojaka kartā* · *ṣaḍ-aiśvarya* · *ananta-catuṣṭaya* · *kevala-jñāna* · *siddha* · *tri-ratna* · *utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya* · *pratītyasamutpāda* · *avyākṛta* · *apauruṣeya* · *svataḥ-prāmānya* · *apūrva* · *niyoga* · *āpta-prāmānya*.

Safe formulations:

- ANALYSIS: "Most proofs underdetermine the rich God of religion."
- ANALYSIS: "Nyāya and Western natural theology converge in inference from order, but diverge over material causation and karma."
- ANALYSIS: "Hume did not disprove design; he dismantled the strength of the inference and the identity of the designer."
- ANALYSIS: "Kant does not prove God; he shows what a serious moral agent must rationally hope."
- ANALYSIS: "Jainism denies God but not godhead: godhood is achieved, plural and non-creative."
- ANALYSIS: "Where the West's sharpest critics of theism stood outside religion, India's stood inside it."

Register 11 - Last-minute memory spine

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM High-value transition: End of the complete learning session and consolidated register notes.

TAXONOMY : *a priori* (ontological) | *a posteriori* (cosmo, teleo, moral, Nyaya)
 GRID : validity -> soundness -> adequacy of the God established
 ANSELM : P2 existence · P3 NECESSARY existence · Gaunilo · Kant · modal burden
 AQUINAS : motion · causation · contingency · degrees · purpose
 per se series (hand-stick-stone) · "first" = explanatory
 DESIGN : Way 5 (archer) ≠ Paley (watch) ≠ fine-tuning (constants)
 HUME : A-A-P-P-E (adapted · analogy · proportion · plurality · evil)
 KANT : CPR destroys · CPR postulates · F-I-G · *summum bonum*
 NYAYA : K-A-D-P-S + *adrsta* · EFFICIENT cause only · *karmaphaladata*
 CRITICS : Jaina (godhead, not God) · Bauddha (conditions suffice) ·
 Mimamsa (*apauruseya* + *apurva*) · Carvaka (no perception) ·
 Advaita (only *saguna*) · Sharma (redundancy)
 VERDICT : classify -> reconstruct -> presuppose -> object -> reply -> GRADE

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

High-yield use: Follow the sessions consecutively as one continuous source-derived teaching and answer-writing route.

Proofs for the Existence of God and their Critique – COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

START / CENTRAL QUESTION

Almost every UPSC critique question ("critically examine", "along with its criticism") is answered by locating the objection on one of these three tiers instead of shouting a general "the proof fails".

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+-- SESSION 01: THE THREE QUESTIONS EVERY PROOF MUST SURVIVE

| DEFINITION / TERMS : Almost every UPSC critique question ("critically examine", "along with its criticism") is answered by locating the objection on one of these three tiers instead of shouting a general "the proof fails".

| MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Almost every UPSC critique question ("critically examine", "along with its criticism") is answered by locating the objection on one of these three tiers instead of shouting a general "the proof fails".

| CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Do not treat "proof" univocally: demonstration, probable inference and practical postulate have different success conditions. Do not say the ontological argument is a posteriori because Anselm "observes" that people have the idea of God – the premise is conceptual. Do not equate "a priori" with "certain" and "a posteriori" with "uncertain"; a priori reasoning can be invalid, and a posteriori reasoning can be strong. Distinguish validity from soundness from adequacy of the God established.

| TRAP / ANSWER-USE: The a priori proof promises necessity but is charged with the existence-predicate fallacy.

| EXAM OPENING: Every proof must be tested for validity, soundness and adequacy: whether the conclusion follows, the premises are true and the being reached is genuinely God.

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+-- SESSION 02: THE ONTOLOGICAL ARGUMENT AS A REDUCTIO

| DEFINITION / TERMS : Distinction to state in the answer: Anselm argues by reductio from a comparative ("greater than"); Descartes argues from essence containment ("existence is a perfection").

| MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Distinction to state in the answer: Anselm argues by reductio from a comparative ("greater than"); Descartes argues from essence containment ("existence is a perfection").

| CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: It is the argument that has attracted the most sustained modern logical attention of all the proofs. Do not manufacture an "Indian ontological argument" out of Advaita.

| TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not fuse the two; the causal one is not ontological.

| EXAM OPENING: The ontological argument is an a priori attempt to derive God's necessary existence from the concept of the greatest conceivable being.

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+-- SESSION 03: TWO KINDS OF CAUSAL SERIES (THE WHOLE ARGUMENT TURNS ON THIS)

| DEFINITION / TERMS : Presupposition: the act-potency analysis of change, and the claim that derivative causal power must be traced to non-derivative power here and now.

| MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Kant's objection, spelled out because it is frequently mis-stated: the cosmological argument concludes to a necessary being; but to move from "a necessary being" to "the most real being (ens realissimum), i.e.

| CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Kant's point is therefore an adequacy-tier attack: the cosmological argument's own resources take it only to "something necessary", and it borrows the rest.

| TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Keep them apart. Do not say Hume "refuted" the cosmological argument; he attacked the necessity of the regress-stop and the identification of the cause with God.

| EXAM OPENING: Ways 1-3 constitute the cosmological family; Way 4 is the henological / degrees argument; Way 5 is the teleological one, treated in Subtopic 4.

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+-- SESSION 04: THREE TELEOLOGIES THAT MUST NOT BE CONFUSED

| DEFINITION / TERMS : Its premise is that things which lack cognition nevertheless act for an end, and do so with regularity – which cannot be chance.

| MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: That chronological point is a genuine fact worth stating, because it forestalls the naive assumption that Hume was replying to Paley.

| CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The trap: Hume does not claim to prove that no designer exists.

| TRAP / ANSWER-USE: But the decisive difference: Western theists generally believe God is not only the cause of the unity/order of things but also the creative energy that gives existence to the things of Nature.

| EXAM OPENING: The inference is not weakened if I have never seen a watch made (as we have never seen a world other than this one) and therefore do not know from direct observation that watches are products of intelligence. The inference is not invalidated if the mechanism does not always work perfectly – as may appear to be the case with the mechanism of the world. The inference is not undermined if there are parts whose function we cannot discover – as there are in nature.

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+-- SESSION 05: KANT'S TWO-STOREY STRUCTURE

| DEFINITION / TERMS : Kant is the destroyer of the theistic proofs and the author of a moral argument, and he sees no contradiction because the two operate on different storeys.

| MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Kant is the destroyer of the theistic proofs and the author of a moral argument, and he sees no contradiction because the two operate on different storeys.

| CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Hick's objection: the basic assumption of all such arguments is that moral values are not capable of naturalistic explanation – in terms of human needs, desires, ideals, self-interest, or the structure of human nature or society.

| TRAP / ANSWER-USE: The whole examinable point is in the architecture, not the content.

| EXAM OPENING: Kant rejects speculative demonstrations of God while postulating God within practical

reason as a condition of the highest good.

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+-- SESSION 06: NYĀYA'S COSMIC DIVISION OF LABOUR

| DEFINITION / TERMS : Nyāya's God is the efficient, never the material, cause.
| MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Nyāya's God is the efficient, never the material, cause.
| CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: God is creator, preserver and destroyer – hence theism, not deism.
| TRAP / ANSWER-USE: God is the creator of the world in the sense of being the first efficient cause of the world and not its material cause – "a sort of demiurgus or a builder of the ordered universe". He is also the preserver, in so far as the world is kept in existence by the will of God, and the destroyer, who lets loose the forces of destruction when the exigencies of the moral world require it.
| EXAM OPENING: Nyāya's Īśvara is an eternal, omniscient, omnipotent special self, never bound by karma.

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+-- SESSION 07: TWO COMPLETELY DIFFERENT SENSES OF "GOD" IN THE INDIAN DEBATE

| DEFINITION / TERMS : Creator-denial must not be equated with denial of every religious ideal, because Jainism rejects a creator while affirming achieved godhead.
| MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: This is the single most important interpretive move in the entire subtopic.
| CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: UPSC's 2019 wording presupposes that Jainism has something to prove; the mature answer explains which sense of "God" Jainism proves and which it refutes.
| TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Creator-denial must not be equated with denial of every religious ideal, because Jainism rejects a creator while affirming achieved godhead.
| EXAM OPENING: Creator-denial must not be equated with denial of every religious ideal, because Jainism rejects a creator while affirming achieved godhead.

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+-- SESSION 08: PART I – JAINISM

| DEFINITION / TERMS : Jainism rejects a creator God but affirms liberated, omniscient souls as achieved godhead attained through self-effort.
| MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Jainism is "a religion without God" in the sense of a creator. There is no necessity of bringing in God to explain creation, for the world was never created: production, destruction and permanence characterise all substances; things have creation and dissolution because of their modes (paryāya), while the substances themselves are eternal.
| CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: "Though Jainism denies God, it does not deny godhead."
| TRAP / ANSWER-USE: In that Vedic sense Jainism and Buddhism are nāstika; but they are intensely spiritual and ethical, and denial of God does not amount to atheism in the Western sense – otherwise Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā, which likewise do not believe in a creator God, could not have been counted orthodox.
| EXAM OPENING: Jainism rejects a creator God but affirms liberated, omniscient souls as achieved godhead attained through self-effort.

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+-- SESSION 09: PART II – BUDDHISM

| DEFINITION / TERMS : Buddhism rejects a permanent creator and explains suffering through conditioned arising rather than divine production.
| MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change. If God creates from desire or purpose, that suggests lack, preference or incompleteness. The presence of suffering and evil sits uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator. Dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator unnecessary.
| CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: If God determines all, karma and moral effort are meaningless; if God does not determine all, God is not the sufficient cause and the theistic explanation is redundant. The Dharmakīrti / Śāntarakṣita line.
| TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Philosophical force, stated correctly: the Buddhist critique is not mere atheistic denial; it is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus.
| EXAM OPENING: Buddhism rejects a permanent creator and explains suffering through conditioned arising rather than divine production.

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+-- SESSION 10: PART III – MĪMĀṂSĀ

| DEFINITION / TERMS : The Veda is authoritative because it is apauruṣeya – eternal, authorless and self-valid.
| MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The Veda is authoritative because it is apauruṣeya – eternal, authorless and self-valid.
| CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: They also record Max Müller's contention that if God were supposed to be the creator, He would be liable to the charges of cruelty and partiality; and Müller's further point that rejection of a creator-God is not necessarily rejection of God, since pantheisms such as Advaita and Spinoza's do not accept the reality of creation and yet are not fairly called atheistic. Their own verdict is more sceptical: judged by what the Mīmāṃsā itself does and says, the Vedic deities are not treated as objects of worship and are not believed to exist anywhere except in the mantras that describe them – "eternal and self-manifesting concepts", like the immortal characters of classical epics. In its anxiety to maintain the supremacy of the Vedas, the Mīmāṃsā "relegates God to an ambiguous position".
| TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Prābhākara adds niyoga: the injunction itself creates obligation, so one ought to act because the Veda commands, not because a deity rewards.
| EXAM OPENING: Mīmāṃsā (school of inquiry into ritual duty) treats the Veda (sacred revealed knowledge) as authorless and karma (morally consequential action) as self-fructifying, thereby displacing the need for God.

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ANSWER-WRITING SPINE

definition -> exact terms -> mechanism/evidence -> consequence/contrast
-> objection/trap -> qualified answer-use